Grayskull's Anatomy

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/42634008.

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Explicit

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Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), there's a lot of people okay

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Angst, there's only one bed, they're all doctors, It's Grey's Anatomy but Gay, Human Catra (She-Ra)

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by ireallyshouldntbehere_

Summary

They just looked at each other for a moment before breaking into laughter, and the way Catra held out her hand to help Adora off the floor was almost too remnant of their shared past. There had been a few, small moments such as that over the last few weeks, but as quick as they came, they were gone again, and Adora prepared herself for the glaze that she knew would sweep over the eyes in front of her.

But to her surprise, they didn't.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

> Welcome to Grayskull's Anatomy, which is like Grey's Anatomy but everyone is gay and they don't cheat on each other.
>
> ọr the one where they're all gay , doctors, and have (mostly) healthy relationships.

‘And what did you expect to happen when I found out, huh? Did you really think I would just be jumping for joy at the thought of you leaving?’

‘But you can come with me!’ Her palm reached out, up and open.

‘Or we could both stay, just like we always planned. We can run this place someday, just you and me.’

‘We’re better than this place, you and I both know that. Come with me, please. We can start over, we can...we can be happy.’

She’d seen the wrath in those eyes directed at many before, but never at her. ‘I already was happy, Adora, but it’s clear now that you weren’t.’

‘That’s not what I meant-‘

‘Save it, you went and got this job behind my back, without even telling me. I thought we did everything together-‘

‘We do! I didn’t tell you because I-‘

‘Just go, I don’t want to hear your excuses anymore. Go be where you want to be.’

No! she tried to reach out, but nothing was there besides air and a pitch black room.

Adora rubbed her eyes and tried to fight the knots in her stomach from yet another nightmare; it was always the same one, and it never got easier. Sleep in general hadn't come easy to her in the last few years since she left Fright City, and she knew that the reason for it lay wrapped up in the long fingers of the woman who ceaselessly plagued her sleeping and conscious mind, but there wasn't anything she could do about it. She tried. It took one phone call a day, then a week, and then each month after she left to understand the message – Catra didn't want to hear from her again.

Adora wondered for so long when she had changed her number, had it been an hour after their fight? The next day? Did Catra regret it? But then again, it wouldn't be like her to regret anything, or show that she regretted it, and that pissed Adora off even more. She looked at her phone, saw the bleary clock that read white numbers far earlier than she hoped, and rolled out of bed. There wasn't a point in trying to get back to sleep, the memory of the last time she saw that wild hair and even wilder eyes wasn't one she wanted to replay again. She decided to get packed up for the gym, at least there she could work out some of her frustrations and clear her head a bit.

The dumbbells just weren't doing it for her that day , and if she were to be honest with herself, they hadn't helped in a while. Each rep burned, but her mind was on fire with an entire life of thoughts blazing a steady course between her ears, and the headache that was beginning to consume her was – frankly – annoying. There were only so many times she could stuff her face in her sweaty towel and groan. What the hell was she supposed to do? The thought of traveling back to her hometown had crossed her mind a few times, but she just couldn't bring herself to do it. The thought alone of seeing Catra again made her entire body flush cold with dread, not to mention–

Nope, she couldn't think of her . That was just another layer of knots her stomach couldn't handle.

Frustrated as ever, Adora racked up her weights and hopped on the manual treadmill, hoping that would help. Her head hung low as she jogged, thinking back to that fateful day where she had run into Glimmer and the chief at a cafe a town over from Fright. Leaving had never really been in Adora's head, but the amount of bad cases she had to sit and watch drove her to escape for a day, just needing to breathe. All she had done was ask for a coffee recommendation – she had never seen so many options before – and by the time she left the cafe, Adora had the chief's number and an interview date lined up.

She should have told Catra about it. She should have been open about the entire thing, and they could have done it as a team, just like always, but she didnt. She had kept it all from her , and for what?

For what?

"Fuck!" She gasped and jumped to the sides of the treadmill. Adora hadnt even noticed how fast she had been running, and watched her sweat drip onto the black strip below her as she panted.

"Fuck" –

She waited for the track to stop and jumped down from the platform with wobbly legs – so much for getting a distracting workout in. She grunted and grabbed her few items before showering quickly , rushing out with hardly a wave to the very nice front-desk person. She didnt know what she was going to do if the nightmares kept getting worse.

"Again?" Glimmer asked immediately when she pulled into her parking spot. "This is the third time this week."

"Dont remind me," she grunted and slung the duffle onto her back, desperately needing a different sort of distraction. "I'm the one dealing with them, you know."

"Is something coming up? Why do you think they're getting so bad?"

Adora rubbed her forehead and sighed. "I wish I knew , but I cant figure it out. I think maybe it's because Im getting upset that they're worse?" That didnt sound right, but she was trying. Glimmer looked thoughtful for a moment, and Adora used that break to look up at the building. *Bright Moon Memorial Hospital.* There were a lot of cars in the parking lot, more than normal, and she felt that maybe it would be busy enough for her to calm down.

"Maybe the universe is trying to tell you something?" Glimmer quipped.

"Yeah? Like what?" Adora asked with a scoff. She was used to the universe not really doing her any favors, but the amount of repeating nightmares were really starting to affect her already fucked up sleep schedule. Glimmer looked ready with another one of her 'insights,' but before either of them could say anything, there was a deafening roar as a motorcycle rode right between them, parking quickly before the rider clicked off the engine.

Were her blue scrubs not bright enough? "Honestly . "Who the fu-" Adora started, but stopped dead when she saw the license plate.

'Meow'

The cold sweat she had felt earlier was nothing compared to the bombs going off in every cell in her body. Adora's mind swirled and her ears went fuzzy as she heard Glimmer 's voice start to rise, but no words made sense. Could it be? There just wasnt – it couldnt be...

Black and red leathers clung tightly to the ass she knew like the back of her hand, and Adora watched – completely frozen – as the star of her endless nightmares dismounted her bike with that easy grace she always had. The helmet came off almost in slow motion, and it was like three years disappeared in an instant.

"Hey , Adora."

And oh good god that voice – it shook her to her very core, and there wasn't anything she could do but stare. Catra had cut her hair , and it was fucking *short.* She looked good. Damn good, and as much as she wanted to say something, words were entirely unable to form in her mouth.

"That was very dangerous, you know ," Glimmer shrilled, but her brain was too empty to process it. Catra merely laughed before running a hand through her short ass hair, a motion that enraptured Adora in ways the woman had always been able to do, and sauntered off towards the hospital.

Oh no. Oh no no no...why was she there, walking towards the hospital? The answer was obvious, but Adora couldn't wrap her head around the implications of it all. Her mind started to go into overdrive as she watched the perfect sway of that tight ass walk closer and closer towards what she had deemed home now for years. Was she?..

"Adora!"

It was the first time she had ever ignored Glimmer, but at the moment she couldn't care much about the consequences of that, her entire body was being summoned to follow the devil reincarnate to see where she went, though at this point Adora had a pretty good idea. She wondered when her brain had turned to sawdust, but it also had been so long since she felt that way, and only one person had ever been able to accomplish that feat.

With Glimmer hot on her heels, rapid firing questions she gave no answer to, Adora mindlessly threw her bag in her locker and headed to the nurses station for daily briefing. Bow was already there talking to Perfuma, and her skin was bubbling with a feeling she couldn't yet describe, so she found herself an empty wall to rest on. Just a few seconds was all she needed as she waited for Angella to give directions.

"What is going on with you?" Glimmer tried when she finally caught up but the Chief clapped her hands in that graceful way she did and everyone went silent.

"Good morning, everyone!" she said brightly. "Some of you may have noticed a few new people along the halls this morning, so allow me to introduce them to our team." Angella swept her hand back and in walked some people she recognized and some she didn't, but she only had eyes for one person. "Bright Moon Memorial agreed to absorb some of the employees from Horde General, and as such, I hope you can welcome everyone into their new respective teams and be patient while we all figure out this process together. Now, here are lists of new names and their departments—" but Adora stopped listening.

'-Gray'

What did she mean? What was going on at Horde Gen? Why were they absorbing anyone? Why was that incredibly buff woman sweeping Catra into a hug?

'-Gray'

"Aren't you excited, Wildcat?" When had Catra ever let anyone call her anything but her name? Adora eyed them carefully but tried not to be too obvious. "We're finally here!"

'-Gray!'

"Don't call me that when we're at work," Catra snipped quickly.

"Adora Grayskull!"

"What?" she jumped and turned to see Glimmer bright red. "What, Glimmer?" Was it not obvious that Adora was clearly distracted? What would be the point of yelling at her.

She heard a scoff. "Grayskull? What kind of name is that?"

"It's—why couldn't she speak?"—

"She picked it herself," Glimmer said proudly, forcing their attention on her, "and I'm Glimmer. I think we got off on the wrong foot this morning." She offered her hand out for Catra to shake, and to Adora's surprise, she did.

"Glitter, huh?" Blue and yellow eyes trailed her up and down in scrutiny. "You pick that one out too?" Catra asked flatly.

A very feisty hand planted itself on Glimmer's plump hip. "It's actually Glimmer."

"I genuinely could not care less." If she wasn't on the verge of spontaneous combustion, Adora might have laughed.

Glimmer huffed but took it in stride. "And what's your name? If we're going to be working together then I think we should try and be civil."

"It's somewhere on your list, Sparkles," Catra twiddled her fingers at the papers they all received, "I'm sure you'll find it if you look hard enough. So anyway," eyes fell on her again, "where'd Grayskull come from?" How was she so calm right now? Was Catra's mind not going numb with the thoughts of the last time they saw each other? Did she not care?

"Oh wonderful, I had hoped you would all meet," Angella swooped over. "Glimmer, Adora—this is Catra Weaver and her friend over there—she pointed to the buff woman from earlier, "—is-"

"I'm Scorpia, hi!" the woman leaped over and joined their group with a heavy wave. "It's nice to meet you all."

She could feel Glimmer's eyes on her instantly at the name, but Adora kept herself locked on Angella, she really couldn't deal with that look right now. She already knew how much she would have to explain later.

"Wonderful," Angella continued, "Adora is our Chief Resident here at Bright Moon Memorial, so if you or any of your new colleagues have any questions, she or Glimmer can help with whatever you need. Welcome aboard!"

She was surprised, really, that Glimmer waited long enough for her mother to be out of earshot. *"You're* Catra?"

Adora could have died, right then and there, she was sure of it. "What an astute observation, Confetti. I can't wait to see how you manage an OR." Adora couldn't help but look at her—Catra's voice had always been able to draw her in no matter what she was saying, and she found those devastating eyes already on her. "Chief Resident, huh? I guess you really can succeed if you don't have any *distractions,* isn't that right, Adora?"

Her throat was close to exploding—"Catra"…

If she had blinked, Adora might have missed the slight bobble in that tense, tan throat, and Catra crossed her arms. "Well this has been so much fun, but if you'll excuse me, I have to go do my job now."

Heat prickled at the edges of her eyes as Catra walked away, just as she had done many times, and her conscience screamed at her to follow. After all these years, they were in the same place again—she could apologize, she could run and take her arm and not let go until Catra heard her finally. She'd never force her to stay—but Catra was stubborn, and sometimes she needed a bit of a fight to get over her own evasive tendencies.

But Adora just stood there, frozen as ever—watching her sachet away in that mouth watering way she did.

This was so, so bad.

"That is Catra?" Glimmer's voice broke her out of her fog and Adora shook her head a bit to readjust. "You never told me she was so *hot."*

"Who's hot?" Bow asked.

"Nice of you to finally join us, you just missed Catra."

His jaw basically dropped to the floor and Adora wanted to roll her eyes. *"The* Catra? How could I miss this?"

She didn't know if she should run, or throw up, or perhaps go take a nap; there were so many feelings bombarding her that Adora didn't even realize she was shaking until dark hands were on her shoulders.

"Hey, come on, you need to eat," Bow cooed and slung his arm around her. "I bet you didn't have your post workout shake, did you?"

That thought alone made her laugh a bit, and Adora let herself be led off to the cafeteria. "Yeah, you're right, I forgot." *Because my mind was being blasted by the very person who had just walked down a different hall;* the person that had been the center of her dreams, nightmares, and living consciousness for over three years now. The person who, before all of that, had been the center of her life, and Adora had ruined it.

The shaking might subside, but what was she going to do?

—

Empty hall, empty hall, empty hall…

Catra repeated it over and over as she practically ran through the unfamiliar wards. It had been hard enough to dodge off Scorpia's excited hugs, but now as her breaths got shallower and everything was turning to static, she really needed to find somewhere.

Finally! The dingy janitor's closet would have to do, and Catra collapsed inside with a choked sob. It had been so long since she had a panic attack, but she should have known it would happen once

she saw her again. She choked on another breath of air and held back her tears as she curled into a ball on the floor.

Breathe in, four seconds, hold, four seconds, breathe out, four seconds, hold, four seconds. Repeat.

Repeat.

Repeat.

What would DT say right now if they knew Catra was panicking?

'Recognize that you're having an attack, Kitten.' Okay, that was easy. It wasnt everyday she found herself –willingly –on the floor of a porter's closet. *'Focus on your happy place, imagine it before your eyes. What is it like? Is it warm and sunny? Are there specific sounds or smells?'*

Deep breath in.stormy blue eyes that would to turn gray when angry.deep breath out.perfect blonde hair that hardly came out of a ponytail as much as she tried.deep breath in.a barking, cocky laugh.deep breath out.perpetually sweaty gym clothes that never, ever smelled bad.deep breath in… *Adora.*

She let that last breath out slowly and shook her head. Anywhere Adora was, was her happy place. It basically had been since the day Catra was dropped on Weaver's doorstep, and even though being in her presence once more was the exact reason she had found herself unable to breathe the last few minutes, Adora had always been her breath of fresh air.

And she despised it. She hated that even though Adora left, that she chose to go and she chose to leave her, that even in her deepest pits of rage, Catra couldnt even blame her .

Not when she knew everyone left her eventually.

But was it really them who left, or did she run them out before anyone was able to leave her? That's what she did with Adora, and every catastrophic failure of what someone *might* call a relationship therein after the day she left. It was so easy for her to run, really – both mentally and physically. Eventually she stopped trying, and turned into a mindless machine that went to work and did nothing else. It was what their adopted mother always wanted, but never wanted it from her–

"Stop it," she hissed at herself and squeezed her eyes close. Catra had spent too long getting short, off-the-books therapy sessions with Dr. Trouble, so aptly named, to just slip back into those thoughts. She ran through the checklist in her head once more, of all the things the Horde psychiatrist might say if they knew about her current predicament and location.

The one thing that Catra could in no way could have prepared for was just how gut wrenching it was to see Adora again, in all of her freshly showered, muscly glory; how gut wrenching it was to see her standing across the foyer in her scrubs, waiting for instruction, when they used to stand side by side. And oh *god* did she fill out those scrubs. Her mind was ravaged not only by remembering how beautiful Adora was, but also by seeing her again, in person, and not in her head. It was just that Catra knew nothing about her now; she watched that bedazzled screecher prance up as if she owned the air they all breathed and Catra wanted to rip off her stupid, sparkly name badge. But the whole scene had formed an even deeper pit in her stomach – was Adora even the same person anymore?

Did she sleep in a little ball again like she had done since they were kids? Once they started to sleep in the same bed, Adora had learned to relax, but did she fall back into her old patterns? Or had the freedom of living (potentially) alone finally given her the chance to spread out and lighten up entirely? *Was* she alone?

Was she? Catra felt sick at the thought and fought down the regret that bubbled up at even coming to work for this hospital. She had no choice to leave now, she was contracted to be there for the rest of

her residency, but could she handle seeing Adora be with anyone other than herself?

Oh get a fucking grip, Weav - no. Catra had finally left every bit of her and Adora's adoptive mother behind when she left Fright City; she needed to leave behind the one thing that had held her to her abusive roots, the one last part that held her close to Adora. But Adora changed her name too, didn't she? Did she not want to remember anything from their old life…did she not want to remember Catra? Of course that wasn't it, but the question of how quickly she changed everything itched at the back of her skull.

Catra wondered if Adora knew what happened to their mother, if that gorgeous, blonde idiot knew they were safe, after all this time. Blue eyes had looked so scared and confused earlier, Catra wondered if she knew what had happened at Horde that prompted her change, that changed everything. There was just so much to tell her…

The speech was already planned in her head, of why she didn't just take Adora's hand those years ago and leave with her, but her stupid pride reared its head.

Adora left. Why should she get any sort of explanation? It was Catra that should get something–

Her head dropped in exhaustion, it really was so hard to stay so mad all the time, but there were so many feelings coursing through her that it was the only action that felt right. Seeing Adora's shocked face was exactly what she had wanted, and Catra couldn't have asked for a better or more dramatic entrance than her stunt in the parking lot. She thrived on the shock factor, and Adora's face never disappointed her.

Oh, Adora.

Through all of her quick sessions, all of her mental preparation, Catra had imagined she would be a nervous wreck once she first saw her, but there had only been the deepest, most profound sense

of longing the moment she looked into those eyes. And if she allowed herself the possibility, it looked as though Adora missed her too. It felt good, and she felt herself cringe at admitting it, but a lot of her move to Bright Moon would be made worth it to know that the person who ripped her world apart felt the same way.

Catra balled her fist in anger at the thought of Adora hurting, at the thought of everything, and knew that they were eventually going to have to talk about things. She dreaded it.

She growled at herself again and stood up on shaky legs. God damn it, she wasnt going to sit there and have a pity party because of Adora, no. She’s a doctor, a certified bad bitch, and she needed to dust her coat off and start acting like it.

Or try to, at least.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer sat down with a resounding grunt and stole a chip from her plate;Adora could have swatted her hand away , but she had learned to choose her battles with the surprisingly vicious woman. Before she could ask what was wrong, Bow walked into the break room and stole his own chip before sitting down.

"I swear I don't know how Raz still has her job," Glimmer said before grabbing another chip, and this time Adora swatted her away and pulled her plate in. "Every time I go down there she has this wild story that doesn't even make sense and then I always get the wrong set of records!"

"I've told you a million times, if you actually listened to her , she makes sense," "no she doesn't, " "but you just need to tell her you're a friend of Mara. It works every time."

"Oooor maybe she should just learn to do her job better?"

She loved Glimmer, she truly did, but the girl just had a different view of life than Adora did, and sometimes it was grating the way she expected things to work like they do in textbooks. It was almost confusing sometimes, since being a doctor was all about preparing for the unexpected, but it was always something small and generally insignificant that Glimmer would get frustrated over.

"Anyway ," Adora deflected, "do you guys have anything good sched-" but before she could finish her question, the door to the break room burst open and in walked the tall buff girl, Scorpia if she remembered correctly, and of course, Catra. They hadn't run into each other much in the last few days, but each time she saw her, Adora's heart nearly burst out of her chest in a way that made her

sick. This time was no different, and she pushed her plate of food away slightly.

"Oops," Scorpia said awkwardly, "I have a habit of opening doors too quickly, I apologize if I interrupted or inconvenienced you folks in any way, it wasn't my-"

"I think they get the point, Scorpia." Catra glanced at all of them quickly and walked by to steal Adora's plate before sitting down on the couch.

"You can't just come in here and steal people's food!" Glimmer huffed.

Catra shrugged. "She wasn't eating it," her eyes came to rest too perfectly on her own, "were you, Adora?" Her entire body flushed at the sound of her name in that voice, the voice she missed beyond reason.

"No, I was finished," she said meekly and wanted to be anywhere but in that small break room at that moment.

"Wildcat here has always had such a big appetite for a little thing!" Scorpia said brightly and nudged the now glowering doctor, yet Catra didn't correct her again. "It must be all that brain power she needs for her surgeries. I haven't really had the chance to get to know many people yet, so how about you two," she looked between Glimmer and Adora, "do you have your specialties picked out yet?"

Adora wasn't paying attention, she just watched as Catra took a bite out of the bun she once had been working on, and her brain was short-circuiting from the entire situation. She wanted to talk to her, to say something, but each time she tried to pluck up the courage, Adora would turn away and make some other excuse for why not to. She watched Catra take another bite, wiping off a crumb at the corner of her spitfire mouth, and thought about what kind of game she was playing. Was she trying to rile Adora up? That was always such an easy thing for her to do, when she wanted, but it wasn't that.

Food had been an issue when they were growing up, Weaver used it as a tool for control, and they hadn't known much besides dry rations until they both got to college. They both knew that food wasn't to be wasted or messed around with. That was a lesson they would never unlearn.

Was Catra trying to get her to say something, to fight back and be territorial? She just didn't expect any of this, and therefore, had no idea how to react to anything Catra was doing – or was she even doing anything? The thing about the whole situation that was getting at her was that she knew Catra. She knew every microexpression, every tone variation when she spoke, every single movement – well, at least she used to. Things could very well have changed in the last three or so years, so there was always a possibility, but Catra wasn't so easily changed. It was all so confusing. Adora watched her finish off the chips, rub the tips of her fingers together to get rid of the crumbs, and maybe, just maybe, she was just eating.

She was still suspicious, but what else was she supposed to do?

"Adora?"

"What?" she said quickly and finally looked away from Catra to see everyone was looking at her. "What happened?"

"Scorpia was asking you two what you're specializing in," Bow said with a curious look. "Are you okay? You were zoned out pretty hard there."

She flicked her eyes over to Catra and regretted it, she could see the tiny hint of a smile on the edge of her mouth. "Right, sorry, I was just thinking of this surgery I had yesterday," no one looked like they were buying it but they were sweet enough not to say anything. Scorpia still looked expectant, and Adora cleared her unusually dry throat. "I'm doing orthopedics."

Catra's light little laugh made the hairs on the back of her neck stand up. "You're so predictable," she said with a short tilt of her head. "You

went with the jock specialty?"

Her mouth ran dry again at being the sole focus of those eyes, even though everyone else was looking at her, Adora had only one thing on her mind. "Yeah," she replied lamely and swallowed to wet her throat. "Cardio was just too stressful for me in the end."

Concern flashed over those mismatched eyes for a moment before Scorpia grabbed Catra's shoulder and shook her.

"You were going to do cardio, weren't you, Wildcat?"

She shook Scorpia's large hand off with a grunt. "No," she said quickly, "I thought about double-specializing once I finished with neuro."

"Oooooo-" Bow cooed and moved to the edge of his seat. "Those aren't even that related, why would you want to dual-specialize in such different areas?"

"Because I can, Arrow boy." To some it might have sounded like she was being a bitch, but there was a tinge of affection for him in her voice. Her stomach pitted at the thought of once having that affection directed towards her. "What else is there to do? I might as well do everything I can while I'm young."

"Are you not dating anyone?" Glimmer asked and Adora, once again, wanted to be anywhere but in that room. When she had talked to Glimbow about her reservations with Catra being there and their shared history, Adora hadn't imagined that Glimmer would ask such a direct question about the woman's dating life. What if she *was* dating someone? What would Adora even do in that instance?

"That is none of your concern, Sparkles."

"I wasn't trying to-" but Catra had popped out of her seat before Glimmer could even try and save herself, barely holding back from slamming the door on her way out. "I was just trying to make

conversation,”Glimmer said as she turned towards Adora, a sad look in her eyes.

She scratched at the itchy spot between her brows and sighed. “Catra has more walls up around her feelings than the borders of Dryl, don’t take it too personally.”

“You can say that again,”Scorpia said with a sweet laugh. “She’s my best bud and sometimes I feel like I know her, but I also don’t—oh, hey, Perfuma!”

Not that she didn’t like Perfuma, but Adora didn’t exactly want to hear about what plant-based pizza she brought for lunch again that day, and so she made a show of cleaning up her spot before leaving by herself. “It was nice talking to you, Scorpia. I’ll uh, see you around.”

Scorpia, who was somewhat buff and intimidating, was really so damn sweet, and to see her little blush as the trauma doctor sat next to her made Adora smile. The thought of the two of them getting together had her smiling all the way to the pre-op nurses station, where she nearly ran straight into Catra. Her back was turned away, so Adora took a moment to relax her cinched throat as she watched her flip through some charts lazily.

“Your little girlfriend should watch her mouth,”Catra drawled as she flipped another page. Adora felt frozen in place again, because she had forgotten that Catra always seemed to be able to tell who was around her without even looking. With her short hair, Adora could see her ears move minutely. She blinked out of her daze and stepped up next to her.

Words. She could do words. “Glimmer isn’t my girlfriend. I’m not dating anyone.”

Catra scoffed and the lines of her throat called out to her. “Well she looks at you as if you hung the stars.”

"She' s also married to Bow, so"…

It was just the two of them, and a nurse who paid them no mind, but Adora wondered how quickly a crash team could get there because her heart stopped entirely when Catra finally looked at her, pupils dilating a fraction.

"W ell they could be poly for all I know."With the slightest shrug of her shoulders, Catra turned back to her charts she had been looking through. Was it really only Adora going through this panic alone at seeing her again? How was she being so calm?

"W ell Im not,"she said finally and watched eyes flicker over to her for a second. "They're just trying to be friends with you, you know? No one here is out to get you."

"I'm not here to make friends."

"Then what are you here for?"

Catra snapped the binder closed and gave her an unimpressed stare. "I'm here to do my job. I dont need friends, Adora."She stepped in close and the air left her lungs. "They're just a *distraction,* remember?"

Her knees trembled as blue and gold eyes seared over her face. Of course the one thing Catra would bring up would be the very pick in her heart of their upbringing.

"Catra-"she tried but Catra' s pager decided at that very moment to blare.

"So this has been thrilling, Im going to go save lives now ."She threw the binder back onto the desk, earning a deep look of disdain from the nurse, and Adora watched her walk away until she was out of eyesight.

"W ell, she's kind of a bitch."

She frowned and turned to the nurse who had been there the whole time. "Catra is a very specific type of person."

"Yeah," he said, "a know-it-all bitch. Don't make excuses for people who are rude for no reason."

Adora looked back down the hall where Catra had disappeared from and sighed. She wasn't making excuses for her, because there wasn't an excuse to be made for someone like Catra. Yeah she had her tendencies to be rather...blunt, but she knew the real woman beneath that damn near evil stare.

Or at least, she used to.

–

'No, dummy, you have to subtract the 17 from both sides to find "x," not divide. You only divide when the coefficient is attached to the variable.'

'Ugh, Catra, I'm never going to get this!'

'That's not true, you just have to try harder.'

'You don't have to try hard, you understand algebra better than anyone!'

She felt her cheeks flush, and Catra pushed Adora's face away with a laugh. 'That's true, but I'm not as good as you at ancient history. That stuff puts me to sleep.'

'But it's so interesting! Like, did you know that there was this civilization called the "First Ones," and they thought we came from this galaxy called Desp–'

'Adora, you need to get ready for soccer practice.' She scowled at Weaver who paid her no mind, and moved to get up from the kitchen

table with Adora, but nails dug into her shoulder. 'You, stay.'

'But I have to get ready for gymnastics.' Which wasn't entirely true, since her practice was an hour after Adora's, but she hated being alone with Weaver.

'Can Catra come to practice with me today? Our goalie broke her arm and'–

'Adora, go.'

They shared a look before Adora turned to leave the dining room, and nails dug deeper into her shoulder. 'What was that nonsense she was talking about, what have you been filling her head with?'

'Me?' Catra cried. 'I was helping her with math! She was telling me about her history lesson!'

'I'm tired of your lies, Catra. You are distracting her, and if this continues, I'll have to make sure you don't practice your lessons together.'

'That's insane, we share a tutor.'

Weaver removed her hand and flattened out Catra's shirt. 'Well, I don't see a need for you to be in school anyway, you aren't going to do anything with your life. Catra, look at you-'

Waking up with a stomach full of knots was her least favorite way to wake up, but she had come to terms with it by then. It had been a while since she had a Weaver dream, and Catra couldnt decide if she hated those, or the dreams of Adora leaving, more.

At least Adora was pretty, so she was easier to look at. Weaver tried to be pretty, but none of her plastic surgery could ever cover up the raging cunt that was buried within her fake, botox-pumped skin.

As she started her pot of coffee, Catra could feel herself smile just a bit at the subtle change over the last couple of weeks. Back in Fright,

if she had a dream such as that one, her day would snowball from bad to worse. No one at Horde cared about each other, if you had a bad day, that was your problem. If you had a bad attitude, you didn't get surgeries, so Catra learned to bottle it all up.

Not at Bright Moon. Everyone was almost unreasonably nice, the attendings and charge nurses always checked in with the interns and residents. Even the shiny little goblin that followed Adora around like a love-sick puppy was still sort of nice, even if she had recently been extra pissy, but it was still better than Horde. It had been a lot to take in at first, and it still was, but at least she knew that when she walked through the doors, she was walking into a new place. A place that had never been tainted by the hands of her adoptive mother.

A place that was graced by Adora.

They hardly talked, mostly when forced to by their mutual friends, and it usually ended with Catra getting pissed at the reminder that Adora left.

Her stomach knotted slightly again, but she sipped her coffee and closed her eyes for a moment. Three years was a long time to be away, and their situation wasnt going to be fixed so soon, so she needed to be patient with herself. Patience wasnt her strong suit, but what else could she do?

At least it was expected, their encounters, and Catra got ready for her shift as she thought of what sort of emotions she might get out of the blonde idiot the next time they worked together. But she had a big surgery with the chief that day, so Adora would have to wait.

It was her third surgery with Angella, and as Catra watched her edge the line of the arachnoid membrane, making her way with utmost precision to the intramedullary tumor that had placed itself in the spinal cord of their patient, she wondered how Glimmer had come out of her.

"So have you thought of a last name yet?" Angella asked, breaking the serene silence that had fallen upon the tense room. She blinked and suddenly all the machines were beeping again, and more than one person now had their eyes on her instead of the man they had splayed open on the table. It was going to take her some time to get used to the fact that no one got yelled at here for conversing during a surgery.

She trusted her attending to know what she was doing, but it was a bit daunting still.

"Uhh, no," she replied and stretched out her shoulders. This was going to be a long surgery. "It's just not really a priority to me right now." Catra had been surprised when everyone respected that she wanted to use Dr. C' instead of her prior name, but there were far more important things to think about. And only ways to rile up Adora.

"A name change, huh?" Dr. Shera – the ortho attending – seemed nice enough, but just as jocky as Adora, which honestly made a lot of sense, but this was the first time that Catra had been in surgery with her. "Didn't Adora choose hers pretty quick, Ang?"

She didn't hear the reply as her ears swam. Catra pulled back her suction and handed it to a nurse, needing to catch her breath from the stupid, stupid rush of feelings. Had Adora really been that eager to change everything? To just leave her old world, her old life behind? To leave to... leave h–

"So I think it was less that she found a name she liked and more that Glimmer just bugged her enough that Adora chose a name to get her off her back."

Hearing Angella's words brought her back, and Catra took a deep breath before stepping forward and moving back to her spot. No distractions, she couldn't let life get in the way of doing her job, and she leaned back in to watch her chief of surgery cut into the spinal column of their patient, exposing the tumor that was going to be a bitch to cut out.

"A little suction here, Dr . C."It was still even hard to understand that direction was not an admonishment at Bright Mon. "Y ou dont have to rush on a name,"Angella of fered in a serene, hushed voice. "Y ou dont even have to change it at all if you dont want to. I didnt know her, nor do I claim to understand what you and Adora went through, but you can be anyone you want to be here, Catra."The pause allowed for her to center around the words and live in the sterile moment. "As long as you show up, every day , and be the surgeon I know you can be, youll make a name for yourself no matter what. Do you understand me?"

Catra blinked a few times before nodding, but the words circled around her head over and over again. She had only ever known to fight for her position in class, on teams, and in the OR. Her subconscious scraped at the base of her neck, screaming that she wasnt good enough, and that Angella was lying. How could someone who barely knew her be so sure she would succeed?

"Are you ready to switch?"

Angella had cleared out as much room as she could to expose the majority of the tumor and Catra looked up to see who she was talking to.

"What do you mean?"Why was she looking at her?

"Y oure going to remove the tumor , Dr. C."

Her body flushed cold. "Butyoure the attending, and this is an incredibly risky procedure."

Angella just smiled and stepped away from her spot. "This is a teaching hospital, my dear, and I plan to teach you. I am right here to direct if I feel as though you are misstepping, but I am confident that you can do this."

She looked over at Dr. Shera, who just nodded, and then over to the anesthesiologist, who was wrapped in blankets and flipping through

a boating magazine.

'you aren't going to do anything with your life.' Weaver's words played through her head, but this time, Catra smiled. Weaver was wrong. "Okay , let's do this."They switched sides of the table and Catra closed her eyes, letting each beep of a different machine hone her into the present, and she nodded once to herself. *You're a boss ass bitch, start acting like it.*

"Are you okay?"Angella asked as they washed up post-op, and it was only then that Catra realized she was shaking.

"W ell, I thought I was?"

"It happens after your first few big surgeries, and hopefully youll get used to the shock of it before doing your first solo."Catra didnt say anything and just kept washing her hands, trying to quell the shake of them. It was going to take time getting used to how...caring everyone was here. It was so hard to believe that no one wanted anything from her besides just getting her job done properly . "Come on, let's go get you some food. That was a really long surgery and you deserve it."

Thankfully Angella didnt force her to sit down and chat, because Catra was already so overwhelmed with everything that had transpired that day, she really just wanted to find an empty room somewhere and eat alone with her thoughts. Her bagel was getting cold by the time she made her way down to a dank and empty hallway near the morgue, but it was silent and dark;a perfect escape from the beating lights of the OR.

'They're just trying to be friends with you, you know? No one here is out to get you.' She closed her eyes and let the words play over and over in her head, feeling the bumps rise on her skin at the sound of Adora's voice talking to her - just for her . *'No one is out here to get you-'* was something that she was going to have to work on, and she

knew that. She really did. Catra didnt even mean to snap at Adora the way she had, but it was just so much easier for her to be mad, or to lash out instead of work through her feelings. Things were just...so unknown to her right now;though she had to admit her relief that Sparkles and Arrow boy were hitched, even if there seemed to be a little too much adoration in the little Gumdrop's eyes when she looked at Adora, but that might just be her jealousy talking.

Catra huffed and ripped off a piece of her bagel. Adora wasnt hers to be jealous over anymore, she had lost that chance when she chose not to go.

Her stomach lurched and she shoved the remnants away before bringing her knees up to her chest. Her panic attacks had lessened since that first day, even though when she thought on it too long they came back, though not as fierce as that first one. As much as she just wanted to grab Adora and pull her into a room, to yell and scream and hash it out, the petty asshole in her wanted that blonde, perfect idiot to try first. She could see Adora's hesitancy, of course she could. She could feel it in the air how her words would falter and the way her hand would almost reach out – *almost*. What she wouldnt give to just open her own palm, to feel the press of her thumb on her wrist.

Down there in that hardly lit hallway, that's where Catra would allow herself to shed a few tears for the years lost seeing those eyes fall on her the way they still do;for the years she could have spent getting food with Adora when she was shaking after an intense surgery and not Angella;for the years and knowledge lost of the person she had once known everything about.

She knew time couldnt be changed, and it was something she was working on, but maybe one day they could get back to a point where they could learn and grow together again. She wasnt ready for that yet, not at all, but it was the reason she was here now. And Catra needed to remind herself of that. A lot.

Chapter End Notes

Angella is both chief surgeon and chief mother to everyone, change my mind.

Also you all have no clue how much fun I've had writing this, and how long it's itched at the back of my head. I hope you like it.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra wished, sometimes, that her new favorite hallway was a little closer to the surgery ward, because having to sit there and listen to idiot interns figure out what was wrong with their patient was starting to drive her nuts. There was no way she had been that blind when she was a new resident, right?

"So at first she was in here for headaches and dizziness right? With some slight breathing issues, but then all of a sudden she starts clotting."

"How old is she?"

"35, with no recent surgery or anything, so there really wasn't a reason she should be clotting." Catra rolled her eyes and sipped at the dregs of her coffee. What were their names? Blue and Jewel? Who names their kid that anyway. I suggested Sjögren's syndrome, and Dr. Hope just stared at me."

"Yeah she's pretty frightening."

He listed off numerous symptoms and she could feel her eyes start to roll further back with each passing issue. "So I tried to look up other things, and the patient started complaining of joint pain, so fibromyalgia seemed to be the next best option, but apparently not! I went in to check on her this morning and she started seizing, so it's back to square one for me." He laid his head down in defeat and Catra clicked her tongue once.

"It's lupus."

He jerked up with scorn. "People always think it's lupus, but it never is."

"Well this time it is. Don't kill your patient because you're too proud to extend your range of possibilities."

"Well," he paused, "I don't want to look like an idiot for giving an answer that seems so simple, you know?"

"Have you ever heard of Occam's Razor?" She knew that answer, because no one can get past general biology without it being hammered into their skull. "I can guarantee you will be more of an idiot if you try and look everywhere else but what's in front of you. Sometimes it really is the easy answer." It looked like their eyes were glazing over, why was she even bothering? "It's lupus. Go recheck her WBC/RBC/platelets, get kidney and liver assessments, erythrocyte sedimentation rate, and an ANA."

They both just gawked at her. "Are you in rheumatology?"

She stood up and brushed the crumbs off her coat. "No, I'm a neurosurgeon. I just actually paid attention in med school." The two of them looked at her in a mixture of fear and awe, which felt oddly… good? Bright Moon Memorial was a teaching hospital, right? Catra would have her own set of interns to teach next year, and as much as she hated to admit it, she was trying to get better at being nice, so maybe these little bits would help her with that.

She shivered slightly, knowing that she had really come a long way with people in general since she was younger, but it still was a little odd. Her teen years were a long time ago, everything that had happened was far in the past, but the feelings still remained. This hospital though, and all of the people who were so helpful compared to the war games that went on at Horde General, just made her feel that much better.

Catra made her way down the halls with a small smile, far away from incompetent interns, but she was still excited. She finally had gotten

around to scheduling hours in the skills lab, which she didn't even know had existed until she overheard Adora mentioning it a few days prior. Horde didn't have as advanced equipment as Bright Moon in general, but they definitely didn't have a skills lab, only a set of silicon suture blocks that were about eighty years old.

The room was big, and quiet, and Catra didn't even know where to start. There were suture sets, IV lines, external and internal fixation kits, bone saws, surgical robots she had never even seen... she was a kid in a candy store. A very expensive candy store, as that room alone probably cost more than she would ever make in her life, but it was hard to not be excited over the spanking-new skills kits.

She jumped at the sound of the door banging open, and she turned to see a woman with huge, purple goggles, long, pink hair, and a cart full of boxes and wires. "Oh, hi. I didn't think anyone was going to be in here."

The woman stopped her muttering about something and flipped open her goggles. "I maintain the equipment here, I am not a doctor. Please ignore me, I shouldn't bother your focus."

She watched her push the cart around, mumbling to herself more, and Catra just shrugged, deciding to check out one of the robots Angella told her about. It wasn't distracting by any means, but the woman really was quite loud as she banged tools around, and Catra stopped a few times to watch her. Most other people she encountered in the hospital had been so eager to strike up a conversation, or had always been friendly, but this woman couldn't seem to care less about that. Catra decided she needed to know her.

"I'm Catra, by the way," she said once the woman was closer to her.

She put a hand on the robot Catra had been using and flipped her goggles up again. "That's a funny name. This is Darla, she's my newest addition to the robots."

"You name the robots?" Catra asked, ignoring the light snub of her name.

"Yes, they all are unique and deserve to be treated as such."

She caught a quick glimpse of the woman's badge. *Entrapta.* Who the hell was she to say Catra's name was funny? She just shook her head and got back to work, spending far longer than she anticipated playing with all the gadgets, and hadn't even noticed that Entrapta left by the time her alarm went off. She booked a few more hours for her next shift before leaving and heading back to the nurses station, wondering how many surgeons were allowed in there at one time. Would she maybe "accidentally" book the same hours as Adora…

Catra came upon the surgery board and reigned in her sigh, knowing that Adora wasn't there that day, so she wouldn't get the chance of seeing that stupid blonde ponytail whipping around the halls. She wondered, as her eyes perused the board, what Adora did on her days off. Was she seeing someone? No, she said she wasn't, but the thought of it still made the hairs on the back of her neck stand up. Did she just sleep all day to recuperate? That didn't sound like Adora, she never knew how to relax, so she was probably just at the gym or something like the buff idiot she was.

"I have surgery with *you?"* Glimmer's pitchy little voice broke her out of her sweaty-Adora daydream and Catra's head snapped towards her, then back at the board.

"What?" she practically cried and looked quickly down the list. She had checked for any neuro's, neglecting any other specialty, and had completely missed it. *"Why?"* She glared at it, the infernal bold lettering:

Herniorrhaphy: SEGS - Attd: Aura,S.Res: Cor ,G. Weaver,C.

"Because-" she heard firmly behind her, she and Glimmer both spun around to see Angella looking completely serene as usual, "while

you are on the track for neuro, you are still a surgical resident and, therefore, still have to practice the other specialties until you take your boards."

She understood that, somewhat begrudgingly, but did it have to be with Sparkles? They were so very , very incompatible. Glimmer had tried being friendly, but that had quickly dissipated into general seething when they were near each other.

"But, Chief," Glimmer said and side-eyed Catra. They must be thinking the exact same thing and oh goody, at least they could agree on their mutual dislike of one another. "Why would we bother teaching someone who wants neuro how to do a strangulated hernia repair? Spinny and I have done so many of those already , we would just be wasting time"…

"What makes you think I don't know how to repair a hernia?"

Watching her little face get red was fun, at least. "I never said you didn't, but it may have been a while since you have done anything in general, so I"–

"So you just assumed that, because I'm from Horde, I don't know my shit?" She had to give it to Glimmer , really. She might have looked tiny and sweet, but Catra could feel the heat radiating off her head once she started to get angry.

"I didn't mean it like that."

"Dr . Cor that is enough," Angella said in that firm voice once more. "Spinnerella asked for Catra personally , and my decision is final. We give everyone here a chance to learn as much as they can before they branch, and now you both have a surgery in thirty minutes to prep for." She gestured them away with some flicks of her hand. "Oh and Glimmer? No violence."

"So what' s the story on the ho violence?" she asked once they were getting scrubbed in. Catra wasn't thrilled at the idea of working with Glimmer, but she couldn't avoid it. "Silent treatment? Okay , I can handle that." Dr . Aura chose to walk in then and Glimmer nodded at her once before walking through the sliders into the OR. "Does she just stop talking before a surgery or something?"

"Glimmer?" She asked curiously , "not at all, actually . She usually spouts the whole rundown of what we're about to do. Maybe she plans to let you do that?"

Catra just gave a noncommittal grunt and left to get gowned up, coming close enough to their patient but didn't want to invade Sparky's personal space.

Spinneralla checked to make sure that their patient was properly sterilized and moved to her side of the table. "Alright, let' s do this!" She let Glimmer make the incision and there was a bit of awkward silence while she worked through the skin. "Now Catra, how do you like it here so far?"

what? As in this OR? Because I've been in here a few times-"

"No no," she said and nodded as they made it through a few layers of fat, "I meant here in Bright Moon. It seems that everyone else has gotten to talk to you and- we need a little suction there," she pointed, "thank you. As I was saying, I haven't had a chance to talk to you so I figured that you can't get away if we are in a surgery together ."

Was she serious? Oh, well, I think you could have found some other way instead of having me watch this?"

"Y eah, honestly."

They both looked at Glimmer, who was cutting through the peritoneum of the abdomen, and Spinnerella just shook her head. "W ell you didn't have any other surgeries lined up so I thought it wouldn't be a bad thing to educate you, don't you think?"

"W ell," she said, "I've done plenty of hernia repairs before, and I thank you for the opportunity, but I think I'm really just in the way here." Glimmer scof fed and mumbled something. "What was that?"

"I said that I can't imagine they taught you well at Horde."

"Dr . Cor don't be so brash," the attending stated with a small chuckle, "Adora came to us from Horde and she' s one of the best ortho residents we've seen in years."

Glimmer tutted. "She was an outlier , that's for sure."

Catra wondered how many sparkles would dull on that shiny head of hers if Glimmer knew how many tests she beat Adora on, but was cut off by Spinnerlla. "W ell Angella can't seem to say enough nice things about Dr. C, so—what happened?" Glimmer had flinched at the sound of her mother's name and pulled the scalpel out quickly .

"Shit-" she gasped, "I- I don't know what happened-"

"Y ou stabbed her bowel is what happened!" Catra looked to their attending to wait for direction, but they were going to have to move fast.

"Spin, I'm sorry-"

"T rade places with Dr. C."

"But-"

"Now!" she said roughly , and Glimmer put her blade and forceps down on the plate. Catra switched spots and grabbed a new pair of forceps. "Y ou're lucky that it was only a tiny perforation, Dr . Cor. I haven't seen you make a mistake that rudimentary in years." The whole room went silent, except for the calm beeping, while Dr. Aura cleaned and patched up the small cut Glimmer had made. "Now Catra, tell me how you were taught to repair an incarcerated and strangulated hernia"…

Catra had to admit that while she found general surgery rather boring, Spinnerella was both an amazing surgeon, and a lot of fun. She didn't hold any room for laziness in her OR, but her gentle and steadfast demeanor was altogether appealing. Would she want to catch up about the week with the doctor during another hernia repair or possibly an appendectomy? No, not at all, but she would make it a point to perhaps sit at the table with Spinny and her wife next time she saw them in the cafeteria together.

She stopped dead when she rounded a corner and saw Glimmer leaned against a wall, looking frustrated and spent. Catra hadn't been spotted, and it would be so easy to back away and let her be, but something compelled her to move forward, to *try* and be nice.

"Hey , are you okay, Sparkles?" Glimmer whipped around and glared at her, which she took in stride. "We all make mist–"

"I don't need you to console me, Horde scum. I don't even know why you were in there. If you had stayed in your lane, none of that would have happened. Everyone thinks you're this golden child but you don't have me fooled one bit."

"I'm not trying to do anything but be nice," she said, swallowing the rejected feeling. "I'm not great with people."

"Just leave me alone," Glimmer said and wiped her eyes before walking off, leaving Catra just standing there, not knowing why she even tried.

'They're just trying to be friends with you, you know?' Adora's words ran through her mind and she scoffed at the thought of them. Yeah, sure. Maybe Bow did, because arrow boy was a saint, and nice to everyone and everything he met, but Glimmer had some spice in her. Maybe the 'no violence' thing did have a little more to it than she thought; being scolded and embarrassed in the OR wasn't unknown to her, so maybe Glimmer was just having a bad day ...

Catra understood that. She had had a bad life, so she knew all about the bad days.

It didn't make any of it easier when all she wanted to do was yell back and kick something, but where would that get her?

–

It wasn't her normal hours going to the gym, and in fact seeing just how many people were there when she walked in almost made Adora spin around on her heel, but she needed this right now. She made a beeline for the back room and hoped to all the stars that there was an empty bag for her. Thankfully the entire room was dark and vacant, which gave her a few seconds to center herself while she wrapped her hands up.

There had hardly been any time lately to actually go through her normal motions, and with how weird everything had been, Adora let herself sigh into her stretches. Work was busier than ever for some reason, Glimmer was on this new kick of having game nights which was too hard to say no to, and really..the majority of her issues were with that demon of a woman who acted like she owned the hospital and every building in a 50 mile radius.

Catra's attitude was mainly a front, and Adora knew that, but she couldn't help but watch in awe at the easy grace in which she sauntered around the hospital. The only person who seemed to be allowed in Catra's personal space was Scorpia, and even then, it might have been just because the buff woman was rather oblivious to some of the comments that were directed towards her. When she and Catra did interact with one another, it had been civil enough, almost *nice,* and Adora had just let herself live in the thought that maybe, just maybe, they could get to a point where they could be okay.

It wasn't exactly what she wanted, at all, because she would always hold the feelings she had for the woman within her, but Adora would just have to learn to live with the consequences of her actions. It was

her fault - she had left - and Catra had every right to be mad at her, to not want to recover any semblance of what they had before. For now, maybe they could just keep whatever silent agreement they had, where Catra would come and steal the last of Adora's food, then laugh at the indignant grunt Glimmer always gave her.

Adora smiled and hopped up off the floor to begin her workout, the stress in her body basically tangible in the soreness of tired muscles. Work had been nothing if not relentless lately, which was probably due to the fact that being a fourth year resident was far more intense than years prior, but Adora just had been slammed with rough patients in the last few weeks.

She huffed and slid her feet across the mat, switching up hits and feeling her muscles relax with each slap of skin across the leather bag, letting herself be thankful that she was even able to do the motion at all. Her patient from the morning had been one that she knew would stay with her for a while: a woman, a few years younger than herself, was crushed under the weight of a vehicle after the hydraulics of the lift failed. They didnt know how long she had been beneath the vehicle, so once she got to the hospital, it was so hard to stop her internal bleedings...she had never seen such a crush injury. Adora was sure they were close to losing her a few times as Mira packed her pelvis, but they got the patient stable eventually. Adora was even able to be the one to place her external fixators, something she had been dreaming of doing, but there was just so much more work to be done.

It had been somewhat of a ritual for her once she moved to Bright Moon, going to the gym and using the means of working out to help center herself. Before then, she and Catra would do that together, but she learned how to function solo eventually. In lieu of a partner to help throw her on the mat, Adora would just slip on her headphones and dissect every piece of information she would need for the days coming up, especially once she was allowed to be a consistent part of surgeries. For her morning patient specifically, she was actually

pretty excited about it;they would be going back in in a few days to set her pelvis with plates, which Mara had told her that–

"Hey , Adora." Even over her music, she could hear the velvety purr of that voice, and Adora spun around too quickly , tangling her legs together, and falling straight on the mats. "How' s it hangin'?

"Catra"—was all she could spit out and ripped of f her headphones. "What are you doing here"?

The woman in question placed a hand on her hip and smirked. "W ell I was trying to find the knitting convention, but I saw this place and decided sweating would be way more fun."

Adora did a quick once-over of Catra's clothing and thanked every star that her cheeks were already red from her workout. "Y ou knit in *that?"* She asked.

"Knitting is serious business, Adora."

They just looked at each other for a moment before breaking into laughter, and the way Catra held out her hand to help Adora off the floor was almost too remnant of their shared past. There had been a few, small moments such as that over the last few weeks, but as quick as they came, they were gone again, and Adora prepared herself for the glaze that she knew would sweep over the eyes in front of her.

But to her surprise, they didn't. "Do you have a little energy left in you"? Catra asked. "I haven't been able to find someone who could really give me a run for my money lately. I swear I've hardly broken a sweat."

"W ell aren't you cocky"? Classic Catra, always so bold, but it wasn't as if her claims were false - she might be gentle in the OR, but that small frame had never been a deterrent from helping people slam their face into the mats. Her championship medallions from wrestling when they were teenagers was a testament to that. A challenging

smirk playing on soft lips had Adora answering before her head could catch up. "You're on."

"I was hoping you'd say that."

"How did you know I was here?" Adora quipped as Catra took the tape from her bag and started to wrap her hands. "Have you been following me?"

Catra scoffed, not even giving her the benefit of a glance. "Now who's the cocky one?" She mused. "Bright Moon isn't a huge place, you know. There are only so many gym options, and this one looked like a good place for a blonde meathead to hang out. Like I said, I was hoping for an actual challenge."

Adora nodded and watched silently, slightly taken aback by the use of an old moniker.

"So why did you come here then?" She asked before she could shut her mouth, "to Bright Moon? Why leave such a busy place like Fright to come here?" Catra surprisingly chuckled at her word vomit, and just stretched out her neck before taking her stance.

"Wouldn't you like to know, Princess?" She shook out her arms and raised them. "Now are we going to do this or what?"

They circled one another for a few turns, the air thick but familiar in the way that they both recognized but didn't dare mention, and Adora braced for the attack she knew was about to come when a small snarl curled on Catra's lips.

Classic.

Adora easily dodged the quick jabs, her muscle memory of their movements aiding her tired body, and she got momentarily distracted with the way Catra's short hair bounced with her movements. She let out a small huff as a firm fist hit her shoulder, but righted before one aimed for her head. The little shit. She was

going to have to change her tactics, because the fiery joy that was crawling into those mismatched eyes was going to make her wind up with her back on the mat. Adora shook out her head, then dodged a mean hook that would have probably ruptured her spleen.

"I see you haven't worked on your poker face," she laughed as she parried a few more rapid jabs, and landed a left hook to Catra's unprotected rib cage. "Your dodges are a little rusty too."

Catra just grunted and let out a fury of hits that, with how tired Adora was, started to land.

"You're going to waste all your momentum that way," Adora bantered once the punching ceased, and they circled one another again, Catra huffing and determined. "Eventually you won't have the energy to dodge me."

"What is this? Boxing for beginners?" Catra asked in a breath before swinging hard at Adora's head, which she took as the time to duck and slam bodily into her opponent.

She held tight as Catra grunted and tried to heave her way out of the hold. "Are you distracted, Catra? You haven't made a mistake that juvenile in-"

"God, can you shut up already?" A foot hooked her ankle and the next thing she knew, Adora had the wind knocked out of her as her back slammed to the mat. "You make new friends with Glitter Gumdrop and her shadow boy and suddenly you're all chatty during a match?" Catra didn't wait for a reply before locking her in an arm bar, which she begrudgingly tapped out of.

Well that didn't go as planned.

Neither of them talked as Catra helped Adora off the ground, grabbed her bag, and left without even unwrapping her hands.

Chapter End Notes

I need to give a quick shout out to my wonderful friend/kind-of-beta/idea giver @BlueEyesAndHair for helping me see my fuckups and also give me ideas for this monster of a fic. I've been dreaming of writing something like this for so long now, and I ignored a LOT of schoolwork for it, so I hope y'all enjoy.

Medical stuff!
-Lupus: (via the CDC) lupus is an autoimmune disease in which the immune system attacks its own tissues, causing widespread inflammation and tissue damage in the affected organs. It can affect the joints, skin, brain, lungs, kidneys, and blood vessels.
-Incarcerated and strangulated hernia: (via Alberta health) An incarcerated hernia is a part of the intestine or abdominal tissue that becomes trapped in the sac of a hernia~~the~~ bulge of soft tissue that pushes through a weak spot in the abdominal wall. If part of the intestine is trapped, stool may not be able to pass through the intestine. An incarcerated hernia can become strangulated, which is life-threatening if not treated immediately since it can cause necrosis (death) of the tissue. I've had two of these, they aren't fun.

Also since Bow can't wear crop tops at the hospital, my headcanon is that he has a bow and arrow tattoo on his arm. They all have tattoos. It's a thing, I like tattoos. I'll tell you when it's relevant.

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

Hi, I'm ireallyshouldntbehere and I like to drop 6.5k chapters. Have fun.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

‘I’m just saying, these general education classes are just a waste of time. Why would I ever need “Advanced Literature” when I’m a surgeon?’

‘Because you need to know how to write a research paper.’

‘I already know how.’

‘Yeah, well people aren’t as smart as you and actually need to learn.’ She itched at her head, her ponytail was starting to give her a headache, which usually meant it was time for a haircut.

‘That’s their problem, not mine. I should be able to test out of it or something…’ Catra flopped down on the couch and sighed.

Adora ignored her sigh and leaned further into her book. She had her strengths, such as chemistry, but unlike Catra, she struggled with writing. She was just so particular that she overanalyzed every sentence. It was getting late, she was tired, and Adora’s head was just getting worse. She pulled her ponytail out and ran her hands through her hair, deflated.

‘Headache?’

‘Yeah…I think I need a haircut.’

‘Why don’t you ever leave it down?’ Catra sat up. ‘Your hair is so pretty.’

The back of her neck and ears felt hot, which had been happening more and more lately. 'I…it's…' she just stopped trying, and Catra smiled as she got off the couch.

'Can I braid it?'

'Why?'

'Why not?'

She didn't have an answer to that, and Adora didn't exactly trust her mouth anyway.

Catra brushed through her hair a few times with her hands before starting, and Adora tried so hard to suppress the shivers that ran up her spine at the feeling. The drag and pull of each strand was turning her into jelly.

'Adora?'

'Hmmm?'

'Did you not hear me?'

'...no?'

'Idiot.' She could hear the smile. 'I asked how do you get your hair so soft? Mine's always just…'

'I like your hair.'

'You do?'

'Yeah, it's'– unruly, fun, wildjust like you, *'different. I never know what to do with mine, so I put it up.'*

Catra tied the end of the braid and came around to look at her, pulling out a few short pieces in the front. Adora's stomach did

something weird, they were so close, and light fingers brushed down her temples.

‘Beautiful.’

The shiver woke her up, but Adora just rolled over and curled into a comfy little ball. She had been having better dreams lately, which was a nice change, but the soft ones such as that had made her hurt more in a way, when she would eventually wake up to her reality. She sighed, thinking about the weeks that had followed what happened in that dream, and how Adora finally realized what the churning in her stomach had meant. She had just been so stupid, it was a marvel that Catra had ever been so patient with her.

And oh, Catra. What she wouldn't give to have those days where she would just braid her hair over and over again. Adora sighed and rolled over to check her phone, but cursed herself at the time. She couldn't remember the last time she overslept an alarm.

She closed her eyes and did some stretches in the break room as the coffee brewed, thankful that she hadn't slept so long as to be late for her shift, but Adora hated missing the gym. It was her time to think without having to think, in a way.

"Morning, Adora."

She jumped slightly, but had gotten used to how Glimmer could just appear out of nowhere, and held back a scowl as the woman poured herself a cup of coffee first. "Hey, Glimmer."

"Have you noticed Bow acting weird?" Glimmer asked flatly as Adora poured her own cup. "I mean, he isn't being particularly *sneaky,* just, not Bow."

She savored a sip, not having time to make a cup as she rushed out of her apartment. "I don't think I've noticed anything?"

Glimmer grunted. "You are the least observant person ever, I don't know why I even bothered."

"Hey-" but Glimmer had already turned and she needed to take only a few strides to catch up. "I'll keep my eye out, if that will make you feel better? Though I'm sure it's nothing"…

"Yeah, maybe" she said. "But speaking of weird, how are things going with you and psycho-hottie"?

"First, you have to stop calling her that, and second, nothing."

"Bullshit."

"We go to the gym together."

Glimmer pulled her to a stop. "Wait, as in like, you two *actually* plan to meet at the gym and workout together"?

"Not exactly," she said and shook Glimmer's hand off of her. "More like we show up at the same time and do our sets together." Mainly she winds up with her back firmly on the mat, Catra smiling above her, pointy canines in full view. She learned quickly after that one day if she stopped talking while they sparred, Catra would stay. "We don't really talk."

"...that sounds healthy."

Adora rubbed at her temples and sighed. It was so hard to explain the dynamic that had always circled between her and Catra, even from when they were little. Glimmer and Bow knew most of the story, the series of events that led her to be in Bright Moon, and everything along with it, but the two of them had been raised in loving, devoted households. They could have and did have everything they wanted, in a sense. Even through the stories, they could never understand what it was like to earn the trust of someone so broken, and to be able to give that trust back in return.

And to try and regain that trust after breaking their heart? Adora was surprised she was doing as well as she was. In fact, she was surprised that Catra hadn't hit her with her bike that first day. Honestly, it would have at least made it somewhat even.

"I am trying my best, Glimmer." She leaned against the wall, inhaling sharply at the cold of it on her back. "I'm still trying to learn how to breathe around her again, so can you maybe get off my case for once with this? Not all of us have sunshine and rainbow relationships."

Glimmer got that feisty twinkle in her eye, which made Adora want to groan, but then both of their pagers went off. "Did you get the emergency in OR-2 also?"

"Yep," Adora said quickly, thankful for the diversion. Most of the time Glimmer's feistiness was fun, but her head was already fuzzy from staying up too late thinking about the way Catra had pinned her down the other night, and then her dream…

"Adora!"

"Right," she hopped away from the wall and tossed out her coffee as they started to speed-walk to the OR. "What do you think it is?"

Glimmer rubbed her hands together. "Well both of us got the page, so it has to be some sort of impact damage. Guy fell off his roof cleaning the gutters?"

"Hmmm," Adora. "It is supposed to rain soon, not bad. I'm going to say a car crashed into a tree."

They went back and forth while they walked, as was their usual routine when going into an emergency surgery. They tried to see who could guess the injury that they would face once they went through the doors.

What they hadnt expected was to be met at the door of the scrub room by Spinnerella and, much to the dismay of Adora's lungs, Catra.

"You three will be scrubbing and gowning up, but you will only watch until given instructions, do you understand?"

They all nodded, and looked at each other in a mixture of confusion and fear at what they were going to find on the inside of that operating room. Catra was new, and maybe she thought this was normal, but Adora and Glimmer knew that they had never seen three residents called to *watch* a surgery.

"What is it, Spinny?" Glimmer asked. Adora wanted to ask, but she was in the middle of trying to not knock Catra's elbows as they washed.

"30 year old female with a left tarsal avulsion, multiple fractures on both right and left lower and upper limbs, frontal depressed skull fracture, as well as a ruptured spleen and right pneumothorax."

Adora turned off her faucet and shook the water from her hands. "What the hell happened?"

Spineralla looked right past her at Catra. "Motorcycle accident."

Glimmer just nodded and followed the General attending into the OR, but Adora and Catra had shared a small gasp together, and stayed behind for a few seconds longer. She had already hated the thought of Catra on a motorcycle, being from Fright City had already assured her that she would never get on one of those things, but Catra was stubborn. She liked to push the limits. Maybe it would be her wakeup call, and Adora hated to be there for it.

See, something Glimmer never really understood was how easily Adora could read Catra's mismatched eyes. She watched her as they were gowned and gloved up by the surgical techs, eyes taking in each spot that wasnt covered by the blue, sterile drapes. Most

people would think that Catra was assessing the situation at hand, but Adora knew that she was seeing herself in that mangled body.

It wasn't often Catra remembered her patients were actual people, but when she did, it shook her up.

"Explain what you would do in the instance of a depressed skull fracture with an epidural hematoma, Dr. C," Angella said at the head of the patient, not looking away for a moment.

Catra's head snapped back from where she was watching Mara clean up what she could of the poor woman's ankle. "I would begin by making a U-shape incision around the edges of the fracture, then perform a craniotomy by drilling four Burr Holes around the fracture site and carefully remove the bone flap to make room for the excavation of the hematoma. Once I am sure I removed as much of the hematoma that I could, I would place a temporary drain at the site and replace the skull flap, plating and screwing where it needed to be pieced back together."

Adora realized at that moment that she hadn't been in the OR with Catra in the entire two months the woman had been at Bright Moon Memorial Hospital, and for that, she was thankful. If she had heard the power and confidence in Catra's voice in those first few days they had been reunited, she surely would have fainted. They had only been interns the last time the two of them worked together, and back at Horde General, you *never* spoke unless it was life or death. She shivered, and it wasn't just because the operating room was cold.

"Good," Angella said with a small nod, "and what do you do if there is brain matter pushing through the dura mater?"

Even though they were gowned to the point where only the eyes were visible, she could see Catra blanch. She straightened up more than she already had been. "It would depend on the location of the brain matter."

"Explain."

It was torture, really, to stand there and listen to Catra speak for almost an hour and a half on each different part of the brain, its merit, and what would happen if it were damaged at a certain level. Adora itched to do something other than listen, she wanted to help with the amputation of the patient's leg, or the plating of their tibia, or even repairing the perforated lung—and she *hated* lungs. She wanted to *want* to do something other than listen to Catra. They had been in the OR for nearly three hours now, the patient had died on the table twice;it had been an absolute flurry of motion the entire time trying to keep the patient alive, and yet, Adora only heard the scratchy, unwavering voice of the woman she always wanted to be next to.

She was going to have a hell of a time trying to do her job if she didn't learn how to be a human around Catra again.

"Dr. Grayskull!"

Adora blinked herself out of whatever far off world she had been in and finally realized that no less than twelve people were looking at her. "I'm sorry, what happened?"

"Dr. Grayskull, if you cannot remain rooted and focused in my OR, you may leave."

It wasn't the first time she heard that, but it hurt no less, especially coming from the chief. "No, I am focused, I promise. What was the question?"

"I said," Angella emphasized with a tired throat, "are you ready to lead your other residents through the splenectomy? Or should I have one of your colleagues take over for you in the meantime. I'm sure Dr. C or Dr. Cor would be glad to stand in your spot."

"No," Adora said and walked over to the position that Spinerella was vacating. Luckily for her, muscle memory kicked in quickly and she

snapped out of whatever ridiculous daydream she had been in. *You are a surgeon, Adora, start acting like it.* "The three of us are going to remove the spleen alone?" This would be her first solo, which was nerve wracking, but all things considered, this was probably the best time to try it.

"We needed to make sure the patient didn't die first," Mira said from her position over the woman's right femur. "A splenectomy was my first solo as well! We'll all be right here if you need any direction, but you three are the best we have, and it's time you all showed us what you've got."

"Right," she nodded and took a breath to center herself. Adora knew – theoretically – she was ready for this day, but also knew that she would never be ready for the feelings that would come with the pressure of a solo procedure, let alone with her best friend and the other incredibly complicated party, but she couldn't be bothered with that right now. She took one glance around the room, noting every person on the surgical team, and nodded again. "Right. Catra, come stand by my side. Glimmer, take the opposite side. We're going to start from the" –

The best decision she made that entire surgery was having Catra stand next to her and not in front, because if she had caught those eyes looking at her any more than the two times she had endured, their patient would have had some serious issues. Well, above the issues she already was going to have, since she now was missing part of her brain and a foot. Adora marveled at how well the three of them worked together, mainly her two other residents who had been known to not get along very well in the OR, and the three of them received plenty of "good job" back pats as everyone trickled out.

Angella was waiting for them once they left the scrub room. "I wanted to tell the three of you what a wonderful job you did, I am very impressed by the way you took care of each other and your patient throughout the procedure. I cannot wait to see how well you

progress with your chosen specialty. Now,” she looked at Glimmer and Catra, “I need a moment alone with Dr. Grayskull, if you both wouldn't mind.”

Adora was already a bit on edge, she could feel something weird coming off of Catra as they scrubbed out from the procedure, and she watched out of the corner of her eye as the tan woman nodded her head and walked away quickly. She took note of which hall she turned down, and hoped Angella would make it quick.

“Adora,” the chief said and she was rapt attention, “what happened in there? I've never had to say your name more than once.”

“I know, Chief, I apologize and I promise it won't happen again.”

Gray eyes regarded her in the way they usually did for a moment. “Very well, but if it happens again, I can assure you that you will be out of that OR in an instant. The only reason you three were given the option of a solo surgery was because the patient was already in rapid decay.” Angella hung her head for a moment, something Adora had never seen happen. “I am honestly amazed that she made it through that alive, and if she does recover from this, there is no telling the damage that has been done.”

“I understand, Chief.” Medicine was not a black and white area, there was no assurance that a treatment would work or not. Adora was still relatively new in terms of the medical world, but even she had been subjected to the horrors of cases that had seemed so easy, then turned out to be anything but. She had seen people on the brink of death come back with a vengeance, and she had also seen someone die from an infected cut. There was no magical cure for things, there were only the statistics of *maybe.* At the end of the day, it was her job to know everything she could know, do her best, and hope to all hell that she would be the ticket to each person's *maybe.* Maybe they'll get to keep their hand, maybe they can walk without a limp, maybe maybe maybe…

Adora knew to be humbled by medicine, but she also knew that if she second-guessed herself, or wasn't completely present, she wasn't giving her patient her all;she could mess up, and Adora Grayskull does *not* mess up.

"Yes, I think you do," the chief agreed, seeing something change in her eyes. "You are dismissed."

She didn't know what had prompted her to try and follow Catra, but she was on a mission, and Adora checked all the doors in the hall she saw her slip down to no avail. *Where would she have gone?* Catra always liked to perch up somewhere high, but she probably didn't have a key to the roof, so Adora decided that the basement would be quiet enough for her to escape to.

Her heart was beating as she rounded the corner towards the morgue and spotted Catra sitting on a forgotten gurney, eyes closed and head back against the wall. She watched her breathing, noticed its practiced patterns, and chastised herself again when she remembered how perceptive Catra was.

"Hey, Adora," she said, not even opening her eyes. "Are you following me again?"

She laughed at that, remembering the days where she would always have to follow Catra after they got yelled at. "I just uhh," she started and cleared her throat with a little cough. "I just noticed you were kind of off after the surgery, so I wanted to check in on you. Are you okay?"

"Do I have a reason not to be?" Catra asked, lifting her head off the wall and letting those eyes drift over to Adora's.

"I don't know, I just figured that seeing a patient with such extensive injuries from a motorcycle crash would be a bit shocking, seeing as how you ride one..."

She laughed, and Adora got caught in the way her neck moved with the sound. "Please, you *do* know that neuros call bike riders, 'organ donors,' right? I knew what I was doing when I bought it."

"Why do it then? Why put yourself at such risk when you know what could happen?"

"Why do you care?"

"I—" she hadn't expected that question at all, and she shut her mouth before any other useless words could fall out. "Of course I care, Catra. I have always cared." And that was putting it lightly . They looked at one another long enough for Adora's heart to calm down, and she sighed. "Can I sit with you?"

Those damn eyes of hers looked to be at war, but then she nodded silently. Adora climbed up and sat far enough away that she wasn't pushing boundaries, but not far enough to be awkward.

"I bought it when I came here," Catra said into the quiet air . "I never would have ridden in Fright, that place is ridiculous, but here? It's a little better here."

"But it's not perfect."

"No," Catra chuckled, "nothing is perfect. I don't know , it just felt like something I needed to do."

Adora looked at her, taking in the lines of her jaw and soft, dark skin. She noted a new little scar above the neckline of her scrubs, and she wondered where it came from. She wondered so badly what had gone on in the woman's life in the last three years, she ached for it. She ached for Catra, no matter how hard it would be.

"Catra, why did you leave Horde Gen?" she asked, wanting to throw up instantly at how stiff Catra got from the question. "Why are so many people from Horde here?"

"Do you not watch the news, or look up anything?"

She shrugged. "Not really . To be honest, I'm not even sure my phone has the internet on it. I don't really do much besides work and go to the gym."Adora hoped that would make her laugh, but it didn't.

"W eaver died, Adora"—

"What?"Her voice caught at the top of her throat, her body flushing with dread. "Catra"…

Tan arms wrapped tight around herself and Catra looked away. "There was an explosion at the hospital, a bunch of people died. Horde Gen had been skiving off of regulations for all the gas compressors in th OR's, and there was faulty maintenance everywhere, so one day it just blew ."

"W ere you there?"Adora asked thickly , and Catra nodded. Static filled her ears as her anxiety rose. "Did you get hurt?"

"No, I was on the other side of the hospital but I found her ."She dipped her head on the edge of her shoulder to catch a tear. "She was already dead, she died from the blast."Her choked, annoyed, wet laugh made Adora's stomach churn. "They tried to cover it up as some fluke, but I couldn't stay . A lot of us left, we all went to different hospitals and just"—she finished with a shrug, wiping another tear .

Adora felt like the wind had been knocked out of her, twice. One for her dead mother, and another time for the fact that Catra had to go through that, alone. Her mind raced, and she couldn't understand why she was feeling pain for someone who had abused her, tormented her, who had tried so hard to tear Catra and her apart. She had tried to take them both away from Weaver, and she never understood why Catra had wanted to stay, but now that she was gone from the world, it all felt different.

"Catra"—she reached for her but Catra flinched away .

"Dont. Dont try to apologize now , Weaver has been dead to you for years, you got rid of her as soon as you could, *Grayskull."* She wiped her eyes again and Adora leaned away from the fire in them. "If you cared, you would have stayed. If you cared, you would have asked before now, you wouldnt have asked me! You could have asked your new little best friend, or her mom that just cant get enough of you. Perfect Adora, you have everything you ever wanted here, you dont care about anyone but yourself."

"I—that's not"—she stuttered, completely unable to form words. "That's low, Catra. Even for you."

"Oh, Adora," Catra said and hopped off the bed. "Nothing is too low for me."

Adora jumped off too and grabbed her arm before she could leave. "I asked you to come with me, I *begged* you. So dont try and tell me that I didnt care."

"You just dont get it, do you?" Catra pulled Adora's hand off of her arm and held it for a fraction longer than she needed to. "Thanks for ruining my secret spot."

Her throat bobbed as she watched her walk away, not even being able to chase. Adora's mind was chaos, they had been so close to being able to talk, but it just...wasnt the right time. She knew when to push Catra's boundaries, when to get her to talk and listen, but it wasnt then.

Adora sat back down on the bed and thought for a while as to whether they would ever be in the right space to talk. Could they ever get back to where they used to be?

She had to let herself believe there was a chance. If there wasnt, Catra never would have come to Bright Moon.

There had to be a chance, so Adora took a deep breath, and then she let herself cry.

–

She stood far enough away from the crowd so that no one would try and talk to her, not that anyone had ever cared enough to try. People trickled out quickly after the casket was lowered in, most of them only coming to pay respects out of necessity rather than sorrow for the loss of Sharon Weaver. Catra wasn't sure if Weaver had any real friends, to tell the truth. It was hard to earn trust when you were about as fake and plastic as your specialty.

A slight breeze caused her to shiver, a single tear that had spilled was icy on her cheek, and she swept it off quickly . Why was she crying? Catra should be celebrating the death of that horrid bitch. That bitch who screamed at her for weeks when Adora left, telling her to go find her.

She hoped that her coffin wasn't sealed right. Bitch.

Catra thought that when Weaver was gone, she would feel relief, but all she felt was exhaustion. It was almost as if the rage she felt whenever she spotted that dull, black hair around the hospital had kept her going, but now that she was gone, Catra was tired. Tired and done with the life she had been living (or barely surviving) the last few years.

Leaves rustled behind her and Catra sighed. 'You didn't have to come, Scorp.'

'I wasn't going to let my best pal do this alone, now was I?'

A drop of warmth swam through her chest. Scorpia really was so nice, almost too nice sometimes. She had tried to make some moves on Catra once, and for a moment she entertained them – Scorpia was blonde, buff, and kind of an idiot sometimes…but she just wasn't Adora.

Oh, Adora. The thought of her made the hair on the back of her neck stand up.

‘Let’s get out of here, Scorpia.’

‘Sure thing! Do you want to grab some food? Maybe we can get’–

‘No, I mean let’s leave. *Like let’s just pack everything and get the fuck out of Fright City. I’m tired of this place, I’m tired of being treated like the gum on the bottom of someone's shoe. There are plenty of hospitals that are willing to take in Horde employees…we can go.’*

‘Oh…I guess I hadn’t really thought of that…where would you want to go? I don’t think I want Kingdom of Snows’–

‘Bright Moon,’ it came out so quickly, but it made that warmth bloom. ‘Let’s go to Bright Moon.’

There wasn't enough coffee in the world, she decided, that would help make her feel better. That was probably to do with the fact that she felt like shit as a whole person, but Catra wasn't ready to admit that yet. She had stayed up far too late the night before, her mind racing as it had been lately, and then of course Weaver’s funeral decided to drop into her subconscious.

The dreams were getting better, some good ones mixed in every now and then, but then she would get to work and her mood would drop. It had been a week since her fucked up talk with Adora in the basement, and since then she had treated pretty much anyone she had run into with the utmost insolence and disrespect. Honestly, Catra had surprised herself with how horrid she had been. The last straw had been making Scorpia cry, which she really thought she had been working on.

Catra rubbed her eyes and got in line at the cafeteria, not even wanting to face anyone else in the break room in fear that they might plot a coup on her, and ordered the largest, strongest coffee they had. *It would have to do.*

She had been so close to apologizing to Adora, she had even gone so far as to walk into the lobby of the gym she had avoided for days, but saw coiling muscles slamming fists into the punching bag, and she wasn't ready for that to be her. Catra found herself walking to Entrapta's office, which had been her new spot now instead of the morgue hallway. So long as she stayed clear of the wires and buttons, the maintenance tech hardly noticed she was there. "Hey, Entrapta," she offered, but only got a wave in reply.

Catra watched as the woman rolled around on her pink chair, her long braids nearly getting caught in the wheels a couple of times, and she sighed. According to DT, the best apology was a sincere apology with a means to do better in the future, which was a problem for Catra, because she had promised herself when she was a little girl that she would never apologize to anyone. Ever.

But she wasn't that little girl anymore, she was a grown ass adult who had been a raging bitch to anyone that breathed, save for Angella. There was no way that the chief didn't know about her little bout of bitchiness, but the sweet and steadfast woman had been the one to give Catra a chance, and for that, she would always be grateful.

Catra sipped at the disgusting cafeteria coffee and thought of Adora, again. That day had just been one thing after another really, it was such an attack on all of her senses. She had known they would eventually be in the OR together, but there was no way she could have anticipated them being thrown in together during *that.* Catra knew it was stupid to get a bike, she knew the stats, but she also never got the chance to do anything or be anyone other than the spare her entire life, so she wanted to be different. She had seen plenty of grotesque surgeries, but seeing that body and knowing why it happened had struck a chord in her, and she had to pat herself on the back for not throwing up.

She also traded her motorcycle in for a car a few days later. It wasn't as cool, but she really liked her leg and didn't want to lose it or anything else.

Angella had the presence of mind, at least, to have her explain why the brain is important, which helped for a while, but then she had to be apart of a solo surgery with *Adora* and fucking Glitter? It had almost been too much, but they had all easily slipped into their roles, thankful to not kill their patient.

But then of course Adora had followed her, and she finally told her that their mother was dead, and it all was–

She took another long drink, not caring at the burn. She couldnt fault Adora for not looking anything up, not really. Catra had worked enough with DT to understand that nothing they went through with Weaver was their fault, and she would always hold the pain of what had happened, but she was free of it now. She had been free, mostly, since she was 18, but her own stubbornness had done more harm than good. She was working on it, and it was hard.

Mostly, she was trying to get the words that came out of her mouth to match what her heart wanted to say, but that was just too much to ask of herself at that point in time.

It had felt good, really, to talk as if they were getting back to normal. Adora was such an idiot, and even though she had left mad, Catra was able to breathe, which was better than it had been. But there was still so much to do…

As the last of the useless coffee touched her tongue, her pager blared:

ALL SURGICAL TEAM MEMBERS REPORT TO EMERGENCY ROOM ONE IMMEDIATELY

Well fuck, that was never a good sign.

Catra hucked her coffee cup into the trash and yelled a quick goodbye to Entrapta, who had paid her absolutely no mind the entire time. She ran, ready to clear her mind of all the bitchy bullshit and get to work. She pushed herself against the wall of the emergency

department, earning plenty of sneers as she tried to get close enough to hear Dr. Tara's instructions.

"Listen up, everyone," her calm but authoritative voice rang through the open space, "there was a bridge collapse on the North end of Bright Moon, and we are trying to divert as much as we can, but we are the only Level 1 trauma center in 25 miles, so we all need to be in our best form. This is going to be a lot of work." Perfuma scanned the crowd, "Netossa, Scorpia, you will take the first rig to Trauma 1; it is a 7 year old boy who was thrown from the vehicle and has multiple fractures. Mara, Adora, you'll take Trauma 4, there is a rig with a 54 year old male with a cervical fracture. Catra and the chief will take Trauma 2, a 20 year old woman went through the windshield and has a depressed skull fracture. Everyone else, remain calm and take the first thing you see. We work best together, and I trust in all of you to do what is right. Now get gowned up and ready!"

This was her third major vehicle incident since moving to Bright Moon, and at first she had questioned whether such a sweet and docile woman such as Perfuma could handle the rigor of being a trauma surgeon, but Catra had learned her place very quickly with the power she possessed when it came time to get shit done. She shook her head out of it and got gowned up, trying to ignore Glimmer's piercing stare. She might be little, but Sparkles packed a lot of energy in her anger.

"Dr. C," Angella acknowledged as she walked up, "it seems that you are going to be able to walk me through a depressed skull fracture repair once more."

She only nodded, knowing full well how different each case was, and waited for their rig.

"Emma George, 20 years old with a—" she ran up with Angella and let her mind go completely blank of everything else in the world besides doing whatever she could to treat her patient.

Heavy trauma days were always the slowest and fastest at the same time, and they were endlessly draining. There was no time for food, or a bathroom break, or hardly time to breathe;if they gave themselves time for that, it meant that someone might die.

Catra scrubbed until her hands were raw, ignoring the fact that they had already been raw for close to 7 hours by that point, but thoughts didnt matter anymore. It had been 18 hours of pure hell, and she couldnt care less about the cracking of skin she felt between her fingers. She had saved another patient, and that's all that mattered to her. She had saved four and lost one, which she would let herself think on perhaps another day, but right then, all she needed was to find the closest on-call room and sleep for a year.

At almost 2:00 in the morning, there was only one other OR that was in use, and she wondered vaguely who was in it. The day had been so hectic that she hardly had time to notice anyone that wasnt covered in blood or screaming, which meant she often mistook Glimmer for a patient, but that too had become easy to ignore. There had been flashes of blonde and gray through the day as well. She even had another surgery with Adora, where she got to witness first hand how much the woman loved orthopedics, and how she never, *ever* wanted to get between Adora and a bone saw, but there hadnt been time to think of anything but bleeding ears and a split jaw .

It had been a long day.

Her surgery clogs padded softly through quiet halls as she let her legs guide her to the closest on-call room she could remember. Catra didnt even consider who else might have stayed long enough to need to sleep at the hospital, but her heart lurched when she opened the door, bright light from the hall illuminating blonde hair.

"Fuck" she muttered as she watched Adora begin to stir . Her heart lurched more when she noticed that she was sleeping curled up in a ball again. *She hadn't done that in years.* It had been such a long, exhausting day, and the other on-call room was so far away."Fuck

it,”she grumbled and walked in the room. If Adora was going to be mad, she could handle that later, but she just needed sleep.

“Catra?”An utterly depleted and groggy voice questioned, and her body felt close to giving out.

“There’s nowhere else to go,”Catra said as she slipped off her shoes and climbed in next to her. It was a tiny bed, and she really wished that Bright Moon could have sprung for bigger mattresses. She squirmed a bit, trying to find a spot, and heard a low *‘oof’* as her elbow hit something.

“Catra,”Adora groaned and pulled her in close. Her skin exploded where that arm was wrapped over her stomach, and she wondered how awake the idiot even was.

“I’ll only be here a little bit,”she said, “I know you all hate me, but I just need to sleep, so dont worry about me. Ill be gone in a little.”

The pads of dry fingertips skidded across her stomach, pulling her in closer, and she could feel hot breath on the back of her neck. “I have never hated you, Catra.”

If Catra had the energy for it, she would have cried.

Chapter End Notes

It's not the "only one bed" we want to see, but it'll do.

Medical stuff!

Tarsal Avulsion: essentially her foot was nearly torn from her ankle, also called "degloving." 100/10 don't recommend looking it up.

A depressed skull fracture is just like...when you crack an egg and there is a round little indent at first? Very common when

skulls hit solid objects. Don't recommend it.

Spleens you can live without, though we usually like to keep them as they are part of the immunity system. C'est la vie.

Pneumothorax: a collapsed lung.

Also I am from Southern California and we are chock full of motorcycle riders out here, I have a life worth of horror stories of people riding them and getting hurt (my dad) or killed (a few friends). Please don't ride them, or if you do, please ride with All Gear All The Time. Car vs. Motorcycle will almost always end with car winning.

Disaster Lesbian Adora is such a sweetheart, I love her .
I hope you're all enjoying this!

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She hummed as she sipped from her cup, not even bothering to wonder why she never thought of bringing her own coffee, and relaxed into the chair.

It had been two days since the night she crawled into that on-call bed with Adora and cuddled into her as if they didnt have any problems, as if everything was normal. It had been two days since Catra woke up, cuddled deep into Adora's neck, feeling a sense of warmth and calm she hadnt felt in years. They had shifted during the night, bodies reverting stupidly into how they used to sleep when they had their own place, and she had panicked for a fraction of second before realizing that the other woman was still dead to the world.

'I have never hated you, Catra.' Sure it might have been just exhaustion talking, but it still had settled deep in the base of her chest, radiating a certain glow that almost hurt with how much she had needed it.

Catra had felt indulgent that morning, body still aching from the day prior, and she just let herself sink into the embrace, telling herself over and over *'just five more seconds.'* Adora was just so *warm,* and her arms held her in such a surprisingly soft way that made goosebumps dance where their skin met through the overwashed fabric of her scrubs. Their legs were intertwined, and Catra smiled at the thought of Adora being able to stretch out. She had closed her eyes, the pulse of Adora's neck on her forehead, and let herself get lost in the smell of her. Even sweaty and overworked from a shitty day, Adora never smelled bad;she always had this woodsy smell,

like a specific patch of trees in the Whispering Woods they used to escape to when they were kids.

Just five more seconds, she told herself one last time before actually sticking to it. Catra refused to look back as she left the room, knowing full well she would give in if she saw the soft, sleepy features of that stupid face she had ached for.

It had been two days, and she hadn't seen Adora at all, which was probably better for the both of them, but it had also been two days where she remembered that everyone else still hated her, even if Adora had personally denied it. It made her groan slightly and sink deeper into her chair. *Apologies.* Catra let her mind tumble through the seemingly never-ending dichotomy of *trying* to be a good person. She hated apologies, she hated showing any sort of weakness on her part, or any semblance of acknowledgement that she had been wrong;and the other side of the vicious coin called humanity ,'was just how good it felt to be nice and helpful.

She'd never let anyone know that, of course, she still had her pride, but Catra wouldn't have become a doctor if she didn't think she could be of use. Yeah, she might have done it because it was essentially indoctrinated in her throughout her upbringing, and then subsequently she fought for her adopted mother 's love through the path of medicine, but Catra still *cared* about her patients —mostly . And, much to her dismay, she actually cared about the people she worked with, and she knew that it was going to be hell to work her way back to a place where she could walk by someone and not be sneered at.

But Catra was stubborn, she would try to end the world if it would get her what she wanted, and she shivered slightly at the growing realization that she wanted to be *good.* It was weird.

It was early enough that she hoped to have the break room for herself, but the door opened and she looked up to see Scorpia pause as she walked in. *Well, guess it's time to start.*

"Oh hey , Catra, I didnt know you were in here," she said and tried to back out of the room.

"Scorpia wait," Catra said quickly and swallowed the lump in her throat. "I've actually wanted to talk to you, if you wouldnt mind?"

"Right, yeah, of course" – and they both smiled just a bit. Sweet Scorpia, she was always unnecessarily nice, even to people who didnt deserve it – people like Catra.

She took a deep breath. "Scorpia, I want to apologize for how I've been treating you lately, and I am sorry for embarrassing you in front of Perfuma the other day. It was wrong of me to have said anything. I have been going through a lot of my own negative feelings and I have used them to lash out on you, and it's not okay. I am working on being better with my emotions, and I hope that we can be okay again."

The light in her dark eyes would have been enough, but then Catra was three feet off the ground and had no air in her lungs. "Thank you for apologizing, Wildcat. I'm so glad you're working on things, but you know I couldnt stay mad at you forever ."

"Right" – she wheezed and patted the enormous bicep that was squeezing the life out of her . She hadnt realized how much she missed Scorpia's hugs, but it was getting to be a lot. "Scorpia? I cant breathe."

"Ohmygosh I am so sorry" – she said quickly and dropped Catra, who barely caught herself before falling. "Sorry , I'm sorry , I was just so happy!"

"It' s alright," she chuckled and patted her friend' s arm.

"And about the Perfuma thing," Scorpia said and blushed, "you actually sort of helped there. We – we're going on a date tomorrow ."

"No way!"

"Yes! Apparently we had both been too nervous to say anything, but then you kind of took care of that for us and, well"…

Catra was sure she had never seen her friend so happy, or so vibrant. Scorpia was gorgeous, that was an easily known fact, but her joy brought out a different sort of beauty, and it nearly hurt her face, she was smiling so hard for her. "I can't tell you how happy I am for you, Scorp, really. I can't wait to hear about it."

They chatted for a bit until Scorpia got a page and had to run, but Catra happily wandered off to the nurses station to see what she could get her hands on. She was happily musing, when Angella came up behind her.

"Catra," she said and Catra turned around quickly, "I need you to go do a work up on a patient."

She bit back a small groan, surprisingly. She usually jumped at the chance to do something for Angella. "Why me? Isn't that what we have interns for?"

"This is a special patient of mine, Catra." If she hadn't already respected the hell out of the chief, the stare she received would have been enough to scare her. "This is the third time he's had to come in for this, and I want to know that he is being well taken care of."

Dealing with patients and giving them excellent care had never been her specialty, and thus far, she usually was able to skip the pleasantries and get right into the OR, but she knew that would change eventually. Catra was definitely working on being better with people in general, but she was just getting started with coworkers, not patients, and with that came much, much more. Being a good surgeon began before she picked up a scalpel, before she scrubbed in – hell, it started before she even signed the papers to perform each surgery. The human mind was her favorite place to be in, but she needed to work on discovering what people were like before she, quite literally, touched their brains.

"What's his name?" She asked.

"Eli Woods." A thick folder was slapped in front of her before Angella swept elegantly away down the hall.

"I see where Sparkles gets her flair for dramatics," Catra mumbled before opening the charts, but then her stomach sank.

Eli Woods, 12 years old, admitted once again for a recurrent Group 4 Large Cell Anaplastic Medulloblastoma.

She hated kids.

Scratch that, she hated *dealing* with kids, because it wasn't fair to have such wretched things happen to tiny little people who don't have a choice. Her throat tightened as she read through the file, all of his surgeries and rounds of chemo, every hospitalization for infection – it was all too much for one kid to handle. She knew all too well what it was like to not have a childhood, and she didn't wish that life on anyone. Had it been a few months ago, in a different hospital, Catra would have pushed the file over to Scorpia. Scorpia was the pediatrics resident, not her, but she was trying to be better. Angella gave her the case specifically, so Catra straightened her shoulders and steeled herself before walking to his room.

She knocked lightly, "hi, I'm Dr. C, I'm here to see Eli." Her heart clenched at the sight of him, so small on the big bed, dark brown hair ridiculously floppy in the way that preteens always had it. "Are you his parents?" She said to the people next to the bed, who looked as wary as she felt.

"Where is Dr. Cor?" The woman asked, "she's usually the one here with us, she always deals with Eli."

Catra noted a small frown in the boy's face but it righted itself quickly. "Dr. Cor is currently with another patient at the moment, but I am the Neuro resident here and will be working alongside her throughout Eli's care." Small again, but it was there.

The man put his hand on his wife's shoulder to settle her. "If Angella sent you, you must be good," he said. "We just want the best for him."

Catra figured something was up by another frown and little squirm, so she thought quickly of what to do. "Alright I just need to ask some questions and check vitals really quick, it wont take much time." She lifted the bed so she could run her checks on her patient before leaning the bed back a little. "So what was the first thing you noticed was going on?"

"He started throwing up in the mor—" the mom tried.

"When possible," Catra interjected kindly but sternly, "I like to get an explanation from my patient themselves. If you—" she stopped and pretended that her phone vibrated. "Perfect—" she said with a smile, "Dr. Cor is out at the nurses station down the hall and would like to speak to the two of you." They looked skeptical, but she was a fantastic liar – she tried not to use that power too often, but would when needed. "I just have a few more questions here, I promise."

"Right, come on, sweetheart," the man said and beckoned to the door. "We ll be back, Eli."

A small wave was all they got in return and Catra waited until the door was completely shut before she turned around. "Alright I just want to make sure that you are okay, I noticed you looked uncomfortable when your parents referred to you by Eli' or used male pronouns. Is there anything you want to talk about?" Big brown eyes looked up at her quickly, they looked so scared, so shocked. It broke her heart. "You are my patient," she said softly, "I am here for your needs and there isnt anything personal I am mandated to tell anyone unless you have been abused or have thoughts of self harm/suicide. I promise that I am a safe person to talk to. Do you want me to use different pronouns?" A dense pause, followed by a small nod, and Catra could hardly hold back her smile. "Sounds good, what do you prefer?"

"She/her , please," was finally whispered, and Catra could see just a small bit of weight lifted off her little shoulders.

"You got it. Is there a different name you would like me to use?"

She looked shy, as if no one had asked her any of this before, and Catra figured that perhaps no one had. "I kind of have been stuck on Elora."

"Elora," Catra said and leaned back a little. "Elora," she tried again. "I love it, it's beautiful."

"You think so?"

"Absolutely ," she replied with a nod and wrote a quick note in her file. "Elora, have you told your parents about this yet?"

Her face fell from shy joy , and Catra hated to have to ruin the moment, but she might not get much time alone with her after this.

"I brought it up before that I didn't feel like a boy , but I'm not sure they understand. They're kind of old fashioned, so I don't think they really get it, but I think they're just worried about my health and stuff mainly."

"Do you feel as though you'll be in any sort of danger if you bring it up again with them?"

"Wha—no. No, they would never hurt me or anything," she said and picked at the cotton balls on the hospital blanket. "They stress a lot about money, and so usually everything else is not that important. I brought it up a few months ago, but we don't talk a lot, so I can't be open with them." Elora pointed to her head, "and now this? It's just… not a good time."

Well, it hardly was ever a good time if someone wasn't sure their parents would be accepting, but that didn't need to be said. "I can understand where you're coming from, but please know that you are

allowed to be who you are here, okay? I know our team here at Bright Mon shares my sentiment, so with your permission, I'd like to make sure that everyone knows how to properly address you, and we will make sure not to do it in front of your parents."

Elora gave her the brightest smile she's seen in days, and it felt good to be able to help her be her true self. "I'd love that, Dr. C."

"Call me Catra, alright?"

She nodded. "Thanks, Catra."

She smiled and pulled over the vitals cart to actually do her job. "Okay, kiddo, so what's been going on?"

—

Adora's brain just about short circuited when she saw the surgery board for the day:

SURGERY - Attd: Shera, Mermista Res: Grayskull, A.W eaver, C.

Her stomach felt like it was going to fall out of her ass. A planned and scheduled surgery with Catra? Who the hell decided that would be a good idea? It wasn't as if she couldn't perform, but things were very interesting between them right now, and she felt heat prickle along the back of her neck at the thought of Weaver's favorite words. *Catra distracts you, she confuses you.*

It was true of course, when they were younger, but Adora had never seen it as a bad thing. She still didn't, but that didn't mean she wasn't afraid of it.

She was distracted and confused, and she tried to push away the memory of how Catra would hang those words over her head when she was at the end of her rope. It hurt so much, it hurt that she was never able to protect her from Weaver, as much as she tried. It hurt

that Catra would ever think she was capable of wanting anything less than equal treatment for them both.

But she was distracted by how easily they both had let down their walls the other night and wrapped around one another. Sure, exhaustion did a number on the decision-making part of the brain, but Adora was entirely cognizant of her actions and words. She was perfectly awake when Catra had rolled over and tucked herself neatly into the crook of her neck – it had taken her breath away . She was distracted because something changed that night; she felt the change in Catra's body at her whispered words, *'I have never hated you'* –

Did she dare hope that they were going to get through this in a way where they could have a conversation without winding up saying something wrong? Who knows. But Catra had shown up to the gym the night prior, and smiled the same, pointy smile once she had thoroughly slammed Adora onto the floor.

"I swear if I have to cut someone' s leg off, I quit." She turned to see Catra looking entirely blasé with her cof fee mug and slightly rumpled hair. She looked absolutely gorgeous, and Adora couldn't even look away once those eyes fell on her. "What, do I have something on my face?"

"No," she said quickly and blinked out the hearts in her eyes, "why would you think we were going to cut someone's leg off? It says right there that it's a" –

"Y eah yeah," Catra waved her of f, "you were just staring at the board like you couldn't read, so I needed to make sure you were, you know, lucid."

Had she been watching her? "I hope I'm lucid, I've been wanting to do one of these for so long."

Catra hummed and tapped the side of her mug. "I'm wondering if I'll ever get scheduled for a neuro surgery again. I had to do an ICD

implant yesterday with Mah."

"Dont you like cardio?"

"So? I want to do neuro first at least," she argued.

Adora could see it in her eyes that Catra really didnt know why she was getting scheduled in different departments. "They all want to work with you because youre a good surgeon, Catra."

The smile she received was more than she had been ready for, but it made her entire body fill with a happiness she hadnt felt in way too long.

"Hey , Ill be in that surgery with you two!" Bow threw his arms over both of their shoulders and brought them in tight, breaking them out of whatever beautiful thing they had just been in, but his joy was too infectious to be upset about it. "I feel like it' s been so long since Ive worked with you, Adora!"

She pushed him off with love, not being able to handle being so close to Catra's face. "That' s because you usually hate doing ortho."

"Fair ," he turned towards Catra, whispering, "I dont like the sound of the saw on bones." He let her go with a pat on her back and started to walk away. "I have to go prep, but Ill see you two in there!"

"Does Bow want to be a surgeon?" Catra asked once he was far enough away.

"What?" Adora turned quickly . "What do you mean?"

Catra tilted her head slightly as she looked at her. "Bow is probably the most attentive surgical tech I have ever seen. Have you not noticed that?" Adora shook her head and Catra pursed her lips before continuing. "If you stand close enough to him, he kind of mutters the whole time, like he's going through the steps of the

surgery, and he always has a blade or clamps ready before being asked."

"No, I never noticed," she said quietly , feeling like a terrible friend. Bow had never voiced a want to do more than be a surgical tech, so she just assumed that his charisma was a love for what he did. "Glimmer did bring it up to me a few weeks ago that he seemed different, but he just seems like Bow to me."

Catra laughed brightly and it warmed her to her very toes. "That's because you're about as observant as a worm, I don't know why she would ask you."

"She said that too," Adora chuckled and took a good look at the woman next to her. "You know, you and Glimmer are a lot alike, you're both just so stubborn that you can't give each other a chance."

"Adora, I was having a good morning," she punched her shoulder lightly, "don't ruin it."

"I'm just saying!" She argued and caught up after Catra walked off towards the lockers. "You guys would probably be pretty good friends if you let it happen."

To her surprise, she didn't get a death glare, but merely an eye roll. "I think you need to tell Sparkles that, because believe it or not, I *have* tried to be nice, and she almost ripped my head off."

"Yeah, that sounds about right for Glimmer," she mumbled and changed into her surgery shoes. "Okay think of it this way , you like Bow, right?"

"Who doesn't like Bow?"

"Exactly . And they're married! She's really not so bad once you break her shell, and then you'd see just how they make sense."

“Look,” Catra said and put her hands on her hips, “I’m not going to put extra energy into someone who doesn’t want to do the same for me, you know? I’m not great at the whole friend’ thing.” She scratched at her surgical cap and sighed. “I’ll think about it, alright? But in the meantime, watch Bow in this surgery. Maybe it’ s just how he is, and maybe I just don’t know him, but he seems way more interested than most techs.”

Being able to walk side-by-side to the OR with Catra, being able to talk to her, had distracted her so much that she completely forgot to pay attention to Bow. But really, who could blame her when Adora had Catra to watch instead?

–

“What’ s up, Arrow boy?” Catra unceremoniously slapped her lunch onto the table that housed a very distracted looking Bow. “Mind if I sit here?”

“Wha–oh, hey Catra!” he said with a slight jump. “Y eah of course. How’s it going?”

He was cute, really, but she wasn’t particularly one for formalities. “I am just dandy , can I ask you something?”

He perked up a bit. “Y eah absolutely.” Of all the new people she had met at Bright Moon, Bow was secretly her favorite. He just had these big, dark, doey eyes and she felt the need to protect him at all costs.

“Do you want to be a doctor?”

Big, doey eyes blinked quickly . “What makes you say that?” He asked.

Catra ripped her bagel and took a bite before pointing it at him. “Y ou watch every surgery as if you are trying to learn what to do, you talk to yourself afterwards about what happened or what went wrong, and I can see the way you watch everyone around you, like you want

to be a part of more than just handing over tools. You like to watch how things work, and it's more than just a thing of curiosity."

"That was not what I was expecting." He paused and she gave him a look as if to say she would wait, and then he sighed. "I don't know. I don't think it's that easy."

"Why not?" She bit off another chunk of her bagel and held his gaze, so he laughed.

"You really are something, aren't you?" Bow smiled at her endearingly. "You're not wrong, it's just that I'm not exactly young anymore, and the idea of starting nearly everything over is kind of scary."

"You're what, 29? That's not exactly senile. Plenty of people start even later than that."

"That's true," he agreed and pushed his plate back and forth, contemplating. "I don't know how Glimmer would take it though, you know? She has her boards in a few months and it would be a lot of pressure."

"Do you think she wouldn't be supportive?" The thought of it actually shocked her. True she wasn't the biggest fan of Sparkles, but Catra could see how much the two of them loved each other.

Bow see-sawed his hands. "I wouldn't say that, it's more that Glimmer is very competitive, she likes to be the best of the best at things and I worry that she might think I'm encroaching on her domain. Does that make sense?"

"Yeah, it sort of does." She knew competition all too well, she had been raised in it, but it had never been a deterrent to what she wanted. "But I also think that is ridiculous. For one, Glimmer loves you and I'm sure she would support you if she knew you felt this way." It felt weird to speak nicely of the little stick of dynamite, but she told Adora she would try. "Secondly, you aren't really a general

surgery kind of guy, so I dont think there would be much competition there."

"Y ou know, you really surprise me sometimes."

"Why' s that?"

"Y ou come off as aloof and callous, but that's not it at all. I mean dont get me wrong, youre not exactly the essence of sweetness and joy , but I feel like you get a bad rap from people who dont understand you."He tilted his head a bit and smiled. "Y ou probably dont want to hear this, but you and Glimmer are actually a lot alike."

Catra groaned. "Not you too,"she said. "Adora said the same thing the other day."

"Because we know Glimmer , and Adora knows you."She wasnt expecting her stomach to swoop the way it did and she looked away from him quickly . "Y ou know, for someone so observant, you really dont see what' s right in front of you."

Her eyes snapped back to his, her insides jumbled at the implication of his words, and she jumped at the sound of her pager:

"9 1R4

"W ell this has been fun,"she said, thankful for the break from his perceptive gaze. "Ill see you around, Arrow boy ."

"Hey , Catra,"he said before she could run away , "thank you, truly . Im glad you came and talked to me."

She didnt have a ton of time to think as she ran to the OR, but Catra already knew what he was talking about. She wasnt stupid, she knew the way she and Adora had been circling one another was going to end up withsomething, but they both were happy to ignore it for the time being. The odd limbo of *'we're not talking about it'* was comforting, no matter how it bode for the future.

"Catra!" Adora waved at her from the edge of the hall and she nearly tripped over her feet. "Are you going to OR-4 also?"

Had Adora's smile always dazzled like that? Of course it had, and she was thankfully getting used to it. "No, they called for free brownies in the breakroom and I was hurrying before Sparkles took them all."

A shoulder nudged her as they walked together. "Glimmer isn't even here today." Which Catra knew , as it was the reason she practically ambushed Bow earlier.

"Never doubt someone' s willingness to go to the extremes for brownies."

Adora threw her head back and laughed her deep, stupid laugh, and Catra was sure she lost some braincells at the sight of her stupid, chiseled jaw . What she wouldn't give to drag her lips acro– "I could make you brownies if you cared so much for them."

"Y ou can't bake."

"I can too!" They looked at each other through the corners of their eyes. "Okay maybe I can't, but it' s not from lack of effort."

'–Y ou really don't see what's right in front of you.' Oh she did, and that was part of the problem. Her feelings, if she let them be, would have her making very stupid decisions. "W e should study for our boards together." Kind of like that.

"W ait, really?" Adora stopped her with a soft hand on her forearm right before the scrub room.

"Y eah," Catra said with a shrug, trying to pass of f the anxiety that rippled through her. "I'm pretty sure we have them the same week, so we might as well."

Another dazzling smile that was threatening her legs' ability to remain vertical. "Okay , I'd like that."

Catra patted her hand and grinned. "Good, you'll need the help anyway." She grinned harder at the indignant grunt she got from Adora and pushed into the scrub room. "So what do you think this is going to be?"

Chapter End Notes

Because ignoring a chat is the best thing to do, right?

But hey, at least they're not arguing...

Medical time!
Group 4 Large Cell Anaplastic Medulloblastoma: (via St. Jude)
Medulloblastoma is the most common malignant brain tumor in children. Medulloblastoma begins in the cerebellum, an area in the back of the brain. Medulloblastoma is a cerebellar tumor . The cerebellum is found in the lower rear part of the brain, in a region known as the posterior fossa. Functions of the cerebellum include the control of movement, balance, posture, and coordination.
- group 4 large cell anaplastic is a rare form of medulloblastoma, but has a decent survival rate of 75% if it doesn't metastasize. The more instances of recurrence, however, raises the chance of metastases.

I just love Bow .

Hope you're all enjoying!

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

> Would like to just give a big thanks to my friend/beta/bane of my existence @BlueEyesAndHair for helping me out. Look for their comments, they throw wild shit in there.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora placed the drill guide on the tibial insertion of the ACL at the point where the wire would come out. "What would be the best way to study for the boards?"

Mara hardly even blinked as she waited for the guide wire to poke through. They had done ACL repairs so many times that it was like breathing at that point, so Adora felt okay chatting about something other than their patient's cut open knee. "Aren't your boards in four months? Shouldn't you have already been studying?"

"Of course I have been," she scoffed, "but you've already been through them, so I wanted to see if you had any pointers."

Mara gave her the shaver and let her clear out the remaining soft tissue through the tibia portal. "Kid, it's been like, a thousand years since I've done my boards. They're probably so different by now. Why don't you ask Hope? That woman knows everything."

"Your wife also has a photographic memory and has never had to study in her life. Honestly," Adora mused as she flexed the patient's knee to get a proper angle, "she's practically a computer."

"Trust me, I know," Mara laughed. "That's why she's the pathologist and not me. It's almost scary the amount of stuff she knows."

Adora stayed quiet as she drilled in the femoral wall plug. It had been some time since she noticed how much more Mara would let

her do in the OR, which was honestly the best way she learned. It was one thing to read how to do something, but to perform it with constant reassurance and supportive direction was incredible. It had been a shock to her after transferring from Horde, where they only got to read or watch, and never ask questions. If you didn't know, that was your problem. Mira acted as the assistant for the rest of the surgery, and Adora smiled as she did a test flex of the knee, knowing it was perfect.

"I don't think you're going to have a problem on your boards," the attending said as Adora began stitching up the incision. "But when I was getting ready for my boards, I asked Raz to let me borrow a bunch of old files so I could study those. Do you know who's in your board group?"

She nodded at the idea of Raz, hoping that being a friend of Mira's would be enough. "Catra and I are the only ones I know of for that week, and I know Glimmer and Scorpia are the week after us. I haven't really asked anyone else."

"So you and Catra are going to study together?"

There was no use denying what Mira was insinuating. "Yeah, we were walking to that cervical fracture 911 the other day and it sort of came up that we should work together on them."

"You could do worse, Catra is brilliant." They both pulled off their gloves and gowns and went to scrub out. "I love the chief, don't get me wrong, but you and Catra are the best residents we have seen in years. And I'm not just saying that because you're my favorite."

Adora smiled at her, knowing that a touch of favoritism hid behind her words no matter what, but she wasn't going to complain. Adora knew she was intelligent, and she worked her ass to the bone to be as good as she was, she couldn't deny that. But having someone recognize Catra's abilities too? That had been her dream for as long as she could remember, and it took everything in her not to sweep Mira into a hug.

"Catra is amazing," was all she agreed to. She could tell her attending knew Adora and Catra had something weird going on, but Mara didn't know about their past, not the terrible parts, anyway. Pretty much all of the senior staff knew about the horrors of Horde in some way, and they welcomed all who moved to Bright Moon with open, loving arms.

"She really is." Mara gave her a few pointers on exactly what to ask Razor for and they parted ways.

Later that night Adora paced in her kitchen, pulling lightly at her clothes as she waited for Catra to knock. It was stupid, really, how nervous she was for their little study session. She knew it was a good choice, the two of them worked together way better than she and Glimmer ever had, but it was just the fact that they were going to be alone, at Adora's, *alone.* Not in exercise clothes at the gym, not in scrubs at work, but in just normal, casual, *'my ex girlfriend who I left years ago but have always wanted is coming over and I'm pretty sure she still wants me but we haven't talked about it and now we're studying for one of the biggest certification tests of our lives'* clothes. It was fine, Adora was going to be okay. Maybe.

The knock on her door nearly knocked the wind out of her, and she braced herself for what she was going to find on the other side.

"Hey, Adora," Catra purred and held up a large, flat box. "I brought pizza."

She stood aside and held back a whine at whatever Catra had said, since she was a little too distracted by the woman's wet, slicked back hair and a crop top. A *crop top.*

Catra was absolutely trying to kill her.

Her brain was a bit fried from seeing so much soft skin, but that at least could be remedied. "Did you get onions on mine?"

"I thought you liked mushrooms and olives?"

"And I thought you cared about me."

Catra jutted out her hip and flipped open the box with gusto. "As if I could forget what got us through med school."

And just like that, they slipped into easy, unquestioned conversation, just as they always had been able to. Catra divvied up a slice of pesto and meatball for herself before pushing the entire box towards Adora, and they smiled.

"Alright so I know that I try not to give props to Bright Moon, but their food really is so much better than Fright's ever was."

Adora tried to save some of the cheese that threatened to slip off her slice with her mouth. "That's because it doesn't have the lingering taste of pollution."

Blue and yellow rested on her for a moment. "You know, you're right. I hadn't really thought of it that way. I always just assumed it was normal growing up, but when I came here, it's like I almost got sick from how good it all tasted."

"Have you tried the brownies from here?" Adora asked with a smile, loving the way Catra's face lit up.

"Only the ones from the cafeteria."

She walked over to the white bag she had on the counter and handed them over to Catra, who was already making grabby hands. "These are from this little bakery down the road, I don't think I've had anything as mouth watering—" *except you.*

"Do you have—"

She was already nodding. "I have mint n' chip and chocolate."

If the look she got in that moment hadn't already said enough, the way dark fingers ghosted on her forearm as Catra speed-walked to the freezer did. It was a subconscious action that Adora wasn't even

sure the woman knew about, but she had always slid fingertips across her arm when she was feeling extra happy. Expressing her feelings with words had never been Catra's speciality, so Adora had learned quickly what all of her body language meant, and if she was so bold as to say it, it was often meant only for her.

"Hey , why the fuck do you have your bowls so high up?"

Adora blinked out of her trance and stretched out the arm that still tingled, watching how the shorter woman was struggling to reach the upper shelf. "Maybe you should try being taller ."

Catra huffed and turned towards her. "Not all of us were gifted with the genetics of a giraffe."

"Are you saying I have a freakishly long neck?"

"I'm saying you're an idiot and need to put your things at a more manageable height."

"You're only like, two inches shorter than me, why are you being so dramatic?" Catra looked as if she was about to jump on the counter , so Adora walked over to save her from the trouble. "Here, just let me."

It had been wrong to assume Catra would move over enough to give her room, and Adora didn't even realize how close they were until she brought the bowls down. She stopped dead, Catra stopped dead, and if she breathed deep enough their chests would touch, so she stopped breathing altogether. At least this time it seemed as if the other woman was equally confused as to what to do, which made her feel better, since Adora always felt like the only one that was freaking out.

Catra finally blinked twice before stepping back and running a hand through her drying hair. "Brownies."

"Right, brownies."

–

"Hey , kiddo."

Elora gave her a little wave as she came into the room and checked all of the bags. "I was hoping I would see you today ."

"Oh yeah?" she said and looked over to see the girl nodding with her little smile.

"I told my friends about me being trans, and they're all so supportive. I knew they would be, but I was kind of scared, you know?"

"I'm so glad to hear that, El. What do they think about your name?"

She laughed, and it made Catra happy to see it. They had already done surgery to get most of El's tumor out, and the mix of recovery and chemotherapy had done a number on her fragile body. "They liked it for the most part, but felt like I should have been a bit more… unconventional." She finished with air quotes. "One of my friends said I should have picked Galadriel."

Catra smirked. "Honestly not a bad choice. She is *'Lady of the Wood,'* isn't she? And your last name is W ood."

"I didn't expect you to be a Lord of the Rings fan," she said with an impressed nod.

"Not particularly a fan, just one of my friends is obsessed." Scorpia cried every time and was afraid of Gollum, but it had always been a good distraction when she needed it.

"I'm the same. It' s cool, but I'm not so obsessed that I'd name myself after it. I like having a simple, unassum–"

She knew it was coming already and had the pan ready for Elora to hack into. "That' s it, kid, just let it out." Catra rechecked the charts and got her a wipe for her mouth. "Do you want some more nausea meds? They have you on a small dose right now ."

"No, Ill be okay for a bit," she said with a slight grimace and sat back. "That stuf f makes me diz z , and my head is already a little" – she pointed to her head the way she always did and Catra chuckled.

"Point taken," she said. "I dont have anywhere to be at the moment, do you want some company?" Catra faked a smile at her sweet nod and pulled up a chair. Elora's parents hardly ever had time to sit with her during treatments, they always had to work, and it broke her heart to know she was alone during such a scary time. "Y ou know, I think you actually might be able to help me. Im trying to change my last name, but I just cant think of anything that works for me."

Her little bald head tilted and Catra made a mental note to bring her a beanie, since it had been getting colder. Deep, brown eyes regarded her for a second and she wanted to melt at them. She was sure she'd buy El a pony if she asked for one. "Why do you want to change your last name?"

"I had a rough childhood," she said carefully , "and when I came to Bright M oon, I decided it was time to let go of my past. M y last name holds a lot of memories that Im not exactly excited to be reminded of when people say it. That's why I go by Dr . C."

"What is it, if you dont mind me asking?"

"W eaver."

El nodded and sat back against her chair for a second. "I think it depends on if you want to keep some remnants of it or if you want to just throw the entire thing away and start fresh."

"I dont care either way , really. Do you have any cool ideas that start with W?"

She hummed in thought. "Y ou know, I just dont think W's your letter; I feel like maybe a G." And that facial expression, Catra could not control. "What, did I say something wrong?"

"No," she said quickly and felt sweat prickle her back. "No, I ju—" her pager beeped and she checked it quickly. "Sorry, kid, I have to go." El looked sad, but nodded in understanding. "Keep thinking of names though? I trust you to think of some good ones. Someone from oncology should be here in a bit, so if you need more of the nausea meds, ask them, alright?"

As much as she liked the kid, Catra was happy to have gotten out at that point. There was no way El could have known about Adora and her stupid last name, but that didn't make her stomach flip any less. If there was anything Catra knew, it was that kids can be surprisingly intuitive if people just listened to them. She walked fast to the nurses station, needing something to do, and tested the name out.

Idiot.

"Ahh, Catra, there you are," Angella said and handed her a stack of old patient charts. "I need you to drop these off down in records, if you could."

"I feel like we definitely have people whose job this is."

"Are you currently treating a patient or in a surgery?"

She sighed. "No."

"Brilliant, all of your other colleagues are busy with something, so I am entrusting these to you." She smiled in a way that said she was being nice but there was no room for argument. "Everyone needs to do their fair share, and it will be good for you to get to know our records keeper."

Catra just saluted her and walked off, having already met the whacky records woman who honestly looked older than Etheria was, so she had a hard time trusting her, but things usually turned out alright. The elevator dinged and she held back a groan when she stepped in and Glimmer did not step out.

"Hey , Sparkles."

"Catra," she said with a nod. At least Horde Scum' was finally dropped, so she took that as a win.

But then she groaned again when she saw that Glimmer was going to the basement as well. Catra was going to hate it if they had to awkwardly walk to records together.

"Are you going to the morgue?" she asked, hopeful.

"No," she said with a scof f, but it wasnt directed at her . "I have to go get files from the crazy lady ."

"Okay so Im not the only one that thinks she' s off her rocker? Adora always says that I just need to mention Im a friend of Mra' and shell get what I need done, but then she starts talking about pies."

She saw the edge of Glimmer's lip rise. Was thatalmost a smile? It was a miracle. "No, I think Adora and Mra are the only ones that– what the fuck?" The elevator clattered to a stop and the doors jlted open just long enough to see they were stopped between two floors, and then shut again. "Oh I cannot be stuck on an elevator right now ."

"It' s probably just a missignal with the lines," she said and tried pushing some buttons to see if it would move, but the lights just flickered and dimmed a bit. "The elevators always got stuck at Horde Gen," she mused. "I spent most of a shift there once." It was one of the best shifts she ever had.

"Oh please dont say that to me right now ."

Catra turned to see Glimmer's eyes closed. "What, dont want to be stuck with me?" She meant it as a joke, but Glimmer was turning pale.

"No, Im claustrophobic."

"Oh, shit." She hadn't expected that. "Okay, it'll be okay. Let me call the chief, she can get maintenance to do something."

Glimmer just nodded and laid her head back against the wall.

'Catra?'

"Hey, Chief, sorry to bug you but I'm stuck on the elevator right now, it's between two floors and none of the buttons are working."

'Oh dear. We had a power outage from the storm and the generators usually only run essential power sources.'

"How are the elevators not essential, Angella? People needed to be transported to different floors. It's a hospital, not a farm.

'The elevators you're on are not in primary use for patient transport, I'm sorry. I will call maintenance, but with how bad the storm is, it might take them a while to get here.'

When the hell had it started storming? Actually, Catra wasn't even sure the last time she went outside, so that might be something. "Okay, but can you try and hurry it up a bit? Glimmer is in here with me and she's not looking too great."

Glimmer gave her a seething look and Catra just shrugged apologetically. *'Oh dear, she does not like confined spaces. I will try, but there's nothing we can do safely for the moment. I'm very sorry, Catra.'*

"No problem, thanks, Chief." She hung up and put all the files on the ground. "So I'm not going to sugar coat it, we might be in here for a while. Is there anything you do when you're in a situation like this?"

"I try my best not to get into these things," she said with a small smile. "You don't need to do anything for me, I'll be fine."

Catra beckoned to their confined space. "I mean, it's not like I'm going anywhere, so" she finished with a shrug.

"T alking helps," she said after a beat.

"Okay what do you want to talk about?" The only thing they had in common was Adora. And being a doctor of course, but that didn't sound like a fun conversation, they hated each other's specialty.

"T ell me about yourself," Glimmer said.

Leave it to Sparkles to be vague and generic. What was this, Intro to Public Speaking? "W ell what do you want to know?"

"Huh, I thought you were going to tell me to fuck of f."

Catra shook her head. "I was being serious when I said I was trying here. I might suck at it, but I really am trying. What do you want to know?"

Glimmer was already looking more relaxed. "Just like that? Full access pass, I can ask whatever?"

"I mean, don't ask about my kinks, but other than that." Glimmer 's face scrunched up and she laughed.

"Maybe another time, but thanks." They regarded one another for a second and Glimmer seemed to decide. "T ell me about how it was growing up with Adora."

She should have known it would be that. "Hasn't she already told you all of that stuff?"

"Y es and no," Glimmer said. "Adora holds back a lot because she thinks I won't understand what it was like. Just because I wasn't raised how you two were doesn't mean I can't still learn and care about what happened."

"It' s a long story," Catra said, and realized in that moment she had never, ever told anyone about her exceedingly irregular childhood, if she would even call it that.

"I think we have time," Glimmer sat down, patting the spot next to her.

As Catra sat down, she wondered how things had changed enough from wanting to hose off the little spitfire's glittery ambiance, to being able to sit next to her and actually speak about her past. Whatever it was, it felt nice. Like maybe she was getting another friend. She took a deep breath, wondering where to begin.

"I was dropped off on Weaver's doorstep right before I turned five," Catra began, eyes fixed on the slight crack in the elevator doors. "Adora was always so nice to me, and I never really understood it since well, I had never known what kindness was, so she scared me. She was so excited to have someone to play with, but I hated all of it. I was awful. It took me probably close to a year to warm up to her, but even then, I always wondered when Weaver was going to ship me off somewhere else. I don't even know why she kept me, honestly," Catra cautioned a glance at the woman next to her , happy to note that Glimmer wasn't looking at her , but just listening. "She had clearly favored Adora, since she had adopted her when she was a baby, but being the favorite was almost worse for her in a way. I learned quickly that if I fucked up, I'd get punished, and if I tried hard, I would still get punished for not being perfect, so why even try? But Adora? She just always had some weird ass people-pleasing tendencies that always made her strive for too much."

"She still kind of has that."

Catra huffed out a little laugh. "Yeah, I know, but it's not as bad as when we were kids, trust me." She drummed her fingers on her knee for a second. "We both struggled socially, because we were homeschooled, but Weaver let us get involved in local sports eventually, so that helped a lot. Adora was always such a meathead, she always took everything so seriously, and we found out our competitiveness made us better at everything. As we started to get older, Weaver really honed in on being a manipulative bitch. We had private tutors and such, because of course we only could have the

best, but everything was always just about who was better , and why the better student wasn't good enough.

"I really can't even explain her fucked up mind games, or how she could twist her words. It's like she was always lurking, even when she wasn't home. We called her Shadow Weaver when we were little," she said with a laugh. "We always were on our toes, and always had to be careful, or else she'd sneak up on you. It was like" she paused in thought, "one day we would be okay and she would treat me well, and then the next day it was like I was just a cockroach she couldn't even look at. For a while I would even try to do what I could to earn her praise, for her to be gentle with me. It makes me sick to think about it. I could never get a read on her, and I usually wound up worse off than I had been before. Adora always tried to protect me too, but then Weaver would show up in the shadows and tell me how worthless I am, how I was *distracting* Adora from her potential."

"That's ridiculous." The fire in her words made Catra smile.

"Tell me about it," she replied with a sigh. Somehow , their little box of forced isolation felt like the best place to get this all out. The way she would see Glimmer glance at her made Catra feel like she was actually listening, and that somehow she knew this would all stay between them. It was like their own little bonding moment, finally. "I really struggled with my feelings in our early teen years, but even after being yelled at or thrown in the cellar for being a little asshole, I would curl up at the end of Adora's bed, and we'd stay up all night whispering about" she turned her head away completely , "well, you know." Catra took a deep, steady breath. "We had never been shown any kind of consistent love, so it took us a while to realize just why we felt so protective about one another. Adora started to argue back as she got older, which I tried so hard to get her to not do, but she was so stubborn." She sighed, smiling just a little, "she's always had this complex, like it was her job to do anything to protect me, even if it hurt her. She even T-posed Weaver one day when she was

coming after me. Like, what was a little nine year old going to do against a whole adult?"

"Anything she could," Glimmer added, her fists balling a little. "That's just how Adora is, even if she doesn't know what to do, she still tries."

For so long, Catra wondered if being away from Fright City, if being away from *her* would have changed Adora; so many nights her skin crawled at the thought of seeing her again, of the chance that the person she had known for so long would be different. It took months for her to realize that Adora was still just the same, gorgeous idiot. She was still good to her, even if Catra knew she didn't deserve it – she had never deserved any of it. "Adora just wanted us to be treated equally," she said and brushed a hand through her hair, "but I knew that Weaver would never let that happen. I honestly still don't know why she was so hellbent on treating me like shit, and it still eats at me to know that I tried to get her to love me just as she loved Adora." She wanted to rip her hair out at the thought of being so stupid.

"Hey," Glimmer soothed and placed a hand on her wrist, "there's nothing wrong with a kid wanting affection from a parent, it's only natural. That is not your fault, Catra. Everyone deserves happiness."

Catra looked at her and realized that she had entirely missed the softness in her dark, nearly-purple eyes. She still had trouble accepting kindness from others, so she just bit the side of her cheek and nodded, thankful that Glimmer took the cue to remove her hand.

"It wasn't all bad, you know?" she steamrolled through her emotions. "She was a plastic surgeon, so she was gone all the time. We had our sports too, which really helped let us get our anger out more productively than fighting all the time. Things got better once we moved into our own place for college, too. Weaver had tried to keep Adora at home during undergrad, but by then, even Shadow Weaver was over her tactics. I could have cried the day she realized that all Weaver wanted from her was the prize of having such an intelligent

and powerful daughter.' She wanted her little protégé that she could parade around, and I was just the flesh-sack recipient for her endless barrage of psychosis.

"Being away from her, getting to just be us, was the greatest thing I had ever felt. Being away from her helped us realize," she stopped again, not able to say it aloud. "Well, I always knew, but Adora was an idiot, so she took some time. We were unstoppable during undergrad and through med school, our competitive natures drove us both nuts sometimes, but the results were incredible. We graduated top of our class, and we had this plan that we were going to run Horde Gen someday, just the two of us. When we started our internship year, Weaver practically ignored us, but it didn't even matter. It was all perfect. Or at least, I thought it was."

She could see Glimmer tilt her head from the corner of her eye. "And then Adora left." It was blatant, but not unkind, so Catra just nodded. It wasn't as if it was a secret. "Do you blame her?"

That, she didn't expect, and Catra snapped her head around to see Glimmer looking at her curiously. "No, I really don't," she said softly, holding that powerfully soft gaze. "I was hurt, it broke my heart that she left, but she asked me to go and it was my choice to stay. I just… *miss* her." Her ribs screamed at the slamming of her heart, the most profound sense of longing aching to get out, she could feel it scratching up her neck. She just wanted Adora. "I'll kill you if you ever tell anyone that."

"Oh, please." She said, and they both sat quietly for a moment. But then Glimmer was nodding, seemingly deep in thought. "Okay, so what are you going to do about this?"

Breathe in, four seconds, breathe out, four seconds. "I haven't really figured that out yet."

The wet click of her tongue echoed in the little chamber. "You are insufferable!" Glimmer groaned.

“Hey ,” Catra said, “I cant just forgive and forget all that time gone, Im not a perfect person by any means. None of my plans ever work well, and Adora and I are just starting to be able to talk without it ending up with me yelling or being pissed, so Im just trying to figure it all out, okay?” Her throat tensed and her body was instantly on edge, begging to get out of their confined space. “I dont even know why I told you all of that, so Id appreciate it if you gave me a bit more slack. Again, Im not great with people, and that even includes Adora.”

“Y oure right,” a hand came to rest on her forearm again and it took Catra all she had not to recoil. “Seriously , Catra, Im sorry . I might think the two of you are ridiculous, but I also know you went through things together that I will never understand.” They sat in a bit of silence, welcoming the soft static of the air to fill their ears instead of words, and Glimmer chuckled. “Y ou know, I kind of hate to admit it, but I think you and I are a lot alike.”

“Oh god, not you too,” Catra argued, entirely done with being likened to the glittery little menace.

“Oh hush, I just mean that I understand you in a way .” She gestured to the space between them. “Look at us, and how long it took to even talk. Were both so stubborn and quick to anger , and I really struggled when you got here. I was jealous, because I felt like you were going to take Adora away from Bow and me somehow.”

“What?” she asked, entirely gobsmacked.

Glimmer nodded. “Y ou came back without a warning, and I felt like Adora was just going to get lost in it all. I didnt trust you, and I wanted to protect her from more heartbreak. I dont think I realized that you both were just huge, heartbroken idiots that dont know how to just hash it out and get it over with. I still dont understand you guys, but that doesnt mean that I cant try .”

“That—” she was at a loss for words. “Thank you?”

"Don't thank me, just," she paused, "just promise me that you two will talk? The pining is killing me."

"I absolutely make no promises." As if on cue, the elevator blinked a few times and rattled before slowly descending once more.

"Oh thank god," Glimmer let out a deep breath and used the railing to pull herself up, letting out a laugh when she saw Catra's amused face. It had been the right choice, to talk like that, and they had seemingly both forgotten the predicament they had found themselves in. Glimmer offered her hand to help her up, and Catra took it. "Bow told me about the talk you two had, by the way," she said. "I wanted to thank you. I'm embarrassed I didn't realize why he had been acting differently, so I appreciate that you took the time to give him that push." Glimmer patted her shoulder affectionately. "You're really not so bad, Horde Scum."

"Aww, don't start getting mushy on me now, Sparkles." The elevator dinged their arrival and Catra swept down to grab the files on the floor.

"Adora?"

She snapped her head up way too quickly. *Smooth, idiot.* "What are you doing here?"

Glimmer slowly took the files from Catra's hands. "Here, I'll take care of these. I'll see you two later!" She passed by Adora and turned around to wink. *The little devil.*

"So," she drawled and held the door open, "you going up?"

Adora had the weirdest expression on her face, but walked in nonetheless. "How are you even alive right now?"

"What do you mean?"

"You just spent nearly two hours in an elevator with *Glimmer,"* she emphasized. "I thought you two would have murdered each other."

Catra just hummed. "She's not so bad, actually." She pointed a firm finger at Adora, "but don't ever tell her I said that."

She loved the way that stupid, perfect mouth fell open just a bit. "What did you two even do in here?"

"We talked," she replied and leaned against the railing, wondering what it would be like if the elevator gave out again. Would she and Adora get to have a nice little heart to heart then?

"What did you talk about?"

She threw her head back and laughed. Oh, Adora. "Wouldn't you like to know, Princess?"

Chapter End Notes

In this chapter: everyone is baby.

We love a good Glimmer/Catra bonding moment.

Medical stuff!
Adora and Mara do an ACL repair, there's videos on youtube if you're interested. Fun fact, orthopedics grosses me out and I have *not* had a fun time trying to write Adora as an ortho, but it do be like that.

Also Catra in crop tops is just *chef's kiss*

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

> OHHHH WE'RE HAEW AYTHERE, OHH!LWNG ON A prayer that these two idiots can do something.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra grabbed the case of beer from the back seat and shut her car door, wondering why the fuck she had even agreed to any of this. She stared at the house for a full minute, swallowing the phrases ‘cute’ and ‘utterly adorable,’ not wanting to let GlimBow know she was warming up to them and their sickeningly cute marriage. So what if she had imagined herself and Adora in a nice, modest house someday – a three-car garage, bikes and scooters out front, maybe a kid or two. A warm wave of something eased over her as she imagined the four of them, maybe a few more friends, all sitting in the backyard, chatting while their kids got up to no good.

She didn’t even realize she was smiling, and coughed to herself before doing one last check of her clothes. *‘Wear something snazzy!’* Glimmer had said without any extra information. What the fuck that meant, she didn’t know, but the pile of clothes she had left on her bed was a testament to her bubbling nerves. Catra smoothed down the lapel of her suit and sighed. She had already made it that far, she might as well go in.

Glimmer had cornered her a few days after their little jaunt in the elevator and invited her to an “official Best Friend’s Squad Game Night.” After many feigned vomit attacks, Catra agreed.

Bow answered the door with his big smile, and looked very much *not* snazzy in sweats and a crop top. “Yes, you made it!” He ushered her in, gave her a squeezing hug, which thankfully, wasn’t as powerful as Scorpia’s usually were, and took her coat. “We were worried that you might have forgotten, it was getting kind of late.”

"It's a bit icy out, I was driving slow," she lied. Her nervous stomach relaxed the moment she saw Adora, who was in a dress, busy reaching for paper plates from the pantry. "Hey, Adora."

Catra winced at the loud crack of a thick skull crashing into the pantry shelf. *Whoops.* "Catra?" she asked and extracted herself, face pink, eyes wide at the newest member of their party. "What are you doing here?" Adora looked incredible, her red dress just did things for her skin and shoulders, and Catra had to blink a few times to realign her thoughts.

"Well I was invited to a snazzy game night, but I think we've been duped." She couldn't even be annoyed, not with how stormy blue eyes were looking her up and down.

She watched Adora swallow twice, and Catra could feel her cheeks heat a little at the staring, but she didn't really care. "Yeah, you'd think I would have learned Glimmer's tactics by now."

"What about me?" Glimmer asked as she entered the kitchen, comfortably clad in sweatpants just like her husband, the little shit. "Oh, Catra, you look incredible."

"I know," she said, letting herself look Adora up and down once more before turning away. "Why are we dressed up and you two are all cozy?"

"Because it's funny," Glimmer said easily and handed her a beer from the case she brought before taking it to the fridge. Catra wondered once again why she agreed to go tonight, but then Adora walked by and touched her arm.

"Are you hungry?"

"Depends," Catra said and twisted off the cap to her beer. "Did you cook?"

Bow laughed. "Adora isn't allowed to cook here."

"I burn the rice one time," Catra heard her mumble and she nearly spit out her drink.

"How the hell did you burn rice?" The glower she received was just incredible, and her chest felt warm.

"Let's eat!" Adora diverted and handed her a plate. They all got busy dishing out the incredible smelling pasta concoction, and Catra nudged her arm a bit.

Catra lowered her voice, "I'm assuming they didn't tell you I was coming?" she asked Adora, who shook her head. "No." "If you're not comfortable, I can go. I don't want to interru–"

"No, please," Adora said quickly, her fingers ghosting the back of Catra's hand. "I'm happy you're here. Please stay."

There was a deep ringing in her ears and everything was muffled for a second.

"Catra?"

"Hmm?" she said distractedly, eyes drinking in the way Adora's arm flexed as she raised her fork to her mouth, and *god* that mouth of hers. "What happened?"

"I asked what game you wanted to play tonight." Bow asked, thankfully ignoring her blatant staring.

"Oh that's already decided," Glimmer cut in. "We're playing Monopoly."

Bow groaned, but Catra grinned. "Fine, but only if we use mine and Adora's rules."

"Which are?..."

She looked at Adora to see if she wanted to explain, but her head was tilted back as she downed the last of her beer. "So we do it

where if you buy anything from the first or third side of the board, the money goes to the bank, but the second or fourth strip goes into the middle;railroads go to the bank, and the utilities go into the middle. If you land on the Free Parking space, you get to collect whatever money was in the middle pile."

Bow and Glimmer looked at each other and shrugged. "Sounds kind of weird but alright."

They all took their food and drinks into the living room, and Catra stopped dead when the game board came out.

"Oh, you've got to be shitting me," she read the box again just to make sure. "You have a fucking *Twilight* Monopoly board? God, I bet you even shit confetti, Sparkles."

"I'll take that as a compliment," Glimmer sing-songed before starting to set it up. "And don't judge, we all had our phases."

"Yeah but at least I burned the evidence of mine," she muttered.

Adora barked out a laugh. "I know for a fact that's not true, you still have that *Spice Girls* shirt."

She glared. "I can't believe you'd sell me out like that so quickly."

"What?" She argued like the dumb jock she was. "We all had a thing for Sporty Spice at one point. It's nothing to be ashamed of."

"That's the damn truth," Glimmer agreed.

"Can we just play?"

Catra really missed board games, she missed the playful rivalry that allowed itself in the moment. She was competitive, of course, but the games made it a fun sort of competitive, and they all were laughing and screaming at one another as they battled for the spots.

"Alright," Bow said with a slap of his thighs, "I think I'm going to call it a night. There's no way I can come back from this."

"Aww come on!" Catra said, knowing full well that he really had no chance. It had been hours at that point, and Bow had spent more time keeping them from brawling than actually playing, but she loved it. The way they'd play, then stop to swap stories or do shots, had felt more normal and natural than she had felt in a very, very long time.

"No, it's definitely time for me to go," he said and stood up. Catra really needed to know where he got his crop top from, it was amazing. "Besides, I actually have work tomorrow."

That, she could understand.

"If you're going, I'll go too," Glimmer said with a grin aimed at Catra.

"You guys are losers," Adora said somewhat sloppily, having drunk the most out of all of them. "We're not even finished yet! We have to finish game night."

Glimmer gleamed. "You two are more than welcome to finish," the little demon offered sweetly. "The guest bedroom is made up if you need it." She finished with a wink and sauntered off, happily looping her arm into her husbands, and they giggled all the way down the hall.

"How rude of them," Adora huffed, and Catra looked over to see her pouting just a bit, and her stomach swooped. "We were having a good time."

Catra took a sip of her water, having stopped drinking long ago, and chuckled. "We can still finish, Adora." Her stomach swooped again when those big, drunk eyes locked onto hers. "I'm about to beat you anyway."

"No you're not," she said quickly and looked at the board. Catra could almost see how hard it was for her to strategize. "No, I'm

definitely going to win."

"Adora, you have never won when we play Monopoly."

"Shot my fault you're distracting."

Adora didn't even have the drunk decency to look up and notice the way those words pummeled every cell of her being, and Catra gulped a few times. "I am?"

Blue, glossy eyes finally found her own. "You are what?"

"Nothing," she said, a little deflated. Adora was drunk, she always said weird shit when she was drunk. "Look, I should probably go—"

"Wha-, no! Haven't you been drinking? S'not safe"…

She covered the hand that held down her own and laughed. "Adora, I stopped drinking hours ago." She fought the urge to drag her thumb across dry knuckles. "Do you want to stay here? Or I can drop you off at your place."

Adora tilted her head, brows furrowing slightly. "Driving doesn't sound fun, we should stay here."

And wake up to sleepy and sappy GlimBow? No thanks. "I can't, I didn't feed my cat before I left so I—"

"YOU HAVE A CAT?"

"Shhh—" Catra instinctively put a hand over Adora's mouth as she yelled. "You don't need to yell." She didn't realize how close they were, and she got lost in the single freckle that rested above a very pink cheek. Adora's hand pulled at her wrist, tongue darting out to wet her lips, and she looked back and forth between Catra's eyes.

"I need to meet them."

Which was how she found herself half-carrying a very heavy Adora down the hall to her apartment. It wasn't that the drunkass couldn't walk, she had always just been incredibly touchy once she had enough drinks in her, and Catra was starting to wonder how good of an idea it was to bring her there. Oh well. She had plenty of experience dealing with her like that during their undergrad years, so it was practically second nature to leave her against the wall while Catra grabbed the package that was in front of her door.

"Beep boop boop beep boop," Adora said in drunken determination as she pushed the buttons of the door lock.

"Ador," Catra started to say , but the keypad flashed green and the deadbolt twisted. "What the fuck?"

"Hmmm," Adora hummed with a loopy smile. "I knew it would be your favorite number."

Catra watched as she opened the door and wobbled in, looking completely ridiculous and perfect in her dress and a hoodie, once again completely oblivious to the fact that she had been setting fire to her soul. Adora found purchase on a random spot on the floor and started tapping the carpet.

"Psst psst! Here, kitty!"

She had to choke back a small sob at the sight of Adora being so soft and drunk and cute. None of her practiced and calculated planning could have ever prepared her for how badly Catra wanted her in that moment. No, not sex, she *wanted* Adora. She wanted those gooey eyes to look up at her, to pull her to the ground and wait for the little ball of fluff to run to them. She wanted to talk, to hear her stupid laugh and voice and feel the way the sounds of it make her heart race, how it always had. She wanted to sit together on the couch, ankles resting over knees as they both read, or watched a movie, or just existed in the world together . She wanted her. She wanted to build a fucking time machine so she could go back to the day Adora left and take her hand, to leave and go with her, and to

never have gone through any of that pain. She wanted to be able to just walk up and kiss her cheek, to slide their hands together and smile at the difference in their skin, how it felt, the warmth that radiated between them. Then, when their days faded into night, and they crawled into bed, she wanted to pull her close, face tucked perfectly into her neck and listen to the steady, strong rhythm of her heart.

She wanted Adora.

Something grabbed her ankle and Catra looked down to see that Adora had crawled over to her. "I don't see your cat, Catra, did you lose him?" Her head drooped to the side and she closed her eyes in a little laugh. "Cat, Catra, that's funny."

She swallowed thickly before taking a seat next to Adora, her stomach in knots with how she just wanted to wrap her up and put her to bed, but she pushed it aside for the moment. "He took a bit to warm up to me, so I'm not sure how he will react to you, so just be calm, alright?"

Adora threw her a sloppy set of finger guns, and Catra was sure her heart was near bursting. "Aye aye, captain."

"Fucking christ," she muttered under her breath. Catra clapped her hands lightly and made a few noises. "Mog, come here, boy. There's someone I want you to meet."

"You named him Mog?"

She heard the jingle of his collar and clapped again. "I don't know, it seemed right. I've never had a pet before, so I'm not entirely sure what I was supposed to do. Mog." He finally came shuffling down the hall and Adora squeezed her knee.

"Ohmygod," she said and made grabby hands at him. "Mog, come here, baby."

"Don't call him that," Catra tried, but shut up when the useless lump crawled right into Adora's lap. "What the fuck."

"Well aren't you gorgeous," Adora cooed and pet him somewhat awkwardly, but he positively preened.

"I cannot believe that he's being like this right now. He wouldn't even let me pet him for a week." Catra had found him in the alley behind her apartment complex one day, and just brought him in to keep him from the rain and to feed him a bit, but then the cat didn't want to leave. She left her front door open for hours at one point, but he just watched her and cleaned himself, so she kept him. It took a while, but they grew on each other. "Little traitor," she muttered to him. He flipped his head upside down so he could look at her and gave her the softest *'meow.'*

"Hairy baby," Adora said with a tired drawl, patting the top of Mog's head, and Catra tried not to laugh too hard.

"Right, let me get you some water and ibuprofen, drunk-o." Catra hopped up to get a cup for the both of them. She honestly needed a break from how cute it all was, and was lost in how easy it all felt when she felt a hand on her wrist.

"Catra—"

Somewhere, deep in the pits of her utterly useless brain, Catra knew that whatever Adora was planning to do as she took the glass from her hand to set it on the counter, was not going to be a good idea. Adora was drunk, she couldn't make a rational decision.

"Adora," she said and took a step back, but the hand on her was still tight and blue eyes blinked slowly. "You're drunk, you—wel—".

Her words were cut down when Adora pulled her close and wrapped around her in a warm, tight embrace.

And it was somehow much, much worse, because she *needed* it. Catra was frozen for a second before tight arms adjusted on her back, and then she gave in. What was the harm, right? Maybe Adora wouldn't even remember it in the morning, and she sank into that sweet, woodsy smell. Just like the night of the on-call room, Catra let herself be indulgent. She balled her hands in the fabric of Adora's sweatshirt, pulling her in just that much closer so she could feel her stomach move as they breathed. She rested into the sweet spot between the hood of Adora's jacket and her ponytail, not even caring how the wispy hairs tickled her nose.

She didn't want it to end, and yet for some reason, Adora was pulling away.

"You're crying."

"What? No I'm not." She definitely might have been, but Catra tried to rub the wetness away as quickly as she could. She was sure Adora didn't believe it, but her droopy eyes suggested she wasn't in the mood to argue. "Here, take the pills and drink your water."

She watched the line of her throat as she swallowed the pills and gulped the water, and okay, maybe she *did* want sex too, but that was so very, very far off.

"You're nice," Adora stated easily as she wiped her mouth off. "I wish everyone knew how nice you are."

"Okay, you need to get to bed now." Catra couldn't take any of it anymore.

"Can you take me home? I don't think I can walk that far."

The words fell from her mouth before she could even think. "You should just stay here." A shiver ran through her body and Catra tried to find reasons beyond just not being ready for her to leave yet. "Uhh, I mean, the roads were getting really icy out there and it's late so it wouldn't be very safe and I—"

"Okay ."

"Okay?"

Adora nodded with a sleepy, dopey smile. "I'll stay ."

–

She quickly accepted the fact that she died, as the bewitching smells and encompassing warmth around her were too perfect for any mortal world to accomplish. Even the brightness lent itself to the notion of the heavens.

But no, no there usually wasn't pain in the afterlife, that was quite the antithesis of it. Dead people don't get hangovers. And dead people also didn't have random cats sleeping on their chests.

Wait, what?

Adora gave all her might to opening her eyes, and was met with the bright blue eyes of a red, furry creature. It was no effort letting her lids slam back shut as she laid her throbbing head down.

'Meow'–

Why was there a cat on her chest? How did it get into her—wait, this was too bright to be her room, the blankets were too fluffy, and it all smelled like–

Oh god.

She sat upright, which sent the fluff ball flying with an exasperated hiss, and even Catra's cat sounded like her. When the fuck did Catra get a cat? How did Adora get into her room? *Why* was Adora in her room? Did they—no, no Catra wouldn't have ever let her do anything like that. She pressed her palms to her temples and groaned. God, her skull felt like a brick wall that was getting repeatedly obliterated by a wrecking ball, and her stomach was making dangerous

sounding gurgles that made her really, really hope Catra had a bathroom attached to the room.

In fact, where *was* Catra? Had they slept in the bed together again? It would explain that, while it felt like she was getting a K-Kod beaten through her brain stem, Adora felt more well rested than she had in a very, very long time (save for their one night in the tiny on-call room).

She let her eyes wander around the room, it wasnt big by any means, but the way the large window let in the early morning sun made it perfect, if not just a bit bright on her retinas for the moment. Most everything was white or gray, which surprised her since they had such dark and deep furnishings when she and Catra had lived together in Fright City, but then again, everything was dark and dingy in that decrepit place. There was a dresser that had a few knick-knacks on it, and a full length mirror to its left that, from her place on the bed, had a photo stuck into its frame. Adora moved to get a better look at it, recognizing the shades, but the cat jumped in her lap before she could stand.

"Hey there," she said with a laugh that only slightly ripped at her vocal cords. "What's your name?" She was pretty sure she remembered learning it, but not much of the night before was coming back to her besides the last two shots she pounded with Glimmer. Finding there was no name tag on the collar hidden in his gorgeous red fur, Adora cradled the sweet thing as she made for the mirror.

Her heart skipped a few beats, and she should have known seeing it would cause her already sketchy stomach to lurch, but Adora couldnt look away. It was the two of them, fake diplomas rolled up and held high as they cheered the end of med school. She remembered the cords around their necks being heavy, and Catra had given her so much flack for whining since she had one less cord than her *girlfriend,* but Adora had just kissed her stupid before asking someone to take their picture.

She honestly didn't even know Catra had it still, nor did she ever think that it would have a seemingly permanent residence in a place she knew the woman looked at everyday. Adora had left some of their shared items when she moved to Bright Moon, but with how mad Catra had been, she honestly thought it would have all been burned to a crisp. It made her heart constrict, and the warm kitty in her arms mewed softly, as if they knew she was in pain.

"It's okay, we'll be okay," she cooed and kissed their furry head, earning a roaring purr. It instantly made her feel lighter, and Adora ghosted her finger across Catra's pointy, bright smile before going to find the real thing.

She didn't find her out in the living space either, so Adora allowed herself the time to look around. In all their nights of studying together for the boards, they had always gone to her apartment or stayed a little longer at the hospital. Adora never argued, thinking that maybe Catra just didn't like where she lived, but if she were to be honest with herself, she really liked the place. The hall from the master bedroom led into a modest, open concept living space with large, bright windows just as the room had, and the light that fell through dark, sheen drapes made for an incredibly cozy ambiance. She could imagine them waking up and making a light breakfast;maybe spend the day cuddling on the couch or reading to each other like they used to.

Adora almost missed the dragging click of an automatic deadbolt, and she held the cat close as she swirled towards the door.

"Well well, good morning, Princess."

"You really need to use your indoor voice, Catra." She groaned as the feeling of her pounding hangover came over her again, and she stuffed her face in the fluff still completely content in her arms.

"Can you not make out with my cat, please?" A bag of food slammed onto the table and okay, cool, she wasn't going to be quiet then. Asshole.

"You're an awful person," which just made Catra grin as she shucked off her coat and hung it in the entry closet. "What's their name?" She asked, planting more kisses to the purring bucket of fur in her arms.

Catra gazed at her for a moment before throwing her head back and laughing. "How much of last night do you not remember?"

Her skin prickled in fear, had she done something? "Uhhh, the last thing I remember were those two Fireball shots I did with Glimmer."

"Oh boy." She held out a long object covered in paper. "Breakfast burrito? And his name is Melog."

"I don't know if I can eat anything," Adora said but took the food anyway. "My stomach is questionable right now."

"Eat the damn food, Adora."

She regrettably had to put down *Melog,* and Adora made a mental note to ask about that name later.

"So, what happened last night? Why why did I wake up in your bed?" Catra didn't say anything, she just looked at her while taking an enormous bite of her burrito, and Adora watched as she used her pinky to push a bit of egg back into her mouth. "Did I did we did– fuck stop laughing at me and tell me!"

"Fine, fine, sorry," she put her burrito down and wiped her hand on a napkin. "Nothing happened, you know I would never take advantage of you like that, have a little more faith in me."

Adora let out a long breath. She could really use some coffee right about now. "I know you wouldn't, I'm sorry. I just woke up in your bed and I have no idea how I got here and my body felt like it was going to explode so I didn't know if we were both drunk or something and I." Catra was laughing at her again, so she stopped and glared, and went to find some coffee.

"How would we have gotten here if we were both drunk?"

"Uber?"

Catra made a sound with her lips. "As if I'd ever let some random person drive us anywhere."

Adora noted the protective tone, and it made her headache *slightly* better, but just slightly. "Okay, so why am I here and not at my place?"

A warm hand took the bag of grounds from her and shooed her from the kitchen. "I mentioned that I needed to feed Mog and you then you screamed that you had to meet him." Catra flourished the scoop in her hand and started the pot. "It was actually pretty cute."

Adora watched pink rise to kiss dark cheeks and felt completely content in the scene. Mog had jumped back in her lap when she sat down, kneading gently at her thigh, and Catra busied herself with cups and creamer as to surely quell the heat on her face. It was perfect, and she could feel the smile nearly break her cheeks.

"Did we sleep together?" Ceramic crashed to the floor, and Adora winced at Mog's sharp nails puncturing her skin as he ran from the noise.

"What the shit, Adora? I already said nothing happened."

She stood up to help clean the shattered bits of the mug and she hoped Catra hadn't liked that one. "I didn't mean it like that, I just meant did we sleep in the same bed?"

"Stop!" Adora's step faltered at the sound, but Catra held up her hands in emphasis. "Stop, you could get cut, don't walk over here. I got it."

"But I made you drop it"…

"It's just a mug, I'm not worried about it." She tip-toed over to a tall cupboard and pulled out a broom. "I don't want you getting hurt, so go sit and eat your food."

She munched lightly, trying to find what felt different about the situation, and she watched silently as Catra swept everything up. "I'm sorry if you liked that mug," she said again once the broom was set back in the cupboard and Catra was walking over with their new cups.

"You don't have anything to apologize for, Adora." She cocked her head in invitation towards the couch along the wall of windows. "I honestly have a few in there that deserved to be dropped, so I'm really not worried about it. How's your head, do you want some more ibuprofen?"

Adora hummed a negative. "No, I just want to sit, I can get it later." The dim sunlight of a stormy, cloudy morning lit the side of Catra's face in the way that a first snowfall hits flower petals – soft, serene, utterly heartstopping. Adora watched in unabashed tranquility as Catra brought the mug to her lips, eyes closing as she tilted her head down to sip off the top few layers of coffee, and she didn't look away when those blue and yellow eyes settled on hers.

It was a slow and sweet morning, they chatted about the night before and random bits of work they both missed, and honestly had more coffee than was probably healthy for them, but they didn't care. She caught Catra's achingly soft smile a few times as Mog plopped into Adora's lap, sometimes trying to hide it by leaning over to pet him, but eventually, the smile stayed.

She wanted to stay.

And the way Catra eventually threw her feet up onto Adora's knees, Mog happily sleeping between them, she knew that the other woman didn't want her to go. It was something no one else really understood about the little spitfire, was how often she craved the simplicity of things, they both did. Maybe it was the fact they grew up

in a place where they never truly got to relax, or maybe their lives as surgeons begged for the reprieve of quiet at home, but the way they spent the morning had always been their ritual, their cool-down, their time to be none other than exactly who they needed to be for one another and themselves.

Adora was sure they both knew it too, she could see it in Catra's eyes how they were cautious and questioning, but at least allowing herself to just let it happen for the time being.

"To answer your question from earlier," Catra murmured, head back against the couch as they spent the afternoon taking mini-naps, "I did not sleep in the bed with you last night. I crashed on the couch."

"Why?" She sat up a little, "the bed was plenty big enough for the both of us.

"I don't know, I just didn't want you to wake up and freak out that I was there too. I figured if I wasn't there, then you wouldn't think we did something, but we see how well that went." They shared a small laugh, not wanting to disturb the gentle ease of the day, and Catra placed her arm behind her head for added support. "You did give me a hug last night though, and that was~~it~~ was really nice."

Adora would give her every hug her arms had available if it would keep her looking that happy. Every. Single. One.

Chapter End Notes

5k of fluff. I love them. They deserve fluff.

The monopoly rules are ones my best friend and I made up when we were...11?12? Have used them since.

Mog is a Somali Red cat, just with blue eyes. Here is an idea of him: https://www.dailypaws.com/cats-kittens/cat-

breeds/somali

Since there is no medical stuff in this chapter, allow me to introduce myself: my name is Noel (like Christmas, not like Dole) and I am currently in the throes of studying for the MCAT, which is the medical college admissions test here in America. I want to be an oncologist (possibly), and writing is my way to relax and clear my mind of the never ending shitshow that is working full time, going to school, and studying. I've had the rough idea for this fic for years, just needed the characters to satisfy it, which I just love all of them so much.

Thank you for coming to my tedtalk.

I hope you're enjoying!

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She blinked once, twice, and then a third time for good measure before reading the surgery board again.

9 Foraminotomy - SURGN - Attd: Cor ,A.Shera, MRes: Grayskull,A,W eaver,C.

10 Vertebroplasty - SURGN - Attd: Cor ,A,Shera, MRes: Grayskull,A,W eaver,C.

11 Chiari Decompression - SURGN - Attd: Cor ,A.Shera, MRes: Grayskull,A,W eaver,C.

What the fuck was going on? Since when did she have not one, but *three* scheduled surgeries in one day, and all scheduled with Catra?

Not that Adora was complaining, but something felt stinky about it all. She looked around to see if she could spot either the chief or Mara, but absolutely no one was paying her any mind. Who did this? Who knew? Something shiny gleamed through her peripheral and Adora followed.

"Glimmer!"

"Oh, good morning, Adora!"

Her sweet, innocent looking face couldn't fool her. "What did you do?" She followed her into the locker rooms and waited for an answer with hands securely fastened on her hips. "Well? And don't try and bullshit me, there's no way that I'd get this surgery lineup on a fluke."

Glimmer sighed and slipped into her surgery scrubs. "I just felt like you two needed a little extra time together, that's all."

Adora felt as if she was rubbing her temples far more often lately, and wondered if she would soon develop bald spots on her hairline where her fingers pressed. "Glimmer , I love you, but you really dont need to do that. I dont think I really want the chief knowing about… whatever it is Catra and I do or dont have."

"Honey ,"she said sweetly and grabbed Adora' s shoulders, "I'm pretty sure the dearly departed in the morgue can sense the tension between you two idiots. Mom doesnt care. If she felt as though you two couldnt handle each other in the OR, she would never have you together. You know that."Realistically , she did, but that didnt really help. Adora knew that she and Catra were essentially a power-duo in the OR, they had this sense of knowing exactly what each other needed, and the more and more they worked together, their talents flourished. "And besides, ortho and neuro work together often anyway so it was something you would have to get used to if you both wanted to stay after residency."

She sighed. "You're right, I guess I was just shocked. I usually get a little reprieve from her if we get scheduled surgery together."

"Do you want a reprieve from her?"

Glimmer smiled and kissed her cheek before leaving the locker room, and leaving Adora to her ever-growing thoughts. In the two or so weeks since the night she stayed at Catra's, things had been damn near perfect, or at least the closest they've been to normal, anyway. They studied as often as possible, went to the gym together (and actually talked) when they needed to let off steam, Catra came to another game night, and things were just normal.

But *they* were different. Since that slow, sleepy morning that drifted into late afternoon, which wound up with take-out dinner and cheesy rom-coms, things between them had changed. It was an unhurried, patient change; gazes lingered, touches ghosted wrists and thighs,

the space they once kept between them grew smaller, more charged. Something was building, and Adora wasnt really sure being hip-to-hip with Catra in an OR for most of their day was going to do very well for theirwhatever it was they had going on. She didnt have a choice, nor would she want to change it, because Glimmer was right –all she ever wanted to be was an arm' s length away from that seering, tan skin.

She wanted those eyes to rake over her, to look at her as if they knew exactly what the other was thinking. She wanted to feel her skin explode at the lightest touch, so purposefully accidental, when they crossed paths in the hallway. She wanted to make her laugh that deep, sqeaky laugh she always had, and then she wanted to kiss her until she couldnt breathe.

"Hey , Adora"–

She jmped so hard her back slammed into the lockers, and Catra raised a curious brow. "Oh, hey , Catra. I didnt see you there."

"I dont think you were seeing anything,"she said, laying a finger between Adora's eyebrows and pushing her head back into the lockers again. "Y ou were going cross-eyed."

"Right, jst thinking about"what?She didnt know , she hadnt had time to plan that far. "Anyway , did you see the board?"

Catra hummed and opened her locker. "Y ep, looks like wee stuck together today."And oh lovely , she was jst going to change right in front of her. That's fine. "If you go all cross-eyed while I get changed, Im going to call security ."

"Dont flatter yourself,"Adora said and pushed her away , taking a few breaths to steady herself before deciding to change as well. She hazarded a glance, face flushing slightly as Catra nearly lost her balance when she saw her stomach. "Should I be the one calling security?

"Shut up." She huffed a laugh as Catra's normal scrub top sailed into her face. "It's pretty cool we get to be with the chief and Mara all day, I think they're probably going to have us together like this while we can since we have our boards the same week."

That actually made a lot of sense, even if Adora knew that Glimmer's sneaky hands had been all over it. "I hadn't thought of it that way," she mused and looked over at the—finally—fully dressed woman. Catra looked a little distracted. "Hey, is something wrong?"

She shrugged. "Not really, it's just—I told you about that kid on my rounds, right? Elora, she has medulloblastoma?" Adora nodded, remembering her mentioning it vaguely once during a study session. "Well, she has a chemo treatment today at 2:00 and I won't be able to make it, I usually sit and talk to her and stuff." Catra sat down on the bench with a huff, so of course she had to join her, stopping short of holding her hand. "Her parents can rarely make it, they have to work and never have time for her—it kills me. She's just so young, and I know I can't judge anyone's parenting, but how can you just… not be there for your kid while they go through something like that? She's all alone."

"Hey," she soothed, ignoring her brain and taking Catra's hand anyway, "you're amazing for wanting to be there with her, you know that, right? I'm sure she would understand if you couldn't make it." Catra grunted lightly, but still slid her thumb across the junction of Adora's wrist. "I'm sure that the chief and Mara would understand if you wanted to step out a little early? Or maybe—" she thought of who else was there that day, "maybe you can have Scorpia go sit with her, and Glimmer is here too. We can make a schedule, so there's always someone to be there with Elora if her parents aren't there."

Adora worried that she said something wrong, but then Catra threw her arms around her neck, and yeah she could definitely get used to that. She pulled her in a little tighter, it not being a great angle since they were sitting down, but it didn't matter. Catra was warm, soft, and smelled like sterile scrubs with a hint of vanilla and rose. It drove her wild.

"You're such an idiot," Catra huffed into her neck.

She smiled as the woman finally pulled back. "Yeah, I am."

Catra shook her head as she stood up, offering her hand to help her up. "Thank you, Adora, really."

She said nothing back as they kept their hands laced together all the way to the door.

—

Catra knew she was being a dick, she really did, but she knew it to be part of her charm. Well, or at least she knew how to push Adora's buttons to get what she wanted, which was definitely the same thing.

It's just that, nothing was happening. Alright yeah sure, they were still studying together, had their normal gym routines, Catra gave in and started hanging out with the loser's friends, but there was still some sort of block between them. She had always been the more forward one, since Adora's skull was thicker than the root systems of Plumeria, but she didn't think it would be as hard as it had been to break through that gorgeous, perfect idiot's head that Catra *wanted* her.

Okay sure, she had said however long ago that she didn't want her just for the sex, but then Adora had to go and change in front of her (which Catra refused to accept she started), and seeing her godly toned stomach changed all of that. If she was being honest, that had never changed, the ways in which she wanted Adora, but there had been some interesting feelings to get through first. And she knew they were avoiding *the talk,* which was still a lingering issue, but that could be a problem for Future Catra. But right now? Right now she *really* liked the way Adora filled out her day scrubs, and when she wore that cute ass little red Patagonia jacket instead of her white coat, it turned her brain to cotton.

"Hold on, you have something on your jacket."Adora turned her head to look, but Catra's hand was already at the collar, picking off a non-existent piece of lint and letting her knuckles brush the base of her neck. She smiled as the little blonde hairs lifted in response, and she patted her shoulder for good measure. "Do you have anything fun today?

"We're literally right in front of the surgery board,"Adora replied, trying to keep her eyes trained on the charts she was reading. "You can look for yourself."

Catra hummed. "But you're right here"—she leaned in, pretending to look at the charts, "and things change."She relished in the way Adora's chest expanded, and figured that was enough. "Well I have to run, so have fun with your"—she glanced at the board—"total hip replacement."

She wasn't the only one doing anything, Adora had her moments as well, but they were far less subtle, and Catra was sure she wasn't trying to be as flagrant as she was. Her favorite thing was reaching for things above Catra's head, letting their bodies push together as if it had been an accident. It was cute, sure, but Adora had never been all that great at sensuality, or letting things build up slowly. She had never been great with plans, and had relied on dealing with things at the moment, but Catra? No, Catra loved to plan, she loved the chase, and she could easily spend days working Adora up to a point where she snapped.

It was getting close, she could feel how tense Adora would get with each word. At first it had just been a deep blush, or maybe a slight squirm, but now she was forcing herself to keep still. She was trying to maintain control.

Catra didn't want that.

Was it a great idea to try this at work? Certainly not, but she was only going for the buildup. They had their gym session the following day after studying, that's when she'd go in for the kill. Catra had

worked so hard on keeping herself calm at the gym, but it was getting increasingly hard to do so since Adora started to just wear a sports bra instead of her normal gym shirt. Watching her stomach contract in the way it did with each punch to the punching bag, sweat dripping down and over rippling muscles...she was impressed at her own restraint.

Skills lab was always a good way to get herself to calm down and focus on something other than Adora, and Catra was happy to see Entrapta in there, her entire arm digging into one of the machines as she muttered to herself.

"Hey , Entrapta!" Catra said and made her way to the sutures kit down the bench. Not that she really needed any practice, her stitching had always been impeccable, but she needed something mindless for a while. "How' s Emily?"

"Someone tried to recalibrate her sensors without consulting me and nearly fried her motherboard."

Catra had no idea what she was talking about, but she had spent enough time in the skills lab or in Entrapta's office to know that she could get her to talk if she asked about machines. "Is she going to be okay?"

"Of course she will," she said and slapped the metal shell of the centrifuge machine. "She' s stronger than that. Why are you working on sutures? Y ou have the steadiest hands on the entire surgical staff, except for the eldest Dr. Cor."

"I'm pretty sure Angella would rather you call her by her first name, or by 'chief,' Entrapta." The woman just tilted her head and Catra didn't feel like explaining how it wasn't nice to call someone 'old.' "And I want to do sutures because I need to take my mind of f things for a bit."

"Y ou mean you want to distract yourself from thinking about Dr. Grayskull, is that correct?"

"Yeah basically."

"Okay," was all she said before diving back into Emily. Catra had to laugh, because Entrapta was just so straightforward and to the point when it came to human interactions. She didn't grasp nuance or timing, but something about how she lacked the ability to do or say anything other than exactly how she felt had really grown on her.

"Have you ever dated anyone?" She asked after getting bored with how easy stitching was, and Entrapta didn't even stop what she was doing.

"Yes, I am currently in a relationship with Hordak."

"Who?"

"He works in the cafeteria."

Catra thought through all of the people, trying to remember. "The guy with the really intense green makeup?"

"Yes."

"Oh. How did that happen?"

"He noticed that I stopped eating when they got rid of the mini muffins and began to make his own for me. He is very kind."

Catra watched her place tiny screws into the plates of some electrical board and marveled at how easy Entrapta made it sound. He did something nice for her, so now they were dating. She wished it could only be so easy, and that just being nice would satisfy enough requirements to make for a stable relationship. But Entrapta was different than most, she was so straightforward, so of course that's how her personal life would be as well.

"That was very sweet of him, Entrapta."

The woman looked up from what she was doing, her reddish brown eyes being magnified by her goggles. "You can talk about your friend, if you would like."

'Friend,' oh Entrapta. But this was their normal routine, Catra would usually get bored and then just talk about her life and woes at Entrapta while the woman worked. So she ranted for a bit about how blind Adora could be sometimes, and about how she wanted her to be more observant sometimes, but also loved to watch things click in those gorgeous blue eyes of hers.

Catra was sure that she could stop talking completely, leave the room, and Entrapta wouldn't notice she was gone. It was okay, sometimes she didn't need someone to say anything back to her, and she was sure that the woman wouldn't be able to give her reasonable advice anyway.

Looking at her watch, Catra decided she would go find Adora and her ridiculous ponytail and do *something.* "Alright, Entrapta, I'll see you later then. Thanks for listening!"

"What?" Catra could hear her ask as the door shut behind her, and she just smiled.

After some time wandering the halls, she spotted Adora going into the supply room. *Perfect, time for some payback.* She hurried over, plugging the code in quickly, and relaxed herself.

"Hey, sorry, I just need—" Adora turned around, which was perfect, and Catra used her shoulder as leverage to push herself up higher, reaching for whatever she could on the top rack. The body below her stumbled back slightly, and she rolled with it. Strong hands caught her hips, and Catra felt like *she* was getting close to losing her control. "Thanks," she said and patted Adora's shoulder, pretending she didn't see how struck she was at their bodies together, and she sauntered off.

"What the fuck—"

She smiled at the choked words, and threw the patient gown she had just grabbed into the dirty laundry bin on her way to check the boards. Adora already finished her one scheduled surgery for the day, and Catra's was later after El's chemo treatment, so she tried to plan what else she was going to do.

Coffee was always a good option, and Catra could honestly use some food, since her body was burning a lot of calories trying to keep her damn heart in check. She was thankful to see Mermista and Seahawk in the breakroom, their banter had really grown on her over the weeks that she had actually started hanging out with Adora's friends. At first, Catra had been irritated by Seahawk's incessant need to sing, but she grew used to it. She had almost spit out her drink when she found out they were married, since they were so polar opposite, but it was cute. She smiled as she chatted with them, knowing that she was growing fond of pretty much everyone there.

It made her heart throb for Adora. She wanted to get wrecked by her, that much was sure, but in moments like these Catra couldn't help but be ridiculously soft, and she just wanted...she just wanted things to be okay.

She finished her food and slipped out of the room while Seahawk was deep in a very vibrant story, and went to sit and wait.

Adora eventually made her way back up the hall, completely engrossed in whatever she was reading on her phone, and Catra just smiled. Sometimes, less touching was better.

She waited, and oh god, she could wait for as long as she needed for those stormy blue eyes to look up at her. Catra could spend her whole life charting the curve of Adora's jawline, she could spend her whole life just looking at her, at the way she held herself when no one was looking. Adora had hated her body when they were young, she had never felt confident in any clothing besides a white shirt and jeans. She still wasn't really comfortable in a lot of things, but she found her style and had stuck to it. Catra was absolutely sure that

Adora could wear a mushroom on her head and a baggy poncho and she still would think she was the most transcendent being she had ever laid her eyes on.

Catra had been so lost in the way the ridge of her forearm moved as she texted that she completely missed Adora looking at her. Well, it had the desired effect, anyway. They locked eyes, the air between them was calm, easy, and she waited for it to ripple. It always did, eventually, and all it took was Adora swallowing, her jaw clenching in such a gorgeous way, and Catra raked her eyes down her body. By the time her eyes met blue again, Adora's nostrils were flaring. *Perfect.* She smirked, pushing herself off the edge of the nurses station, and walked a few steps backwards before turning around completely.

It was still a bit early to head down to oncology, but Catra was good at improvising.

She almost missed the sounds of heavy, grumpy steps behind her, and had no time to think before she was being pulled into the closest unlocked door.

"What are you doing?" Adora shut the door behind them, flipping on the light before pushing Catra back up against the wall, a firm hand planted next to her head.

"Well, I was walking down to oncolo–"

"Stop being a little brat, answer me."

Well, she was hoping for at least another day, but this could work. The empty on-call room Adora so luckily chose was dim, dimmer than most other rooms in the hospital, and she gazed at the heavy rise and fall of the chest in front of her.

Catra looked up, her eyes screaming *'kiss me,'* and she had a feeling for less than a fraction of a second that *maybe this wasn't a*

good idea, but then Adora's lips were warm, chapped, and utterly insistent on hers.

And *oh.*

A hand wrapped around the back of her neck, Adora's whole body forced her deeper into the wall behind her, and Catra damn near sobbed when that hot tongue met her own. They had finally broken their seal, the little dance they had been doing around each other for months, the longing they had both felt for years all culminated in tight hands and open, panting mouths. She slid her hands under Adora's scrub top, body on fire as she scraped her nails at the base of her back. She felt a heady groan reverb through her chest, so Catra did it again, completely lost in how she knew it was driving Adora mad. The hand that had been next to her head came down and crawled under her shirt, the feel of it pushing on her stomach sending shockwaves straight down, and she gave in. She gave in to anything and everything Adora wanted. She was hers.

"Come on," she gasped, grinding against the thigh that was in the very spot she needed it to be, but that wasn't the pressure she craved. Hot, calloused fingers started to push past the tie of her scrub pants, endlessly thankful that they were loose, and Catra *whimpered* into her lips. So close, so close–

The chime of her phone alarm stopped Adora's hand, and Catra was so close to chucking it through the window that she might cry.

Adora's head dropped to her shoulder, hand leaving her pants to squeeze at the jut of her hip while planting slow, wet kisses to her neck. "What is that for?"

Catra moaned at the sound of her gruff, lust drunk voice, and she pressed against the dimples she knew were just above Adora's ass. Her brain was a complete mess, and the shocks rippling through her body from the lips on her neck didn't help. "N-nothing," she stammered.

"Catra"—

No no no no, they were so close. "It's time for El's treatment, but she can wait."

Adora placed one more kiss below her ear and pushed herself away. "Go."

"No"—she followed her and tried to pull her in, but Adora held her wrists to stop her. "Maybe one of her parents came today."

Catra was not at all prepared for the look Adora gave her. Blue eyes gone entirely gray and muddled with want, she knew it well, and her body felt utterly bereft as the woman took another step back. "Catra, go."

The finality in Adora's tone was enough to kick her brain into gear, and Catra made a hasty retreat, pausing only as the door was almost closed to hear Adora groan and flop onto the bed.

Well, at least it wasn't just her.

She leaned against the wall to catch her breath, wondering why she had let herself get that bad on *company time.* While the results were exactly the direction she was hoping for, Catra could have smacked herself at how stupid it was. They could get fired. She took another deep breath before marching her desperately horny ass down to oncology.

The gym should be interesting tomorrow.

And of course Violet and Mark Woods weren't there, they rarely ever were, but Catra tried with all her might not to judge people's circumstances. She had never faced true poverty, though things were rough for a bit after Adora left, but she survived. She had a job to do, and judging the parents of a sick child was not part of her job description. Some people just had shit luck, and the Woods family seemed to be chock full of it.

“Hey , kiddo!” She called as she knocked and entered the room.

“Y ou look weird, what’s wrong with you?”

Was it rude to flip off a 12 year old? Probably . I think the proper reply is, hey , Catra! How’ s it going?”

“Where’ s the fun in that?”

She didnt have a point to make back, so she just checked her charts. Catra could already see El was getting more anemic, her normally dark skin was starting to get pale, but she wasnt loving her blood panels. She wasnt an oncologist by any means, but Catra was going to have to have a chat with them about getting some blood transfusions to help with her low WBC count.

“Why are you making that face?”

“I don't love your iron levels or white blood cell count, but they're perfectly within the limits of the treatment you're going through.” Elora had changed from that meek, shy girl to someone who wasnt afraid to speak her mind. Catra liked to think that she just needed an adult to listen to her and treat her with respect, so that’s what she always did.

El tilted her head a little bit, the pom of her beanie flopping with it. “So Im okay?”

Catra laughed and set the chart down. “T rust me, if I was worried about anything, I would already be barking orders.”

“Right,” she nodded and tried to sit herself up a little, but yelped when her wrist gave out.

“What’ s wrong?” Catra hurried over to the side that gave out. Chemo patients were notoriously fragile, and El hadnt been the healthiest kid before all of this in the first place. “What hurts?”

A soft sigh. "I hurt my wrist skateboarding the other day . It—dont think it's broken, since I can still move it, but I justdidnt want my parents to worry about another thing."

"El," she said softly , "a hurt wrist is completely dif ferent than what youre going through. It can be really dangerous to not get things treated properly when youre on such a strong regiment."

"I know , Im just already tired of getting poked and prodded that I hoped it would get better on its own."

"If you can move it, there' s a good chance you wont need any poking or prodding, but let me get an ortho down here to check it out anyway."

Those damn brown eyes tried to break through her tough exterior. "Cant you just look at it, Catra?"

She put a hand on the girl's shoulder and pulled out her phone. "I'm not that great with bones, honey, but I promise I will stay right here with you the whole time, okay?" She waited, and El eventually laid back and nodded, so she smiled and pushed the 'call' icon.

After the fourth ring, Catra was worried she wouldnt pick up.

'...Hello?' She wanted to laugh at her hesitancy, but she understood it. What other reason could she have for calling after what they just did?

"Hey , Adora, can you come down to onco-317? Elora hurt her wrist and I want you to take a look at it."

'Oh, yeah, sure, I'll be right down. Is she okay? Her panels weren't looking great the other day, so I can imagine she's not feeling the best.'

Her heart thudded heavily against her ribs. "How do you know about that?" She heard some papers rustle on the other end of the line and

Adora murmured a quick order to someone.

‘I told you we would all keep an eye on her.’ She was struck absolutely speechless, and probably wouldn't have trusted her voice anyway. *‘I’ll be down in 10, I’ll call radiology and have them bring a portable x-ray.’*

"Okay ."She hung up and swallowed the lump in her throat. Adora was just so damn good. Catra had no clue what she did to deserve her.

"So I talked to my parents some more about me being trans."

"Oh yeah?"Catra asked as she sat down on the stool next to El' s chair. "How'd it go?"

She see-sawed her hands, wincing at her weird wrist, but then just shrugged. "It went alright I guess. I still think they're kind of confused about it all, but are open to it, they just want to wait until I'm in remission to go ahead with everything."

Catra chose her words carefully. "That' s good, so have they been better about using your pronouns and name?"

El nodded. "A bit better , yeah, but they still mess up a lot. It's okay, it's something to me, I just"she gave her some time to collect her thoughts. "I'm worried what it will be like, to fully transition, you know? I already hate the medicine and surgeries I'm doing now , and thinking about it scares me. I'm a girl, I know that, but my body-my body just-feels weird. Am I making sense?"

"I have never felt what you feel, but I can understand what you mean."Catra adjusted in her seat, resting her elbows on her thighs. "Elora, you don't have to medically transition, do you understand that? It doesn't make you any less of a woman if you want to keep your body as it is. Every person has different feelings, and different bodies, and you are allowed to be who you want and do whatever you want with yours."While Catra had always been comfortable in

her own body, she knew plenty of people who weren't, and as such, knew that they all eventually found their own path. "You have a whole life to decide what feels right to you. Whatever makes you happy, that's all that matters."

"Thank you for telling me that," she said softly. "Would it be too much to ask for a hug? I could really use one right now."

When she had ever let a patient get so close to her heart, Catra didn't know, but she just smiled and sat on the edge of the bed as little arms wrapped around her neck. She tried to hold back the thoughts of whether Elora's parents hugged her enough, when there was a knock on the door.

She had almost forgotten that Adora was coming down, and Catra felt heat rise on the back of her neck when their eyes met.

"Elora, right?" Adora said as she walked over to shake her hand. "My name is Adora, Dr. C says you hurt your wrist?" El explained what happened and let Adora examine her wrist, but her eyes kept darting between the two of them, and Catra coughed lightly at the thought of how perceptive the little thing could be. "Alright so it looks like you have a greenstick fracture of your left radius, which we'll just need to put a cast on to let it heal properly and keep it from getting hurt any more than it is."

"Can I see it?" she asked.

Adora laughed and turned the machine towards them. "Of course. So it might be a little hard to see, but this line right here?" She pointed to a spot on the bone that Catra definitely would not have seen. "There is a little slip right there, and we call it a 'greenstick fracture' because it doesn't break completely through the bone, it bends just enough to split, sort of like when you break a twig but it doesn't completely come apart."

She leaned back and smiled at the picture of the two of them. It had been a while since she had seen Adora interact with a patient, and

she forgot how good she was at it.

"That's so cool!" El said and looked over at her, smirking when she caught Catra's gooey eyes.

"You think so?" She asked, shutting the X-ray machine down. "Maybe I can show you some other x-rays sometimes, I've saved scans of all my favorites."

Of course the nerd would. It made Catra's heart clench. "I would really like that."

Adora smiled at the two of them and excused herself to get a wrist brace until she could put an order in for an actual cast, and Catra busied herself with rechecking lines until she got back.

"Alright, kiddo," Adora said as she came back into the room and sat next to the bed. "This should help steady your wrist until we put a cast on, but I still want you to keep weight off of it as much as you can." She fastened the straps around the brace and patted it once she finished.

"Why did you pick ortho?" El asked as she twirled her arm slightly.

"Oh uhh—" Adora blinked a few times, "I guess I just find it interesting, and I've never really had the patience or delicate touch that Catra has to be a neurosurgeon."

No, Adora, wrong thing to say. "Interesting," Elora hummed. "Can I ask you something else?"

Adora looked over at Catra, who could only shrug. "Yeah, go for it."

"What's your last name?" Catra bit back a groan as Adora's brows furrowed. "Catra has been trying to find a new last name, so I've been helping her with ideas."

The kid was going to be the death of her, and it wasn't as if Adora didn't know she was still on the market for a new last name, but over

the months, it just hadn't really bothered her all that much. If she had thought about how her name sounded with Adora's last, well then, that was her business.

"My last name is Grayskull, but I didn't really put a whole lot of thought into it. It's sort of a mouthful, so I usually go by 'Gray.'"

She didn't think El's smile could get wider, but it did. "Grayskull, huh?" She eyed Catra, and they both knew what the other was thinking. *Damn it.* "And you said you picked that?"

Adora nodded. "Yep. My old last name held a lot of memories that weren't always the best to remember, so they suggested I change it when I moved here. My friend, Dr. Cor, sort of bullied me into picking something, so I just said the first thing I saw, which was a gray anatomy skull." She shrugged. "It's not that exciting of a story, I'm sorry."

Catra bit the side of her cheek, realizing that through all of their talks since being *able* to talk, she had never thought to ask her about it. Sure, she had asked that first day, but that was so long ago, and so much had changed since then.

"So what do you think we could get Catra to pick if we were to do that to her right now?" They smiled at each other, very menacing smiles, and she wondered what kind of weird shit they would come up with.

If she was being honest with herself, Adora could tell her to change her last name to Foley-catheter, and she probably would.

Alright, maybe not that bad, but it was close. She would do damn near anything to make her happy. El and Adora were looking to get revved up, but then both of their pagers blared.

ALL SURGICAL TEAM MEMBERS REPORT TO ARTIC

She and Adora looked at each other, never liking a full surgical 9 1, but it's what they did. "Raincheck on that idea, alright?" Adora said to El, and the girl just waved them out of her room.

"What do you think it is?" Catra asked as they ran down the hall.

Adora shook her head out of some thought and glanced over at her. "Well, it's snowing, so it's probably a car pileup."

"Not a bad guess," she offered. "But I'm going to say a collapsed building. Wanna race?"

It felt good to laugh and run together, just like they used to, but that could only last so long.

Chapter End Notes

Damn, we were so close to some smut...tragic.

Medical stuff!
Foraminotomy: (via Mount Sinai) Foraminotomy takes pressure off of the nerve coming out of your spinal column. This reduces any pain you were having. Foraminotomy can be performed on any level of the spine.

Vertebroplasty: (via Mayo Clinic) In vertebroplasty, bone cement is injected into fractured vertebrae to stabilize the spine and relieve pain. Vertebroplasty is an outpatient procedure for stabilizing compression fractures in the spine. Bone cement is injected into back bones (vertebrae) that have cracked or broken, often because of osteoporosis.

Chiari Decompression: (via Mayo Clinic again) Doctors usually treat symptomatic Chiari malformation with surgery. The goal is to stop the progression of changes in the anatomy of the brain and spinal canal, as well as ease or stabilize symptoms. When

successful, surgery can reduce pressure on the cerebellum and spinal cord and restore the normal flow of spinal fluid.

1. Shout out to Glimmer for getting these disasters into surgery all day together.
2. Shout out to Elora for being a tiny menace.
3. Shout out to Entrapta for being Entrapta.

I'm also pretty sure that Adora would need a radiologist to agree on her findings of the Greenstick Fracture, but we take artistic liberties here in Gay's Anatomy. Thank you.

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The emergency call hadnt been nearly as bad as the bridge collapse one a few months ago, but that had only been because Catra had been right. It was a structural collapse, and while it wasnt very inhabited, a lot of people died.

She groaned as she rolled over in her bed, thankful that she was able to get home and not have to sleep in an on-call room, but it had been restless sleep. She worried the whole afternoon and night yesterday about what happened with Adora. She knew the woman wanted her, that was for sure, but those blue eyes had hardly looked at her once they left Elora's room. Catra attested it to Adora being in the zone, which they all needed to be when major traumas were coming in, but that didnt make her feel any better .

With Melog bugging her for food and attention, and the knowledge that sleep was not her friend that day, Catra begrudgingly got out of bed. She started a pot of coffee and sleepily stared at the couch, wondering if maybe she could invite Adora over for a slow day again.

Speak of the devil, she thought, as the contact photo of that dumb, blonde idiot lit up her phone. She wondered for half a second why Adora would be calling at 8:33 in the morning, but picked up anyway.

"Hey , Adora."

'Hey, Catra, sorry if this is early'–

God, that morning voice just *did* things for her. "It' s cool, I've been up for like, three minutes. "What' s up?

She could hear her roll over in bed, and she wished she was there. *'I don't really feel like studying or going to the gym today…'* Catra's stomach fell out of her ass and she felt queasy. She fucked up– *'I was thinking that maybe you could come over instead. We could watch a movie or something…'*

Catra still wanted to vomit, but at least her heart was racing now. A movie? She could certainly do that. There was a lot of that weight in *'something,'* and while she didn't want to get her hopes up, it was still there. "Yeah, I'd like that. Do you want me to bring anything?"

A deep, sleepy morning stretch groaned through the phone and Adora sighed. *'Nope, just yourself. Come over around 4? I don't want you driving in the dark in the snow.'*

"Okay, dork, I'll see you later."

'Mmkay, bye, Catra.'

"Bye."

All Catra could think about on her way over later that afternoon was how Adora said *'I don't want you driving in the dark in the snow.'* She hadn't really caught it at first, but she smiled at the thought of her sleepy brain admitting she wanted her to stay the night. While she hoped that things would go the way they had the day before, she just loved spending time with Adora.

But, a girl had needs, and the way that those lips made her feel in the few minutes they made out was more than she had felt in years, and she needed it.

Catra knocked on her door, catching a whiff of something burning, and was worried what would meet her inside the door.

"Catra, hey!" Adora said quickly, trying to block her view of the inside of the apartment. "You're a little early."

"And you're about to catch the place on fire!" She pushed past her, earning a grunt, but Catra ran over and turned off the burner that housed something far more burnt than she expected it should be.

Sweet, ridiculous Adora. She wondered how the woman had made it this far in life without being able to cook without burning something. "I swear I looked away for five seconds and suddenly there was smoke everywhere." They both looked down into the pan, seeing the blackened vegetables, and Adora sighed. "I was just trying to make something nice."

"It was a valiant effort, really. At least it was only the veggies?" Catra looked around and couldn't see any other food, so she hoped there wasn't anything lingering in the oven. "Do you want to cook together? Or we could order some take-out?"

"I mean, I still have all the ingredients?"

Catra slipped off her jacket and hung it on the back of one of the bar stools before pushing up her sleeves. "Alright, let's see what you've got."

Somewhere around the point where they were grilling the chicken to throw in the stir fry, Catra realized that there wasn't anything Adora did that ever failed to make her mouth water. Just the way her brows furrowed in concentration as she flipped the chicken, eyes lighting up when she didn't drop the piece out of the pan. Her sweet, stupid smile coupled with the way she would always check to make sure she was doing something right had Catra's stomach swooping over and over again. They worked well as a team in the OR, so it only made sense that once Adora got the hang of things, they worked well in the kitchen too.

"This is close to done, do you want to go pick a movie and I'll get it all plated up?" Catra laughed to herself a bit when Adora walked off,

wondering how the fuck she had burnt she veggies earlier, but the results of it all turned out nicely. She scooped their food into two bowls and stole a piece of chicken to try, humming happily at how good it was, and then plopped herself on the couch.

She wasn't even sure what movie Adora had put on, because the woman had decided to scoot so close to her that their entire sides were touching, which meant that Adora's stupidly buff arm kept rubbing up against her, and Catra swore she saw her smirk a few times from the corner of her eyes. *That little shit.* If making dinner together hadn't already riled her up enough, being so close that she could smell Adora's shampoo and feel her soft skin rub up against her arm was.

"Are you finished?" She asked, standing with her bowl and pointing to the empty one in Adora's hand.

"I'm fine, I can do it"…

Catra reached down and took it from her anyway, knowing that blue eyes would follow the sway of her ass out to the kitchen. She looked back, smirking when she caught her staring. Adora had always loved every bit of her body, but she had a special relationship with Catra's backside that often came in handy when she wanted something.

The way those eyes stayed on her as she came to sit back down had Catra feeling extra bold. "Is this seat taken?" The bobble of Adora's throat as she gulped sent a shiver down her spine, and when her head slowly moved back and forth, she straddled those firm, hot thighs.

"Shit" Adora muttered, her hands pulling at the bend in her knees, and Catra had to take a steadying breath.

"Is this okay?" She would only ask once. If Adora wasn't ready , she would say it, she was always good about that. Catra watched her nod, and she put a finger under her chin, forcing their eyes to meet.

It took everything in her not to bring their lips together. "I need to hear you, Adora."

Hands pushed their way up her thighs and grasped tightly around her hips. "Yes, I want this."

Good girl. She leaned in slowly, hands moving to the back of Adora's neck to scratch lightly at the collar of her shirt. Catra let herself get lost in that single freckle, before fingertips were pressing impatiently into the back of her hips, and so she blew a light breath into her face, watching as blue eyes fluttered closed, and finally brought their lips together.

She knew Adora's lips like the back of her own hand, but that didn't stop her from appreciating every single soft spot, the warmth of them, the way her tongue slid so easily against each other's. It started as light, much lighter than what they had done in that on-call room, but they could do light and slow later – she needed – well, she needed to get absolutely wrecked, that's what she needed. Catra tilted her head, deepening the kiss expertly, the gasp from those perfect lips spurring her hips to grind down. The change of pace made her hot from her head to her toes, and when strong arms wrapped all the way around her stomach, pulling her in tight as they both begged for friction, Catra wanted to scream.

She needed control, usually, and if she would have her way, she'd already be naked with two fingers achingly deep in her, but Catra wanted to let Adora decide where they would go with it. She knew Adora wanted her, the way her needy hands were squeezing her ass and grinding up was an ever-living testament to that, but Catra needed her to *show* her how much she wanted it. It wasn't often that she allowed it, but for at least this once, Adora could call the shots.

The vulnerability of it made her shiver, and Catra ducked into the dip of Adora's collarbone to center herself, kissing her way around to all the places she knew best. It plagued her mind for months and months, *'what if Adora doesn't want me?'* It could still go that way, those stormy blue eyes could clear up and realize that it was a

mistake, and Catra would slink away into the recesses of her brain, never to return from the recoil of rejection.

Stop it! She had worked too fucking hard to let those thoughts control her, it was fucking stupid, especially since hands that had been damn near digging into her skin were now frantically pulling her shirt off.

"Is this okay?" Adora's eyes looked so lost, so very lost in the throes of her need, but she looked up to make sure Catra was still okay.

"It's more than okay," Catra forced herself to say. She pulled out the hair tie out of that damn blonde ponytail, breath hitching at the sight of it spilling over broad shoulders, and she leaned back to unclasp her bra, throwing it to god knows where.

"–fuck." Adora leaned in and wrapped her hot mouth around a nipple, rolling her tongue in a way that had Catra practically mewling, and her mind went completely blank besides the white hot heat radiating down between her legs. She wanted to let Adora set the pace, but she felt like she was going to explode, so it really would be nice if she could hurry up.

Catra's hips bucked as Adora worked on her nipples, hands slipping into the back of her pants and grabbing on to help a rhythm. She was a sputtering mess, and was already starting to get close, but she needed more. Catra threaded her fingers into loose hair, then pulled so Adora was looking up at her.

Face lost in lust, chest heaving. "God, you're so beautiful"–

Their lips crashed together again, needy and breathless. Hands started to move to the front of her sweats, and Catra's stomach flipped at the feeling. But they were too tight, and the angle was weird, and Adora broke off from her lips to look down, then back up, and back down again.

"Are you attached to these in any way?"

She would light them on fire right fucking then and there, even if they had cost more than a car, she couldn't care about anything else in the moment besides getting Adora's fingers in her as quick as possible.

"Fucking rip them."

Adora grunted and lifted her just a bit to reposition her further back, then wasted no time in finding the seam of Catra's infernal sweats, ripping them beyond repair. It made her heart skip a beat.

But then fingers were pushing her panties to the side, wasting no time at all as they slid so easily up and down through her wetness. "God, Catra," was all Adora could say before leaning in and taking a nipple into her mouth again.

Catra's legs were already shaking, and she grasped the back of the couch with everything she had when two fingers started to slowly, so god damn slowly, push into her. She moaned as they bottomed out, letting herself get lost in the way she stretched so perfectly over them, and her head fell back as Adora started to pull out. It was going to be hard to hold back her orgasm, but she wanted this to last. She *needed* it to last.

The first thrust back in, accompanied by that perfect drag out, had noises breaking through her mouth she didn't know she could make, and Catra tried to use her hand to keep herself quiet as Adora set a pace that matched the racing of her heart. A rough hand snatched her wrist, dragging it away, a thumb landing on her pulse point as Adora trailed soft bites and hot, open kisses up her chest and to her ear. "Don't do that."

Being silent had never been something she was good at, but as she rolled with the pumping of Adora's fingers, a hand dropping to help Catra's hips rock to the motion she set, it all made her want to scream. The tension building between her legs as fingers curled, and curled, and pressed in the spots only Adora had ever found was everything she didn't know she needed, and Catra pushed down all

the other feelings bubbling at the base of her throat to just relish in what was.

She was so close – well, she had been close since the moment that Adora pushed her panties to the side, but Catra was starting to see spots and she really, really needed that last little step.

"Ado" – she tried, her mouth stuck on the 'o' as fingers pumped harder. This was it, this was how she was going to die. Adora dragged her mouth to Catra's jaw , planting a kiss in that sweet spot just below it. "Adora" –

"Cum for me."

She stopped breathing entirely, her body needing every bit of power as her orgasm snapped through her, ripping every semblance of air or understanding from her as Catra's vision went completely blank. Her body continued to rock with the aftershocks of her orgasm, her brain somewhat registering the gentle coax of Adora's palm on her thigh, and Catra finally let her head fall onto the woman's shoulder as she let her lungs refill.

"I'm sorry about your pants."

Catra couldn't help it, she dug her face into Adora' s slightly sweaty neck and just started laughing. Of all the things she could have said after giving her one of the most mind-blowing orgasms of her life, that had not been one of the things she imagined. She laughed so hard she was almost crying, she could feel Adora giggling too, and it just felt so *right.*

Catra pushed herself up and wiped off a tear before slowly (and regretfully) extracting herself from Adora's warm lap. "Don't be, I have plenty of others" – *that I would let you rip too.* Blue eyes looked so forlorn as she stood up, and Catra absolutely hated their difference in dress, so she held out her hand.

"What are you doing?" Adora asked, letting herself be pulled to her feet.

She pulled her in close and slipped her hands under the front of Adora's shirt, letting herself finally feel that tantalizing skin of her abdomen, tracing over the ridges of the muscles that rippled at her touch. Catra moved to the hem of her shirt, lifting it a fraction of an inch. "I want to take your clothes off. Is that okay?"

"Please," she croaked, and Catra kissed her for good measure before pulling her shirt off in one fluid motion.

Catra already knew she didn't have a bra on, it would have been a hot day in the Kingdom of Snows if Adora wore a bra at home, but seeing her boobs like that, pink and perky while they rose with each steadying breath, it was serene. They stood there, just allowing themselves the time to look. Catra soaked in every single line of her, the way goosebumps would raise the baby blonde hairs before mellowing, how the slight mounds of ab muscles became visible when she exhaled, and every little mark she had charted throughout the years. Adora was perfect, so utterly perfect that she wished everyone could be as lucky as she felt to have those eyes stare at her the way they were.

She wasn't sure who moved first, but their bodies were absolutely on fire, mouths needing lips and tongue more than air, and Catra started to pull them backwards towards the bedroom. Somewhere along the way she lost the useless sweats, and by the third time the walls caught them from falling, Adora slid her hands to the back of Catra's thighs and lifted her, never breaking their kiss.

The door closed behind them and she gave one last swipe of her tongue before Catra leaned back, her hands running through blonde hair until she got a good enough hold to make Adora look at her. Not as if she needed to force that, but she'd never do herself the disservice of feeling those silky threads. "I need to taste you." There was no *want,* Catra physically **needed** to taste her, to run her tongue over every bit of her, and she might die if she didn't get the chance.

Alright, dying might be an over-exaggeration, but Catra did always have a flair for the dramatics.

Adora just pulled her in tighter, kissing her answer into welcoming lips, and then expertly rolled them onto the bed to where Catra wound up on top. She laughed into their kiss, because of course Adora would try and do some cool maneuver instead of putting her down and getting on the bed like a normal person. She was such an idiot, and Catra pushed one more hot, languid kiss on those perfect lips before moving to that jaw she had been dreaming about.

She felt a satisfied hum on her lips as she trailed open, wet kisses along Adora's jaw and down her neck, Catra's skin erupting where the back of fingers dragged against the sides of her stomach. Soft, explorative touches were threatening to make her lose focus of what she was trying to accomplish, but it felt too good to care. She ran her tongue one last time through the dip of Adora's collarbone before sitting up, missing the heat of their naked skin touching, but the sight below her emptied her brain of any thought.

Adora tried to raise herself up on her elbow, but Catra pushed her back down with a hand on her chest. She smiled at the annoyed grunt and let her hand glide over hot, wanting skin. She brought her other hand down below the edge of Adora's boob, moving both so that her thumbs would graze over perfect, pink nipples. Her skin was so soft, Catra could spend hours just touching every inch of her, feeling the difference on each part of her body. She pressed the pads of her fingers over the spaces between ribs, feeling the deep, stuttering breath that jumped at her touch, and Adora's hips started to become impatient below her.

"Please dont tease me right now."

Catra looked up to see Adora's eyes closed, her head pushing into the bed as she strained to be patient, and her heart slammed against her chest at the sight. While it hadnt been her intention at all to be the teasing bitch she very well knew herself to be, Catra held back a shiver at how needy Adora sounded. She leaned down, pressing one

kiss to her jaw and then another hotter , needier one to her lips, and started a quick descent down. Maybe later she would be able to go back and lavish all the spots she wanted to, but Catra scooted herself down, pulling at the front of Adora's sweats, kissing towards the patch of light brown hair she couldn't wait to be in.

Hips lifted into her face and she bit the soft skin lightly, earning a grunt from the woman who still had her damn eyes closed, and pulled at the sides. Catra threw the sweats and boxers unceremoniously behind her and settled easily between Adora's legs. Her stomach flipped at the sight, and she had to take a deep breath to control herself at the sight of Adora so perfectly naked, body tense with need. She wrapped her arms around strong thighs, settling her hands flat on that rigid stomach, and planted a single kiss to Adora's thigh before running her tongue clean through her center.

"Oh god," Adora choked, hands fisting quickly into the comforter , and Catra hummed in agreement.

Because *oh god,* had she missed how Adora tasted, her stuttering little breaths when Catra would push down on her stomach, the feel of her restless legs. She missed everything about her. Catra ran the flat of her tongue back and forth over her clit, the muscle memory being as easy as walking, and hands grabbed at the bend of her elbows to hold onto *something.* She circled around her clit, pushing her hands harder into Adora's stomach to keep her held down, and grinned at the whimper she received at a particularly good flick of her tongue.

She did it again and again, watching in wonder as Adora's head pushed back further into the bed, chest lifting up from the mattress from the feeling. "Shit—just like that."

Who would she be to deny anything to Adora? She asked not to be teased, and Catra was only so happy to oblige. She rolled her tongue again and again, feeling thighs squeeze her head the more she worked, but wouldn't stop until—

"I'm gonna—"

Catra felt stomach muscles contract and snap under her hands, and she held constant pressure through the waves of Adora's orgasm. Her head felt like it was about to burst from those thighs, but she couldn't care less about anything else in the world besides choppy, labored breath and the aftershocks that still fucked her face.

She was in so, *so* much trouble.

Cloudy blue eyes blinked open slowly, but didn't really seem to be that attached to the world, and Catra patted a thigh so Adora might relinquish the hold they had on her head. She crawled her way up that slightly sweaty body and tucked herself into her favorite part of Adora's neck, breath hitching when a hand ran through her hair. Catra closed her eyes at the touch, letting herself breath the intoxicating scent that was Adora and sex, she whispered a silent prayer that this wasn't going to be a one-time thing, that it wasn't a mistake.

She couldn't lose her again.

The hand in her hair left to weave small, lazy patterns over her skin, and Adora leaned down to place a kiss on Catra's forehead.

They laid together for a bit, just cuddled and happy, hands roaming without any sort of purpose or destination. She was almost beginning to doze off, perfectly comfortable in Adora's arms, when the woman raised up on her elbow. Catra wasn't sure she would ever get used to how pretty Adora was, how those soft eyes could make her melt by the way they looked at her. Adora brushed her hand through Catra's hair, playing with a few short strands before she leaned down and kissed her slowly, much more slowly than anything they had rushed earlier.

She lifted back up, placing one kiss to Catra's cheek, and smirked. "My turn?"

And jµst like that, Catra wasnt tired anymore.

–

It was still dark out, and Adora was confused for only a few seconds as to why her phone was going off in the middle of the night, but then she jµst groaned.

Damn it.

She felt the other body in the bed begin to stir, and all she wanted to do was to stay so perfectly wrapped up with Catra. Not only was she tired and sore from theirexertions the night before, but sleep jµst came so easily to her when those surprisingly strong arms were wrapped around her stomach. Adora tried to gingerly climb out of bed so as to not disturb Catra, and grabbed her phone to answer it outside her room.

Being on-call usually didnt bother her , and oftentimes nothing ever happened, but of course the one damn night that they actually–

Adora took a deep breath at the thought of the night before, her eyes closing as she let her head fall back against the wall, remembering all the different ways they had flipped each other around. She knew it had been coming for a while, the two of them had both been incredibly conspicuous with their flirting and touching, but the fact that it *happened* was still incredibly surprising to her. And dangerous.

It was very dangerous what they did.

She rubbed hands over her tired face and started a small pot of coffee to brew while she got ready. They had done it all wrong, and not that either of them knew what to do in a situation such as theirs, but Adora was sure that most people had a discussion about the skeletons of their past before, qite literally , ripping each other's clothes off. But then again, she and Catra had never done anything

normal, their entire life was abnormal to a fault, so they kind of had just been winging it.

Was it smart? Of course not, but things were good, and that was a start.

She turned on the hall light so she could have some light to get dressed, and Adora smiled at how cozy and completely rumpled Catra looked in her bed. It made her chest ache, and all she wanted to do was climb back in bed with her and spend the whole day making her gasp and whine.

Adora zipped up her coat and crawled onto the bed, planting kisses up a naked, warm arm. "Catra? Hey, I have to go."

The woman rolled over and stretched, her bleary eyes blinking open slowly. "What?"

She chuckled. "I have to go, but I wanted to say bye first."

Catra ran a hand up her arm, then wrapped it around her neck, and pulled Adora back down onto the bed with her. "No." Her morning voice was so gravely and cute. "You have today off."

I wish I did. Adora leaned up and kissed her neck, earning a happy, sleepy hum. "I'm unfortunately on-call today, and they just called me in." She smiled at the indignant whine and pulled Catra in closer. "Hopefully I won't have to stay all day, but I have to go."

"Fine."

She rolled out of the bed, but leaned down and kissed her with all that she could allow without entirely giving in. "I'll leave my spare key on the kitchen counter if you want to go, but you don't have to leave." Ever. "And we should we should probably talk about this later."

Blue and yellow blinked heavily, losing their bleariness, and Catra nodded. "Yeah, we probably should. Drive safe, okay?"

I will.”She leaned in, wanting one last kiss to hold her through the day, and almost forgot what she was doing as Catra slid her tongue against her lips. “You're a brat,”she said breathlessly .

Catra laid back down and snuggled into the comforter. “Aww, you're just saying that 'cause you like me.”

The thought of their morning interaction kept Adora going through the long day, and while it wasn't as long as any of her normal shifts, it still felt as if it took forever. Thankfully she was only needed for two, somewhat short, surgeries and hurried back to her apartment with a nervous stomach, wondering if Catra would still be there. She could have texted her, but that might just hurt worse.

When she opened the door, Adora was greeted by the sight of Catra at the kitchen table with a plate of something, legs clad in borrowed sweatpants from their alma mater, and it was practically second nature to walk over and kiss her.

Unsurprisingly, they never did get around to having that *talk.*

–

Adora hadn't quite decided yet if she liked the new study arrangement they had going on, which was mainly because she didn't have a choice in the matter . Glimmer and Scorpia had their surgical boards a week after she and Catra did, so realistically she knew it was helpful if they all got together and studied, but it also meant that she didn't get as much alone time as she wanted with Catra.

It was probably better for them anyway, since they really didn't get around to studying much more than each other’s bodies lately, but that was neither here nor there, really. Catra and Adora had been top of their classes for a reason, they were both brilliant and incredibly hard workers –there wasn't a whole lot more they needed to study in the grand scheme of things, but keeping up on material couldn't hurt.

The worst part about being forced to study with Glimmer and Scorpia was that no one had really found out their little secret yet, and it was getting progressively harder to maintain a calm and collected façade, especially when they were anywhere but work. At home they had allowed themselves to behave as they wished, and at work they maintained a perfect reputation, save for some savory ass grabs in storage rooms or empty halls. But once Glimmer had put her foot down and demanded they all work together, they had been switching between each other's homes, and it was hard to play along.

Catra was also exceedingly hellbent on pushing Adora's buttons, and had made it a game to get her as riled up as possible so that eventually when they were alone, she'd break. It really worked wonders, but she was on a mission that night for some reason. The amount of times she had gone into the kitchen to get something and bent over, or reached for a shelf high enough to lift up her damn crop top to the point where Adora could see she wasn't wearing a bra was killing her.

Scorpia was so sweet and focused that she didn't see any of it, but Glimmer kept having to flick her hand to get Adora to stop staring.

"You can eye-fuck her later," she hissed under her breath. "It's your turn for a case."

Adora shook her head out of the thoughts of kissing her way up the line of Catra's spine and picked a folder at random. "Raymond Kytis, a 39-year old male who presented to the emergency department with hematemesis, jaundice and hypotension with a blood pressure of 62/20mmHg. The patient was conscious with a medical history of esophageal varices secondary to alcoholic hepatitis, previous GI bleed with banding and thrombocytopenia. Hematemesis was preceded by nausea the previous day and EMS reported 1-1.5L of blood lost via emesis. Upon arrival, in addition to the severe hypotension, he was tachycardic with an oxygen saturation of 91% with 3L of oxygen through a nasal cannula. His arterial blood sample had a pH of 6.71, pCO2 of 101mmHg, pO2 of 64mmHg, bicarbonate

level of 10.3 mEq/L and base excess -28mEq/L." She looked up at Scorpia. "What is your diagnosis and plan of treatment?"

"Oh gosh, alright." She placed a hand on her chin and parsed through the information. "It's clearly hypovolemic shock," Adora nodded, "so I would immediately start two large bore IV's for 3L of saline, 2L with the LifeFlow on one and the other with 1L with a pressure bag."

"Alright," Adora nodded and looked at the file. "His BP rose to 195/58 and had a pulse-ox of 100%. His CBC panel came back with hemoglobin at 8.8g/dL and platelets at 23X10^9." She was sure that dating Bright Moon's trauma surgeon had helped Scorpia out immensely, as she used to be rather shy and somewhat of a pushover, but now she set her shoulders firm and got to work without losing an ounce of her sweetness. It was really nice to watch.

"For thrombocytopenia and anemia, I would treat with 10 units of RBC's, 1 unit of platelets, and 3 units of fresh frozen plasma. So long as he was stabilized without any further incidence of hypotension, we would proceed with surgery after a few days of monitoring to insert a transjugular intrahepatic portosystemic shunt to reduce portal hypertension."

Adora read through the remainder of the report and smiled. "Congratulations, Dr. Black, your patient made a full recovery and was discharged 4 days post-op."

Catra sauntered back to the couch and sat down marvelously close to Adora. "And then Dr. Black hugged her patient goodbye, rupturing the shunt and killing him instantly."

"Can we make it through one study session without you being a bitch?"

Pointy teeth gleaned as Catra grinned at Glimmer. "Maybe if you were as good as me, you wouldn't need these study sessions, Sparkles."

Adora just laid back into the couch and let them go at it, she was used to their snappy banter at this point and there was no use trying to stop it. The two spitfires had grown to like one another quite a bit lately, but that didn't mean they didn't butt heads as often as they could.

"I'm just sayin" Catra raised her hands in acquittal, "it's not my fault that you couldn't remember to give your patient prostaglandin for their nonocclusive mesenteric ischemia post thoracic-aortic aneurysm. That's like" – she laid back against the couch and wrapped her hand on the inside of Adora's thigh, "textbook."

It was so simple, so mindless of a maneuver that Catra didn't even realize why Glimmer had gasped, but Adora just closed her eyes and let out a long, whistling breath. "Fuck" –

The hand was gone in an instant, but the damage had been done. "OH. MY. GOD!"

"What?" Scorpia asked so innocently that Adora nearly laughed. "What happened?"

Glimmer positively squealed. "I KNEW THERE WAS SOMETHING GOING ON BETWEEN YOU TWO!"

"Alright, studying is over!" Catra jumped up and pulled the bouncing woman to her feet, trying to push her out. "This has been really nice, but it's time to go!" Glimmer might be short, but she was fast, and dodged around Catra's hands quickly.

"Fuck you, tell me everything."

"What's happening? We're only halfway through with the pile"…

"Bow owes me $100!" Glimmer blasted through Scorpia's increasingly confused face.

"You *bet* on us, Sparkles?"

"You're goddamn right I did, now tell me everything. Don't leave out a single detail."

"I feel like I'm missing something here," Scorpia said.

Adora pinched the bridge of her nose and stood up, patting Scorpia gently on the shoulder. "Glimmer , not now, okay?" It was her first day off in nearly a week, and all she had wanted that night in the first place was to lay around, watch movies, and kiss the words out of Catra's mouth. "Not tonight."

"Oh come on, this is so juicy!" Adora just shook her head, and thankfully, Glimmer seemed to give in.

She grabbed the stack of files on the coffee table. "Alright, but you know I *need* to know about this, right?" Adora nodded her head. "Right, Scorpia? Do you want to finish studying at my house? I think Bow made those chicken dumplings you like."

"That sounds great!"

Adora sighed and sat on the edge of the couch as Catra ushered them out of the apartment, Scorpia happily chattering away about Bow's cooking skills, and she looked up once the door finally shut.

"So... that happened." Catra said somewhat awkwardly . "I really didn't mean to do that, it' s just become second nature by now ."

"I know , trust me." Honestly , she was surprised that it hadn't been her that fucked up, since Adora struggled to keep her hands off the woman. "I just already wasn't in the mood to study tonight in the first place, so Glimmer's energy was just a bit much for me."

Catra came to a stop a little ways from her, still somewhat concerned about her mood. "I understand if you're upset with me, do you want me to go so you can rest?"

She answered that by grabbing the bottom of her shirt and pulling her in close. Adora rested her head on Catra's chest, letting the slow beat of her heart calm her down. "I'm not upset with you," she said and kissed the spot where her head had been before pulling her in closer, "and I don't want you to go, either. Do you want to just watch a movie or something?"

Deft fingers pulled her ponytail out and carded through her hair, she hummed at the touch. "That sounds nice."

She picked a movie at random and they cuddled onto the couch, Adora knowing full well that she would probably fall asleep first and have to be half-carried to the bed later, but she didn't care. Catra played with her hair while they watched, her skin going through wave after wave of goosebumps at the soft touch, and she sank deeper into their embrace.

It had been an interesting few weeks, really, and probably a large portion of Adora's exhaustion beyond being worked to the bone, studying, and trying to make time for the gym was that things were… weird between them. Not really *weird,* but it was sometimes hard to get a read on Catra's emotions, and she was sure that there were still bad feelings lingering from all of the shit that had happened. Adora didn't know how to bring it up, she didn't know what to say, because so often it was like those mismatched eyes were looking at her just like they used to, and she didn't want to ruin what they had going on.

Catra deserved better, she deserved the world, but Adora was afraid that if she brought it up, that if they talked about what transpired nearly four years ago now, that everything would crumble. It was stupid, she knew that she was being stupid, but she couldn't help it. Their boards were just two months away now, then once those were over, she would bring it up. They couldn't have any distractions right now, what they had was good.

But as those hands brushed so softly through her hair, she knew it wasn't as good as it could be, not entirely. They both held back,

Adora could see the pain in Catra's eyes sometimes when they were alone, and while she wanted to hold her close, to ask what was going on in her head, she couldn't. She hadn't earned that trust back, not entirely.

Besides that lingering, somewhat oppressive omen of the talk she knew they would have eventually – the one that might rip all the goodness apart again – they were having fun. Adora was getting better at the gym, having been able to throw Catra to the ground a few times, and she didn't know if it was because she was getting stronger, or she was finally able to relax around her. They spent a lot of time together beyond work and studying too, like driving out to neighboring towns to explore what they had to offer. Adora was making a mental note of the hikes she wanted to take Catra on once the snow melted and the mountains were stable. And then, on most days but not all, they'd lose themselves in each other, lips and fingers touching and pressing on every available spot. It was amazing, and she really wasn't ready for it to end.

Catra kissed her shoulder, and then the back of her head. "Come on, let's get you to bed before I have to carry you there."

She really, really didn't want it to end.

Chapter End Notes

About damn time, am I right?

Glimmer sees all.

Medical stuff!
Haematemesis: means vomiting blood
hypovolemic shock: an emergency condition in which severe blood or other fluid loss makes the heart unable to pump enough blood to the body. This type of shock can cause many organs to stop working.

Honestly that case is too long to explain so I'll just post the case study I sourced if you're interested. https://410medical.com/2020/12/09/case-summary-hypovolemic-shock-the-role-of-early-volume-resuscitation/

At any rate, they finally got somewhere, so I hope you enjoyed this and are ready for where the rest goes!

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I really don't know why you thought this time would be any different."

A soft grunt followed a bright laugh. "For—another grunt, "adventure!" Adora pushed just a bit into Sea Hawk's hand, hardly even trying as she watched a vein rise in his forehead. "I would set my boat on fire before I stopped trying to best you in a match!"

"You've already set two of our boats on fire." From the corner of her eye, Adora watched Ermista flip the page of a boating magazine, always seemingly bored with her husband's antics.

"You wound me, dearest, those were mechanical failures."

For what it was worth, Adora actually enjoyed the couple, once she had gotten used to their unbalanced banter. She didn't understand it in the beginning, how Sea Hawk was so lively and Ermista couldn't care less about anything, but they worked. Adora, for one, knew what it was like to understand someone who no one else could. She smiled at the quick raise in the woman's dark eyebrows, as if to say *'yeah, sure,'* to her husband.

And hey, they were an anesthesiologist and a plastic surgeon, they could probably afford a yacht, so who cared?

She flexed a little and pushed harder into his hand, inching closer to her side of the table, and he huffed. "While we're here," he said, "would you describe me as 'cool'?"

Adora's alarm went off on her phone, which almost gave him the leverage to get the upper hand, but she just cackled and slammed

his hand onto the table. "You're pretty cool, Sea Hawk, but I gotta run." She hopped up and stopped at the door , "you almost got me today!"

"Really?"

"No."

She laughed again and let the door to the break room close behind her, smiling at his call for a rematch. Sea Hawk had many talents, but arm wrestling was certainly not one of them. But who would Adora be if she didn't agree to a match every now and then? It was practically a free mini-workout.

She checked the boards quickly to see if she was needed in the immediate future, but was satisfied at not having rounds or a surgery for a few more hours. Catra wasn't there that day , so she wheeled herself around and headed towards oncology, thinking about the few surgeries on the board that would have interested her.

Walking along the halls, Adora had hardly noticed the change from being shocked to have Catra at Bright Moon, to wondering how the walls of the hospital had ever felt like home without being graced by the woman. The first few weeks had her heart stuttering whenever she would see that dark skin and short, dark hair, how it all had flipped her world upside down at every chance, how she ached in fear at walking around a corner, to be looked at with those eyes.

But now? Oh, now it all just seemed so natural, as if Catra had been here the whole time, and Adora wondered how she had happily walked anywhere in that hospital without Catra's bitchy snarl having graced most wards.

She wondered, heart pushing against her ribs, how she had ever functioned during those years apart. Adora woke up most mornings now, chin tickled by short, moppy hair, and legs poking into her own. The thought of it now made her stand taller, and it almost made her

hurt, the power of that feeling. Some mornings, when she had to be awake and Catra didn't, she felt like she might explode.

Adora came up to room 317 far quicker than she expected, and paused before pushing the handle. She had been in to check on Elora a few times, her plan of always having someone to at least poke their head in going rather smoothly, but the lump in her throat grew to be nearly unbearable sometimes. If there was a heaven, there was a special place in it for people who chose pediatrics as their profession, and an extra special place for pediatric oncologists. Adora was good at hitting things, like the mallets she used to beat in Kkods, she wasn't good at watching little kids fight battles that they didn't sign up for.

For Catra, she pepped herself up with a thick swallow, and knocked. "El? Hey, kiddo—oh, hello," she said to the woman sitting next to the bed. "I'm Dr. Gray, I'm doing rounds for Dr. C since she's not in today."

The woman looked slightly frazzled, and Adora figured that it was Elora's mom, finally. "It's nice to meet you, I'm Violet, Eli's—" she winced, "I'm sorry I'm El's mom."

Adora just nodded and shook her hand. She had listened to all of Catra's lamenting over her patient's parents, and while Catra had really never been the most patient or understanding human being, she really had to agree with her. Adora looked down at El, who had started off being small, but now was so pale and fragile, that it took everything not to have her heart break right then and there. She wasn't a parent, but she just couldn't imagine anything more important than her kid, and she would do whatever it took to be there with them in a case such as El's.

But then again, some people just didn't have the stomach for it, even parents who loved their child more than life. She tried not to judge, and looking at the woman who was just an adult version of her daughter, Adora could see how much she loved her, even if there

was a weird sort of wall put up. Being loved was as good of a start as ever, and she should know, because she had grown up without it.

"So how have you been feeling, kiddo?" Adora picked up her chart and checked the oncologist's notes.

"Just super," she replied with a fake smile and thumbs up. She liked to see her still joking, that was always a good sign. Chemo might have sapped all of the color, energy, and fat from El's body, but it hadn't stopped her from smiling and being an adorable, preteen drama queen. "Has Catra picked a last name yet?"

That got Adora to laugh, and she flipped the chart closed for a second. They hadn't had the chance to talk about the last name debacle since the day El needed a cast. Adora had been bullied into choosing, but Catra was particular about things, it wouldn't be so easy. "No, she hasn't. Dr. C is very meticulous about things. She doesn't make rash decisions."

"You both have very similar stories, I've been trying to figure out why. You're clearly not sisters—"

"Honey," El's mom stopped her, "you can't just butt into your doctors' personal lives like that, it's rude." While Adora didn't usually mind it, she was grateful for the little break. There wasn't exactly a need to tell a twelve year old her and Catra's pitiful life story. Violet's phone rang, and she whispered a quick 'sorry' before ducking out of the room.

"I'm sorry if that was too much, I just try to entertain myself when I'm all hooked up here."

Adora smiled in understanding. "I appreciate that, I just don't want to overstep Catra's boundaries, but I'd be happy to hear any ideas if you have them."

"Really?" She asked with a smile and sat up a bit. "Okay, so I looked up some medical stuff, since that's what you said you chose from.

What do you think about Glabella? Thoracic? Golgi? Marrow? Gastrocnemius?"

She barked out a laugh and set down the charts. "Did you find an anatomy book laying around or something?" El shrugged and Adora coughed her laugh away. "You seem to like 'G' names though, any reason?"

"I just get the feeling that 'G' is her letter."

"Interesting," she said and picked up the charts again to distract her cheeks. "But Gastrocnemius? I don't think she'd want to be a calf muscle."

"My sources are limited, there aren't a lot of great 'G' names out there. There's Glucose? Since she's sweet?"

Adora snorted and tried to turn it into a cough, which didn't work all that well. "That's not terrible, but you don't have to stick with medical stuff. Doctors do have lives outside of the hospital, you know."

"What do you guys do when you're not here?" El asked sweetly.

"Well, a few of us residents have our surgical boards soon, so most of our time is spent studying for those." She flipped through the pages of El's charts and clicked her tongue. "Your neck has been hurting?" she asked, reading her list of recent symptoms. *Neck pain, nausea, sleepiness, dizziness…*

El shrugged. "Yeah, I figured it's just because I haven't been sleeping well, even though I'm always tired. My oncologist said it's normal for chemo, since I'm prone to getting sick."

That wasn't entirely wrong, but Adora didn't like it. "Have they said anything about scheduling a lumbar puncture?"

"You're worried," she said flatly, head tilting to the side a bit.

"There' s no such thing as 'overly concerned' when it comes to onco," she brushed off, but those steady brown eyes didn't look impressed. "Also don't forget that I'm the broken bones lady , not an oncologist. I'm only going on what I remember from med school here." El raised an eyebrow, but didn't argue. "I have to run, alright? I'll talk to your onco, but I'm sure everything is fine. I'll see you around, alright, Elora?"

"Thanks, Adora," she said softly and waved, "tell Catra I say hi."

She was waving back and nearly ran full-bodied into El's mom on the way out of the room. "Oh, I'm so sorry!" Adora tried to hold the door open, but Violet shook her head and shut it.

"I wanted to say I'm sorry for earlier , for calling her Eli." She fiddled with her hands a bit, "I promise that my husband and I are trying our best to—"

"I understand," Adora said, placing a hand on her shoulder to stop her. "Y ou are all under a lot of stress with Elora's treatment, so thank you for doing what you can to understand her. Is there anything else I can do for you?" The woman shook her head, so she smiled and walked off, needing time to process everything.

She wondered what the Woods family did for work, what made them unable to take even a few hours off work to be there for their child. She wondered how they were raised, how they came to be the people who struggled to accept their daughter for who she was. They had gotten better with El, but it just baffled her how it was even a struggle. There couldn't have been that many years difference in Adora's age from theirs, but maybe it was just a regional thing. Fright had been a surprisingly open place for people to be whoever they wanted to be, which was probably because as long as you were a functioning body, no one gave a fuck about your name or gender. But by now, most places were accepting, so it was just confusing.

She sent a quick text to Catra about El' s charts, and heard a voice call behind her.

"Adora!" *Oh no.* She had been able to avoid Glimmer for a few days now, but her luck seemed to have run out. "Oh don't you dare try to run from me now!"

"I have to make a call, Glimmer ," she said without even turning around, hearing a whisper of footsteps before the woman flanked her.

Purple filled her vision as Glimmer rounded on her, hands up, forcing Adora to stop. "Nothing could be more important than you telling me what the fuck has been going on." She grabbed her biceps, nearly shaking her. "I can't believe you haven't told me anything! What happened? How long has this been going on? When did you finally have the talk? How did that go? How' s the sex?"

She groaned at the rapid fire of questions. "Glimmer"—

"Y ou haven't talked, have you?" Adora didn't know how she extrapolated that, but she really felt the need to rub her temples, but couldn't. "God, you two are such idiots, I swear . I'm just going to lock you in a room and"—

Both their pagers blared, which made Adora crave being locked in a room with Catra beyond anything else.

9 1SEGCAL*

They both nodded, knowing they'd talk later , and ran.

Angella was waiting for them at the nurses station with bright, neon yellow jumpsuits. "Good, you're together . A sinkhole opened on the corner of 2nd Street and Crimson Ave. There is a woman that has been trapped under debris, and you two will be repelled down into the pit to remove her."

They took the jumpsuits and eyed one another , having never been sent anywhere outside the confines of the hospital. "Chief," Glimmer started, "why can't they just lift the debris of f of her?"

"And where is Mira?" Adora added.

"Dr . Shera is already on her way there, and the debris is a 97 foot slab of asphalt, so she would die before they could move it." Angella stood up straighter, "time is of the essence, crush injuries are already dangerous enough, but amputating a leg in non-sterile conditions is exceedingly risky. You will need to work together, and with Dr. Shera, to ensure the safety and wellbeing of your patient. Understood?"

Her body carried itself out of the elevator and down the hall, Adora not even really realizing where she was until she came upon the keypad to the door. *This wasn't her apartment.* The hand that fumbled keys which wouldn't fit the lock was scratched and haphazardly wrapped in gauze, and she took a steadying breath before knocking on the door.

She would parse out later why it had been so natural to drive to Catra's instead of her own place, but for now, she was bone tired.

"Adora?" She tried to mumble an apology , but a firm hand dragged her inside. "Jesus, what happened to you?"

"Long day ," she wheezed.

Blue and yellow eyes looked utterly unamused, and Catra pulled her to the bathroom, pushing her to sit on the corner of the sink. "Did you get in a fight with a sidewalk or something?"

"Sort of," she replied, moving her legs so Catra could get her first aid kit from under the sink. "Mira, Glimmer and I had to go down into a sinkhole and save a lady who was being crushed by a slab of asphalt. I was lowered in fi–"

"You *what?"* Catra asked tightly, pausing as she unwrapped Adora's hand. "Why the fuck would you have to do that? There are search and rescue teams for a reason."

"Because we were going to have to amputate her leg first, which search and rescue can't do."

Catra didn't look satisfied, but busied herself with doing a better cleaning job than Adora had on all of her cuts. "Why didn't Mara and Perfuma go?"

"Mara was there, but Perfuma was already busy with other people they pulled from the sinkhole." She sucked in a breath at the sting of antiseptic on her wrist, catching the slight flinch in Catra's fingers.

"So why the hell are you all cut up then?"

"I'm trying to tell you that, but you keep interrupting me." They locked eyes, and all she wanted to do was crawl into bed with Catra, to feel her soft skin and relax to her patterned breathing. Adora watched her for a few moments as she nodded and got back to work. "They tried lowering me in first, but the jagged edge of the hole tore up the rope and it snapped, so I sort of tumbled the rest of the way in." If she had the energy, Adora might have laughed at Catra's scowl. "It was only a few feet," she tried to ease, "but asphalt is pretty unforgiving. They lowered some supplies in for me, so I got her into a C-collar while Mara tried to find a dif ferent spot to be lowered in from. It's uhh—" she paused, "it' s a very different feeling, you know? I'm used to having everything I need around me, and the patient up on a bed. But she was awake, in shock, and scared." She paused and watched Catra' s steady hand wipe her down. *"I* was scared."

She hadn't let herself show it earlier , and the adrenaline letdown from the entire situation was probably the reason she was so tired then. Catra just glanced up at her for a second, and Adora could see how she was seething, and was using the distraction of cleaning her wounds to keep her calm.

"Mara eventually was lowered in, but she forced Glimmer to stay up at the edge." She dove into the story , feeling the fatigue and stress of the day seep out of her skin with every soft stroke from Catra's hands. The woman stayed quiet, but reacted at all the appropriate

times, and finally found her way to the cut on Adora's cheek. "They airlifted her out, but Mara and I had to wait for them to come back and airlift us out because there was no way any ropes would be able to safely pull us up. It was—" she stopped to lean into the warm hand that cupped her uncut cheek. "It was a long day."

One thumb rubbed on antibacterial gel, while the other traced the line of her jaw. "You're an idiot."

Her eyes closed when Catra's hands left her to clean everything up. "I was doing my job."

"You're a surgeon, Adora, not a fucking mountaineer." She couldn't argue that, so she just hummed and smiled when fingers laced together with her own. "Come on, you need to be rinsed off."

She closed her eyes as Catra undressed her delicately, and Adora swayed at the feeling of fingertips against the scrapes all over her, and was directed easily into the shower. The water pressure made her hiss, but eventually it felt good, and she opened her eyes to see Catra grab the shampoo bottle. She was so pretty, so nice, and Adora just wanted to climb under Catra's soft sheets and sleep for a year. She didn't want Catra to be sad.

A warm towel was wrapped around her shoulders before Adora was led from the bathroom, and Melog danced around them, mewling softly before hopping on the bed. Catra dried her off gently before getting her dressed. She could have done it herself, she could have grabbed the extra clothes in the corner of the closet that she had left there over the last few weeks and got changed herself, but there was something different about the moment. Lips whispered over each scrape, lips that always made her heart race when they graced her body, but Adora just felt a bone-deep sort of contentment as Catra slid the clean shirt over her naked body.

Hands cupped her cheeks, and Adora stared into worried, mismatched eyes. "You are *never* doing something like that again."

She replied by pulling Catra into a tired, tight hug, knowing she would do whatever she could to never hear that scared clip in her voice. Adora let her mind swirl on the thoughts of how she ever survived exhausting days without having Catra to fall into at the end, and it made her pull tighter.

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‘There must have been moments even that afternoon when Daisy tumbled short of his dreams -- not through her own fault, but because of the colossal vitality of his illusion. It had gone beyond her, beyond everything. He had thrown himself into it with a creative passion, adding to it all the time, decking it out with every bright feather that drifted his way. No amount of fire or freshness can challenge what a man will store up in his ghostly heart.’

Behind her on the couch, Adora could hear Catra pause her reading and scoff, mumbling something to Melog on her lap, and she smiled as she stirred the rice in the pan. It had been a whirlwind week or so since she had gone through the sinkhole fiasco, which was followed by days of craziness at work and endless nights of studying with Glimmer and Scorpia. Catra had been less than friendly also, which had nothing to do with Adora and everything to do with Elora’s oncology team that didnt seem too worried about the little girl’ s increasing side effects of her treatment, but they were finally getting a day.

Rain pattered against the large windows as Catra resumed her reading, and Adora thought of Gatsby and his supposed love for Daisy. She could understand him, in a way, because she too had dreamed of her lost love for years, but the similarities ended there. It had nearly destroyed her to walk away from Catra those years ago, and not a day passed by without some thought of the woman or another, but there comes a point where one has to let things go and play out how they will.

The thing about Gatsby was that he relied too much on the perfect memory of someone, and his obsession allowed him to neglect the

fact that she was not his to try and win back anymore.

Adora tried, she really did try in the beginning to explain her side, to explain why she needed the change, but Catra made her decision – they both did. She had spent the majority of her life trying to protect Catra, to lead her in certain directions that would make her prosper, but there came a point where Adora couldn't make the decision for her, no matter how hard she tried. She had never been under the impression that there was only one person destined for the other, it was just statistically unlikely, but the days passed along with people that just never measured up to Catra.

And really, she never held onto a perfect vision of her, because Catra wasn't perfect, and that was a simple fact. She was bossy, bitchy, dramatic, a sore loser, she jumped to conclusions and hated to give people a chance, but also a lot of who Catra was as a person, was just a front. Yeah sure, she was all of those things and more, but she was also gentle and caring, she liked to pull her feet up when there was a scary part of a movie so monsters didn't eat her toes, and she had a soft spot for brownies. Catra might act like she didn't give a fuck about anyone, but she could read their body language as if it was her native tongue, and damn well knew what a person needed almost before they did. She loved old Disney movies and slow dancing to the sound of rain. She hated pants but was always cold so she used it as an excuse to cuddle. Her love language was touch, and it was mostly subconscious, because she had this block in her brain that people couldn't see her as weak, even though Adora eventually broke down that wall.

She wasn't perfect, but as her low, raspy voice lilted through the room, mixing in with the rain and Clair de Lune in the background, Adora didn't want anyone or anything else.

She turned off the burner and covered the pan, feeling a small swell of pride at the unburnt fried rice. Catra had taught her well, and it had been weeks since she burnt anything, but she couldn't care about food right now, not when there was that slice of imperfect perfection sitting on the couch.

"Dance with me," palm up, an easy invitation.

"What about our dinner?" Catra asked, letting herself be pulled off the couch.

Adora slipped her free hand around Catra's waist and started to sway them in slow circles. "We can reheat it if it gets cold, but I didn't want to miss this. It's your favorite song."

"You're an idiot," Catra tried, but the way her smile pushed her cheeks up to make small crinkles next to her eyes said everything. Adora pulled her in a little closer, needing to brush her thumb over those soft lines like a person crossing the Crimson Desert needed water.

And the way that Catra leaned into the touch had her thinking that maybe, just maybe, there *was* something perfect about her.

She leaned in and kissed her, no rush or expectations needed, it was just that the pink curve of them always called to her, wanting just as much attention as the rest of the woman's body. Adora leaned back, trailing a few light kisses along Catra's cheek, and arms wrapped around her neck as they just swayed. She sighed into their embrace, letting the sound of the music and rain wrap them in cozy. There was no rush for anything in the world at that moment, they had already gotten that out of their system earlier after the gym, and she smiled as Catra dug her face into her neck.

The sex had been—well, it had just been out of this world, really, and especially earlier after such a hellish few weeks, Catra had a lot of pent up frustrations, and pissed-off-Catra-sex was a different realm altogether. It was probably why she was so calm now, having worked off all her anger, but it was just part of the never ending ride that was the little devil's emotions. Adora rubbed soft circles on the bottom of her back, lived in the smell of her fresh shampoo, and was happy.

"We should go somewhere after our boards." Short hair tickled her jaw as a head dug into her neck further. "Catra?"

"Mmm?" She hummed.

"I said we should go somewhere after our boards, just get away for a while. Treat ourselves." She knew it was asking a lot, since they hadn't really talked about them or what they were doing, but Adora couldn't deny it sounded nice. Maybe they could finally hash it out there.

Catra leaned back, looking thoughtful. "Where would you want to go? I'm not going on another plane right after flying to Mystacor." She started to scratch the back of Adora's neck and she really just wanted to kiss her again so she did.

"Thaymor? I think they have some sort of festival in the early spring"…

"The one where everyone wears goat heads and flails around with ribbons? No thanks."

She huffed out a laugh. "Alright yeah I'll scratch that one off. Well, what about"–

"Mog hissed as fists banged on the door. "Hellooooo!" A voice rang.

"What the fuck" Catra murmured.

"I know you're in there, Adora, so get out from between her legs and open the door!"

"Glimmer" a voice hissed. She was going to kill them.

"What the fuck" she mirrored Catra's words, until it dawned on her. "Oh god, it's your turn for game night. I totally forgot."

Catra groaned and dropped her head to Adora's shoulder. "Make them go away."

"To the insistent knocking. "Catraaaa, I brought brownies!"

She perked up quickly, but then squinted. "Oh, she plays dirty—"

"They're not going to leave, you know." Even saying it, she tightened her hold around Catra's waist. She could have lived in their peaceful, barely-a-slow-dance moment for eons.

Catra sighed and unlocked her arms from around Adora's neck, mumbling something that sounded oddly like *'slow rain sex'* as she walked to open the door.

"No," Adora said as Glimmer bounded in the door with a full bottle of Fireball. "Catra and I work tomorrow, absolutely not."

Bow placed the Yahtzee box on the coffee table and went to rummage the cabinets for shot glasses. "Just do a fluids drip, you'll be fine."

"You'll be fine"— Catra mocked. "Last time you said that, Adora nearly broke her ankle!"

Glittery fingers pointed at her, "but she didn't."

"Not the point. Don't you think we should drink something more… distinguished? We're almost thirty."

Adora threw her head back and laughed. "Us? Distinguished?" She passed over an achingly full shot glass, grinning at Catra's wary face. "Well only have a little."

Which was another thing people said before things went to shit.

—

It wasn't her fault, really, and no one should have expected her to have acted otherwise. As Catra's hand pushed past the waistline of Adora's scrubs, a hand over her mouth to shut her up, there was nothing else she could do. She *had* to.

And honestly, she would blame it all on Adora.

Adora, who the night prior had left her apartment saying, *‘oh, I think I’m going to go get a haircut tomorrow.’*

Adora, who walked into Bright Mon Memorial Hospital that morning, seemingly oblivious to the utter devastation of Catra’s brain, with a fucking *undercut.*

And Catra was only human, and the second she saw her run a hand over that fucking buzzcut underneath her stupid ass ponytail, she lost any and all semblance of control. She had promised herself that they wouldnt do anything at work, she had made it a priority to not cross that line, but what was a girl to do.

The first chance she got, after everyone decided that they should bombard Adora to tell her how much they loved her new hair, Catra yanked her into an on-call room and locked the door behind them.

Sweet Adora, she was so confused at first, but then lips had quickly shut her up, and while Catra hadnt anticipated that it would go so far as her fingers dragging through a surprising amount of wetness, she wasnt fucking complaining. She kissed her way down Adora’s sturdy jaw, fingers dragging and swirling, and she had to put her free hand over that noisy mouth so they wouldnt get caught. Her lips followed the racing pulse, wishing she could leave a mark, but she had to have some control.

“Mmf—Adora huffed into Catra’s hand, and she split her fingers so she could talk. “So I take it you like the hair? I have been thinking about it for a while now, so I figu—”

Catra shut her up with her lips again and tasted the gasp as she pushed two fingers in. The angle was all wrong, since they were standing and still clothed, but she was trying her damndest. Adora clawed at her back as she pumped a few times, but it just wasnt working, and she smiled at the keening whine when she removed her fingers.

“Wha—why?”

She kissed her – hard – then spun Adora around and bent her over . Catra made quick work of the scrub pants, letting them fall over shaking knees, and paused right at her opening. "You're going to have to be quiet."

Adora laid her head on the door and looked at her through the corner of her eye, panting, and she gave a single small nod.

Catra draped herself over her back as she pushed in, eyes closing at the feeling of that tight, wet heat, and raked her nails up Adora's thigh. If she had the time, she would tease the everloving shit out of her. It was her favorite game, to get Adora to beg, but their situation was a bit too precarious to be so flippant, and she set a fast, firm rhythm that had the other woman biting her arm to keep quiet. And god, she didn't know what had come over her to do this, but the muffled, needy little moans coming out of Adora's perfect mouth made her want more and more.

"Touch yourself," she breathed into her ear , shivering at the gentle scrape of short hair on her cheek, and Adora obeyed. Sometimes she could get her to cum just through penetration, but they were on a time crunch, and it was honestly one of the hottest things, to watch her arm move in disjointed circles as she searched for a release. "Come on, let go" –

Adora bit her arm harder as her entire body shuttered, and Catra dragged her fingers slower as walls clamped around them. Even from behind, she was so beautiful, and watching a dazed smile crest her glowing face would never cease to make her heart clench.

She rubbed her free hand slowly over an ass cheek and down Adora's thigh, getting lost in the feeling of her light skin that was surprisingly squishy and supple for how strong she knew the muscles beneath were. Everything around her had melted away besides the choppy breaths of the woman in front of her, until her pager went off.

"Fuck," she gasped and looked at the offending black box. "I have to go."

"Mmmm," Adora hummed and melted into the door. "Is it a 911?"

Catra begrudgingly removed her fingers, making sure Adora was looking as she licked them clean, grinning at the stunned look. "No, but it's from Angella."

"Do you think," Adora tried, voice still lusty, "do you think she saw us?"

Her stomach twinged, she hadn't thought of that. "I doubt it, but I probably shouldn't keep her waiting." Catra couldn't help it, she smacked that wanting ass before being a lady and pulling the scrubs back up. She flipped Adora around, grasping her chin lightly, and they shared a smile before she kissed her slowly. "I definitely like the hair, by the way."

She stopped off at the bathroom to wash her hands, catching herself in the mirror, and she couldn't help but laugh at the fading pink on her cheeks from the minimal exertion. *Ridiculous,* she thought, and her stomach twinged again at the thought of Angella perhaps knowing what they had done. Catra wasn't exactly in the position to get fired, not when her boards were so close.

And to the few people she would admit it to, she *liked* it there.

Angella had her back turned to her once Catra finally made it to the nurses station. "You were looking for me?"

"Catra, yes," she turned around, thick folder in hand, eyes firm. She didn't like it. "Elora's tumor metastasized into her spinal cord, and we will be operating on Friday to remove what we can of the new tumors before upping her regimen."

She took the folder and looked through the new MRI's and bloodwork, needing something to help steady her from coming down

off of such a high before, but it almost made it worse. "I'm going to kill her onco," she muttered, scanning the list of testing that should have, in her opinion, been far more frequent.

Angella pointed a motherly finger at her. "No violence." Catra faked a smile to appease her. "I know how close you have gotten to El, and I admit that she has always had a place in my heart as well, but we both know the risks, don't we? There is always a chance of things going wrong, or going right, and all we can do is prepare for both. Are you able to do that?"

The question was flat, easy , but it held a weight behind it. *Can you handle this,* it meant. "Yes, I can do this."

"Good," the chief said and set her shoulders. "I've called her parents in to discuss the new treatment plans, so I will take care of her pre-op and paperwork. I will see you Friday."

As she watched the tall woman walk away, Catra wondered if it would have been easier to just not tell her until the day before. Now she had to sit on all of the knowledge for nearly a week, and she wasn't all that stellar with waiting.

Chapter End Notes

1. Don't fuck your coworkers at work.
2. I'd generally just say don't fuck your coworkers but that would be hypocritical since I'm writing everyone banging each other in this fic.
3. Fireball is not for people above age 24. Trust me on that.
4. Also don't listen to me and make your own bad decisions, we all learn differently.
5. Catra is baby and just wants Adora safe.
6. Do yourself a favor and listen to this:

https://open.spotify.com/episode/7uOcImpiHoC1El7sHmSpy?si=a7f6d564b64fd9

It's rain with Clair de Lune playing in the background and it's my favorite studying track.

7. I personally think "Catra Thoracic" sounds metal as fuck but...we shall see where it goes.

Medical stuff (though minimal)
Glabella - the front flat part of your forehead between your eyebrows.
Thoracic - your thoracic spine, which spans from the base of your neck to just under your rib cage.
Golgi - as in the golgi apparatus, a complex of vesicles and folded membranes within the cytoplasm of most eukaryotic cells, involved in secretion and intracellular transport.
Marrow - bone marrow, which is the spongy tissue on the inside of your bones, they produce blood cells.
Gastrocnemius - it's just the calf muscle.

Fun fact! Most anatomical terms that start with 'G' are horrendous, like gall bladder or gonads.

And yes, my love of brownies has spurred me to write Catra's love of brownies. Thank you.

Hope you're all enjoying!

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Unhinged. That might be a good word for it, for what she was feeling.

But then again, Adora wasnt quite sure she could think of anything else besides the slaps of skin and the throaty, broken grunts spilling from Catra's mouth as she thrusted into her again and again. Her hands splayed around tense thighs as she pulled that ass back into each drive of her hips, and her brain went absolutely foggy at the jggle from each movement.

Unhinged, ravenous, craved for that sweet skin and the way Catra's hands fisted harder into the sheets, trying to keep her body steady.

Adora smacked an already pink cheek, chest aflame at the moan it garnished, and she thought back to how they even got here.

They had fought;about what, she couldnt even remember , but her throat and neck could feel the frustration at wanting to lose her cool, but she was better than that. They had grown up from the days where they couldnt control their anger towards one another . Screaming wasnt healthy , but their tempers had already been high because of the day, then the stupid argument, and Catra had grabbed the strap from her bottom drawer and hucked it at Adora's face.

'Fucking do something about it then.'

And she had been only too happy to oblige, she needed to let off some steam, and she knew Catra could take it. It's why they worked so well. They matched par for par on damn near everything besides perhaps muscle structure, which was hardly a determinant, since Catra was able to match her weight at the gym too.

But Adora couldnt bother to think of any of that at the moment.

She gave one more resounding smack to the other ass cheek, then pulled out and flipped her over. She needed to see those wild eyes. Adora paused the dildo at her entrance, searching for an answer to her silent qestion, and Catra replied by grasping her hips and doing the jb herself.

Fully hilted, she wasted no time pulling out a little and driving back in. Her thighs were starting to ache, but seeing those mismatched eyes flutter closed at the motion gave her all the fuel she could ever need. Adora lifted herself up on her knees, threw tan legs over her shoulders, using the leverage to drive in deeper and deeper. Catra pressed her hands to the headboard, mouth shut tight as she tried to arch into the movements.

It was frustrating, not being able to touch all of her at the same time, and Adora grunted as she tilted her hips a different way and thrusted hard.

"God, right there, Ado-"

Her ears crackled at the gasp, and she hit that angle again and again, every cell in her body being fueled by Catra's dazed whimpers. Adora moved her hand tighter around a thigh, using her thumb to rub nearly frantic circles around Catra's clit as she thrusted over and over. A hand wrapped around her wrist, holding it steady, and she could see it coming. She watched firm stomach muscles tighten even more, and blunt nails dug into her wrist as Catra's body arched, a single gasp was all that could be heard before her entire body jlted through her orgasm.

Adora gently slid the legs off her shoulders and rubbed her hands up until she was cupping the back of a very sweaty neck. How long had they been at this now? T wo hours? Three? They were going to be so sore, but it was worth it. She dragged her mouth between the valley of pert boobs, smiling into the sternum that ached with each

expanding breath, and nipped between ribs. Breathing slowed, and Adora placed one last kiss to her shoulder before leaning back up.

Her brain misfired at the burning look that was waiting for her, and she had no time to think before legs wrapped around her hips.

"Are you sure?"

Catra looked annoyed and damn near growled. "Just shut up and fuck me."

Wish? Granted.

She pulled out further than needed, but she needed room to work, and legs loosened just a bit from her hips before Adora rolled and dove back in. Unhinged, crazed, unrelenting, she rolled and thrusted over and over, chest tightening in her own annoyance at trying to prove a point. What point? She didn't really know , but blue and yellow eyes stayed open, and she couldn't help but get lost in their burn.

Her mouth parted, needing all the room for air she could get as nails started to scrape at her back. The pain felt so good, felt so grounding, and she felt her eyes begin to close, wanting to get lost in the feeling.

"Look at me," a firm voice said, and her eyes snapped open to see Catra's filled with mirth.

It annoyed her.

She pushed her weight onto one hand as the other wrapped around the front of a jumping throat, her thumb and fingers tightening ever so slightly, waiting to get the approval. Their eyes met, an unspoken bolt of electricity swirling between them, and Catra nodded.

This, they hadn't done in years.

She increased the pressure slowly, her hips never stopping, and Catra's eyes nearly rolled back in her head as the corners of her mouth inched up. She was so beautiful, it was almost hard to watch her like this. *Almost.*

Adora could feel the moans under her fingers, the vibrations sending hot spikes down her spine, and she fucked her harder.

In turn, Catra smiled harder.

And when those eyes opened up to look at her, it hit her like a freight train.

Adora had fallen in love with her, all over again.

As blunt nails dug deeper into her hips, mismatched eyes flickering with something her muddled, love-blown brain couldnt comprehend just then, she was sure Catra knew it too.

She couldnt stand to look any longer , or else her mouth would betray her, and Adora ducked her head into the crook of her neck and sucked at a sensitive spot. "Come on, Catra," she whispered, fingers tightening more. "Cum for me." For *me.*

Adora felt Catra's body arch up into hers, felt her name rasp like a cry through tight vocal cords, and removed her hand to pepper kisses along the spot where her fingers had pressed.

Hands pulled at her hips, bucking into the padding of the strap as Catra tried to ride out her orgasm, and Adora felt like she was on fire.

The body beneath her finally relaxed, so Adora slowly pulled out, unlatched and threw the strap somewhere with a thud, and rolled back over to look at her. She could feel Catra's eyes watching, so she started at her feet, trailing her way up to ankles and shins that flexed under her gaze. She reached down, ghosting a finger over a light, small scar that the woman had received one day in the woods

when they were eleven. They both had plenty of scars from when they were young, and she edged the line of all the ones she could see, brushing over Catra's soft, dark hair. That was somewhere they differed, Adora couldn't stand the feel of hair on her legs and had shaved since she could steal Weaver's razors, but Catra never did. Her legs were slightly patchy from years of clothing rubbing against spots, and she traced around those too.

By the time she reached mid thigh, her palm pushing against taut muscles, Adora could see her squirm. It wasn't her intention, she was honestly surprised that Catra would want another, but she wasn't ready, she still wanted to explore. Adora's fingers walked up to the jut of her hip, thumb brushing over the scar from the appendectomy Catra got on her sixteenth birthday, and was about to dip into her belly button when a hand caught her wrist.

They locked eyes, the hair on the back of Adora's neck raising at the look she was given, and she held Catra's gaze as the woman pushed her hand down, down through wet curls, and Catra nodded with a deep breath as her fingers pressed at her entrance.

She might actually die, Adora decided.

As she pressed two fingers in, she dropped her head on Catra's shoulder, her throat closing at the feel of the tight heat welcoming her home. She felt a cheek rest on her temple, and Adora had to take a deep breath before pulling out and pushing back in.

Slow, she was going so slow, she needed to feel every curve and ridge as she thrusted deep inside, moving to the rhythm soft breaths were puffing against her ear. Adora felt Catra shift slightly, moving her leg to get better access, and she kissed her shoulder before lifting herself back up and locking eyes once more.

Love, love, love, love–

The love she had never left. It had permeated every cell of her being since the day Adora had come to her senses and realized, but

looking down, watching those eyes try and stay open, stay on hers, as Catra's chest caught over and over with each drag of her fingersAdora wondered how she had been so stupid. She had fallen in love with her the moment her helmet came off that day, had fallen in love with her each time Catra stole her food, had fallen in love with her every time their eyes met, and each time she'd glare and walk away.

Adora had been falling in love with her over and over, every single day.

Suddenly woozy from the feeling of it, she leaned down and pressed a kiss to Catra's chest, just above her heart, and kissed again when she felt the walls clench around her fingers.

Hands grabbed her face and brought her in for a kiss, messy and needy, but utterly perfect. Catra was perfect. Adora tilted her head and deepened it, never stopping her rhythm, and her hips dug into the mattress to match. Gasping breaths on her lips quickened, and Adora pressed her palm against Catra's clit, swallowing a short mewl at the new pressure, lifting back just an inch so she could watch her come apart in her hands.

She was nearly sick with love as those eyes slammed shut, Catra's mouth dropping open in a small 'o' as she clenched around Adora' s perfectly curled fingers. She held and pushed slowly, working her through each wave of her orgasm, and she had to swallow the bile that rose when her brain decided to think about *what if.*

What if this all was just sex for Catra? What if it was just a way to burn off steam, and the years missed and passed couldn't ever be forgivenwhat would she do then?

Catra pulled her fingers out and rested Adora's hand over her quaking stomach, the edges of that spitfire mouth raising slightly as she controlled her breathing, and maybe, just maybe, it wasn't just sex.

When they got cleaned up and dressed for bed, and Catra didnt make her go home but instead curled up into her favorite spot in Adora’s neck, her brain decided to calm down.

Sometime later, when breaths became patterned at her collarbone, Adora pressed a kiss to the top of Catra’s wet hair.

I love you.”

–

Mental checklists were always so long when the last thing you wanted to be doing was make a mental checklist.

But seeing as how Catra had forgotten everything that morning as she rushed from her apartment, a mental checklist was necessary. Not that she really needed much, since she had a locker that was full of backup essentials, but Catra liked her routine. Her eyes gazed over the surgery board again, her stomach churning at the thing that kept bringing her back.

Craniotomy & Resection - SEGA - Attd: Cor ,A, Senes,C,Res: W eaver,C,Black,S.

She felt slightly more at ease seeing Scorpia up there with her, they worked well together and Catra wasnt positive she would be able to deal with a different resident, especially since the oncologist would be in there, and she wasnt particularly thrilled with him. How the hell he was so lax about retesting on a group 4 large cell anaplastic medulloblastoma was beyond her, but that was in the past now, and Catra had to be 100% present for Elora today . She couldnt let her opinions get in the way of doing her job to the best of her ability .

Not that she would be doing much in the surgery, even if she wanted to, it was too risky a procedure to let a nearly 5th year resident really dive into, but still. She had to be there, mentally.

"Hey , Catra!" So much for her brain being there. Since when did Adora wear her hair down? And were those new scrub pants, because they really did things for— "you left your phone on the bathroom sink."

"Shit, thank you," she stuf fed her phone in her pocket and held back the feeling of wanting to kiss her pink cheek. Adora held out the coffee cup in her other hand, and Catra tilted her head.

"I didn't smell you making cof fee, so I figured you might need one"— she finished with a nonchalant shrug.

Catra hid her smile behind the edge of her cup as she took a sip, giving a happy hum to the delicious caffeine. "W ait, you went to *Rebellion's Roast?"* she asked, smiling at the dorky sword logo from one of their favorite spots a spot that happened to be on the opposite side of town.

Adora started to pull her hair into its usual ponytail and looked at the board. "I didn't have to be here for a while after you left, and you sort of aren't quiet when you get ready , so I was up." She finished with another shrug, tightening her pony and feeling to make sure her little poof was perfect. "Is it good?"

"Hmm?" She asked, entirely missing the question, fingers itching to play with her undercut. "Oh yeah, mhmm"— which seemed to be a good enough answer.

"How are you feeling about today?"

Catra sighed and took the cup from her mouth. "I'm okay , I think. I'll… just I…want to get it over with, you know?" She looked down at her watch, "I actually should get going, I have to do El' s pre-op checks and such. Thank you again, for the coffee," Catra leaned in and placed a hand on her elbow, "really . I needed it today."

Warmth bloomed in her chest at the grin she received, a warmth she carried all the way to the locker rooms to change. Catra hated

chugging such good coffee, but she had to finish it before she walked into the pre-op room to check on Elora.

"El? How' s it going, kid?" El drowned in her surgical gown, the blue and red lines written over her bald head screaming *'cut here'* made Catra's stomach churn. She hated working with kids. "Y ou ready for the big day?"

"Is anyone ever ready to get their skull drilled into?"

"I wouldnt know ," she bantered as she took a seat. "I'm usually the one doing the drilling, so it's easy for me."

"Y eah," she said, fiddling with the edge of her gown.

"Are you nervous?"

"I wouldnt really say that," El paused. "Catra, is it worth it?"

"Is what worth it?" And the face Elora gave her in answer was everything. Her initial reaction was to scream *'of course it is,'* but she swore to never lie to her. It didnt make it any easier . "What are you feeling, El? What' s making you question it?"

Small hands flopped onto the bed. "I just dont see an end to all of this, how many times am I going to have my head cut open? How many times will I have to lose all of my hair, and watch it grow back differently? Even if the cancer never comes back after this, which I doubt because this is now the fourth time, what then? Hormones, surgery, all of the shit I have to do to feel okay in a body that already hates me?"

"El, you dont have to" –

"I'm tired, Catra." She had never seen such a mature finality in the eyes of a teenager. "I'm just so tired of all of this, and I need you to tell me that it will all be worth it."

They held each other's gaze, and Catra leaned over to take her hand. "Personally , I think it is. This might sound incredibly diplomatic, but you and I have had very different experiences in life, so I cant tell you for sure, but I know that I had times of feeling the exact same way. Life isnt perfect, and there will always be struggles, but I always try to at least remain curious about what the future can hold. It helps, it helps to understand there will always be the good and bad, and I know that you have a big life ahead of you."

El took it in, blinked a few times, and leaned back against the bed. "Can you tell me about your past?"

"Oh, geez," she blew a slow breath out. "That' s a long story, El." Very long.

"Where does Adora fit into it?"

"What makes you think she is a part of it?" Brown eyes just bore into her, and Catra sighed. "Okay fine," *fucking kids.* "Adora and I have known each other practically all our lives. We were adopted by the same woman – Adora when she was a baby , and me when I was four."

"So you weresisters?" She asked with a weird face, which made Catra laugh.

"No, not at all. Our adoptive mother was a surgeon, like us, and our upbringing was more of a competition than a childhood. Like I said, it's a long story."

"Tell me the part where you fell in love."

"No."

"Please?"

She took a deep breath and sat back on her stool. "I swear Im not trying to be vague or not tell you things, but everything with Adora is

just so intertwined and convoluted. It's a mess, and not really a cute story."

Even if it was her favorite story. "We've never had it easy, and even now there are a lot of unresolved feelings that we're ignoring and not talking about. It's not healthy, but it's just what we know."

"Do you think it will be okay once you two figure it all out?"

Now that was the age old question. "I'm not really sure, but I'm curious to find out."

El looked pensive, then nodded. "Can I ask you something else?"

Catra looked at her watch, they had a little more time before she had to go. "Yeah, shoot."

"Have you picked a last name yet?" she asked. "I want to be the first to know, and if I don't come out of this surgery, I want to at least have that with me."

Catra leaned in again. "Hey, I need you to change that attitude, okay? You're going to come out of there."

"Please?"

Those big, brown eyes would be the death of her. "I'm still bordering on a few, but there's Taylor, Meier, Carter, Baker—"

"Grayskull"…

"You're a lot of work, you know that?"

"You're being too generic," El tutted, "and I still stand by my 'G' thought, so I'm just going to believe that it will happen one day."

Catra wouldn't give her the satisfaction of wanting to agree, but her pager vibrated. "It's almost go-time, the nurses will come in here in a minute to give you your drip lines for surgery, but is there anything I can do before I leave?"

"Can you give me a hug?"

She had never cried for a patient, but in that moment, Catra had to force herself to remain calm. There was Elora, bald and tiny and wanting to be normal, but life had thrown her nothing but shit. Catra knew life was unfair, she had lived it, but her chest was on the brink of snapping at her need to protect this little life she was vaguely entrusted with. She had to make this the best hug she had ever given.

"Of course, El." She sat on the edge of the bed and squeezed as hard and loving as was safe for such a fragile thing. Catra held on, letting Elora decide when she had enough, and then sat back. "Listen to me, and I know we have talked about this, but surgeons and medicine are only a part of the healing process. It is you that has to decide in here," she pointed to El's heart, "and here," to her head, "that you are going to get through this. You have to choose to fight, we can only help lead you there."

It was a lot of weight to put on the shoulders of a child, but Catra knew she could handle it. El was strong, she had done it before, she could do it again.

A small, dark hand wrapped into her own. "Yeah, I know."

"Elora, look at me," Catra said, needing her to chin up. "You are going to get through this. You're going to get through this, and I'll tell you the whole story about Adora and me, and I'll help you find all the resources you need, do you hear me?" She made sure El was looking at her. "You're so strong, you can do this."

A small smile was going to have to be enough, because her pager rang this time. "Go on, I'll see you I'll see you later." Catra stood up and nodded, but El caught her hand. "Catra? Thank you."

The weight of those two words pressed on her chest, and even Angella could sense she was torn.

"Catra"–

"I know ," she cut in, scrubbing her hands harder . They already went over everything numerous times together and with the onco team, but Catra was still allowed to have her feelings. She knew the risks and rewards, she knew it for every single surgery she played a part in, and she used the quiet Angella let through to hone her back into exactly what she knew.

Catra was a surgeon, her abilities were hard-earned and fought for, she was the best of the best. There was a reason she was sought out, and she held onto that lifeline while giving Scorpia a nod before entering the OR.

Elora was already prone, draped, and a nurse was brushing on the betadine to the area that Angella was about to hold a scalpel to. She took a deep breath, running through her mental checklist of each step that would go down during the procedure, and waited.

Waiting was awful, it made her hands itch and her ankles hurt. Catra hadn't been so uninvolved in a surgery since her second year residency at Horde, but she tried to use the time to catalog every one of Angella's perfect, pristine movements. Her movements were art, and since Catra had usually been involved in the surgeries, she rarely had the time to appreciate the delicate precision that went into each and every cut or pull from her instruments.

The room was tense, it wasn't a secret that El's tumor had grown and metastasized during treatment, but they were the best neuro-onco team in the world. They had dealt with worse.

But they had also seen easier cases crash in an instant.

"A little more suction over here, please." Angella was leading mostly , as Dr. Senes was there to back up her choices and give opinions.

"Dr. Lineas, do you have EACA ready? We're getting quite a bit of blood here." Catra had been watching her hands, but looked on the screen that showed the chief's surgery cam, and saw her spreading the cut through the vermis. Blood pushed out quicker than suction was working and her BP monitor alarmed. "That EACA, please, and more suction here—"

Catra's eyes were rooted on the screen, watching her heart rate rise slowly.

"Perfectly within limits," Angella said, eyes not leaving where she was trying to soak up blood. Catra knew it was said to her, to keep her calm, but Ermista was putting vials of epinephrine on her tray, and it made the hair on the back of her neck stand up. More and more gauze were being thrown onto the floor with wet, red slaps.

"Chief—"

"Get the pads ready, she's getting tachy."

Her head swam as Scorpia connected the lines to the defibrillator pads. "Angella—"

"Defibs are lined," Scorpia said and stood back.

Angella stuffed more gauze in El's skull, eyes flicking to the monitor to watch her heart rate. The minutes dragged and she wanted to scream, but her throat couldn't do anything. "Please start compressions, Dr. Black. Dr. Lineas, have the epinephrine ready if compressions are not successful."

Catra couldn't move, her heartbeat was shattering her eardrums as she watched Scorpia flip up the sheet to expose El's back, thick arms beginning to execute perfect, precision compressions into a ribcage that was probably smaller than the doctor's hands.

One, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight, nine, ten— she lost count somewhere around seventy three, but eventually Scorpia stopped

and everyone looked at her monitor.

"Still tachycardic, charge to 120J." Catra took a step forward, the ground nearly slipping under her feet.

Dr. Senes lifted the defibrillator control. "Everyone, clear"—

The spike on the monitor rose with the shock, but the line resumed its useless rhythm. Scorpia started her compressions again, Catra feeling every deep push like her own ribs were cracking. Ermista pushed in an epi, and her rhythms turned sinus.

"Alright, good," Angella said and started to change out some of the gauze. The monitor blared. "Damn, v-fib. Next, another of epi; Dr . Black, continuous compressions!"

"No"—Catra felt her body move before she could think. "Scorpia, move." It had to be her , Catra had to do it, and she tried to push her friend out of the way, to get her to stop touching El, but Scorpia was firm in her spot and grunted.

"Dr . C," Angella said firmly , still changing out gauze, "you can switch when Dr. Black is ready."

She swallowed the desert in her throat, not knowing where to look, not knowing if she should run. No, she needed to be there. She settled for the monitor, because watching El's back cave under the sturdy beat of Scorpia's hands made her vision go spotty. The lines of the monitor were a false sense of security, but they were the only thing keeping her breathing. Catra didn't know how long it was until Angella told her to hold.

"Asystole." Her legs buckled and everything swirled. "Let' s give it another go, push another of epi. Dr. Black, do you need to switch?"

Catra didn't give her a chance to decide, she checked her out of the way and started her own compressions, somewhat thankful that she couldn't see El' s face. With each compression, everything faded

away;all the beeping, all of the voices, nothing mattered but the press of her palms against that small, dark back.

Down, down, down, down…

She remembered every single person she's done CPR on: 67.7% of them survived the surgery, and 45.1% survived long enough to go home. Those were pretty damn good odds, but she had never performed CPR in prone position, so all of her statistics she repeated to herself during compressions were thrown out the window.

This was Elora, she was going to press and press and press until every fucking rib was broken, if it meant she'd see those gooey brown eyes again.

Down, down, down, down…

There might have been a voice saying her name somewhere, but Catra ignored it, she only could feel the bruising push of the heel of her palm in the other, could only feel the groan and soft snap of bones as she pressed again and again. She thought of how she'd make it up to El once she was awake, maybe she'd like mint n' chip ice cream. She could tell her about the time Adora broke her arm trying to skateboard with a cone in each hand.

'Catra, there's nothing more we can do.'

Lars. She could feel the beads of sweat trickle down her jaw . Catra had a 67.7% success rate, she was going to do it.

'Dr. C, stop compressions'–

No, no, no, no. She could do this forever, how many people had come back after 45 minutes of CPR? Her blood type was AB+, she could get every bag of blood they had in the hospital. Elora was a fighter, she could do it.

She wasn't given the chance though, as her arms were locked to her side and she was feet above the ground. "Catra, stop! We've done all we can."

"Let me go!" She screamed and tried to wriggle out of Scorpia's grasp. "Fuck you, let me go!"

"Time of death, 1443."

"No!" Her voice ripped through vocal cords and she kicked down *hard.* She wasn't phased by the yelp, or being dropped, and Catra jumped towards the bed, not seeing or caring about anyone other than the girl on the bed with a red back. Maybe if she just flipped Elora over–

Angella stepped in her way and put a hand on her chest. "Catra, that is enough, we did everything we could. She is gone, you will just be disrespecting her by trying more. I'm sorry."

Gone.

She didn't understand it, it didn't make sense. They had just been talking a few hours ago, she couldn't be gone.

"Catra–" Scorpia said softly behind her, and Catra didn't even bother to scrub out before her feet were carrying her out the doors of OR-2.

Gone.

Chapter End Notes

...Medical stuff:

EACA - (via Pubmed) Epsilon-aminocaproic acid (EACA) is a synthetic inhibitor of the plasmin-plasminogen system. EACA has been used in numerous clinical situations to control bleeding and has been claimed to be an effective agent in

subarachnoid hemorrhage, genitourinary bleeding from many causes, and in dental surgery in hemophiliacs. Essentially it is used to help control bleeding.

Epinephrine - (via Pubmed) Epinephrine is the primary drug administered during cardiopulmonary resuscitation (CPR) to reverse cardiac arrest. Epinephrine increases arterial blood pressure and coronary perfusion during CPR via alpha-1-adrenoceptor agonist effects. However, the dose, timing and indications for epinephrine use are based on limited animal data. Recent studies question whether epinephrine provides any overall benefit for patients.

Tachy - tachycardia (via openanesthesia) Tachycardia is defined as a heart rate greater than 100bpm. Tachycardia in the OR is not uncommon, and generally associated with severe hypovolemia, an inflammatory response or an inadequate anesthetic for surgical stimulus.

Sinus rhythms - that's what we want to see, it is normal rythym.

v-fib - ventricular fibrillation: (via John Hopkins) a type of arrhythmia, or irregular heartbeat, that affects your heart's ventricles. Ventricular fibrillation is life-threatening and requires immediate medical attention. CPR and defibrillation can restore your heart to its normal rhythm and may be life saving.

asystole - (via NCBI) Asystole, colloquially referred to as flatline, represents the cessation of electrical and mechanical activity of the heart. Asystole typically occurs as a deterioration of the initial non-perfusing ventricular rhythms: ventricular fibrillation (V-fib) or pulseless ventricular tachycardia (V-tach).

Catra's CPR percentages were real statistics, I just don't remember where I got them from, I apologize. CRP is not very successful unless you're already in a medical setting.

CPR in prone position (where the patient is laying on their stomach) is very, very rarely ever done. It was actually something that was a huge hassle in the height of Covid, because patient's were often prone to help them breathe, and medical personnel would have to attempt to resuscitate them whilst prone, and it is insanely difficult (though not impossible).

Unfortunately, even the best surgical teams in the world cannot save hemorrhaging. Sometimes even the healthiest of people can't be saved, and it's a part of medicine that affects those who aren't ready for it, even if they think they are.

We can only hope that Catra, and the rest of them, will be okay.

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Dr. Gray, do you need to step out?"

Adora winced, looking from the clock back down to the patient she hadn't been paying much attention to in the last half hour. She had taken the surgery so she wouldn't pace about the hallways, waiting to hear how El's operation went, but clearly the tibial plateau fracture just wasn't catching her attention the way she had hoped. Damned if she did, damned if she didn't. "No, I'm okay, I promise. Just antsy."

Mira nodded, not casting a glance up as she drilled a plate into place. "Alright, well if you want to look at the clock again, just try not to suction my screws up, if you could."

Adora noticed how close her tube was to the plate of bolts, nowhere near where she needed it to be, and she sighed before handing it over to the OR nurse. "Maybe I should just watch."

"That might be for the best," Mira agreed. "Tell me how studying is going, you're just under a month until boards, right?"

"Three weeks," she replied with a hum. "I truly don't think there is any more information I can fit in my brain at this point, we've gone over every case Raz would give us, and then over all of our cases we've had during residency. Is there anything else we should work on?" Adora was confident, she always had been about her work, but she was nothing if not overly prepared.

"K, you need to take a break. Even just a week off from studying, relax, do something for yourselves, and then rehash before you go." She took a deep breath, knowing that *'relax'* had never really been a verb she could accomplish, but the thought of warming spring days

with Catra did sound nice. "Are you going to take that vacation after your boards?"

Adora smiled, thankful that it was blocked by her mask, and felt the back of her neck heat up. "I think so, we got the PTO approved, so"–

The hiss of the automatic door was damn near silent, but it had Adora on full alert. "Adora"–

Her knees buckled, dread spilling over her neck and chest. "No"–

Scorpia's hand that was holding the mask over her face was shaking. "Dr. Shera, do you need Dr. Gray?"

The OR started to swirl as she took shaky steps, hardly registering Mara's soft *'go,'* but nothing mattered right then. Scorpia rounded on her in the scrub room, holding Adora up tight by her arms. "Elora didn't make it, Catra ran off and no one can find her."

"Oh god," her hand gave a half-veiled attempt to stifle a sob. "What happened? Where did she go?"

Scorpia dropped her head in defeat. "We don't know. Catra lost it in there, we tried everything to bring El back, but she was gone, and Catra just wouldn't stop compressions. I had to pull her off, and then she just ran. I don't want to freak you out, but when I couldn't find her, I didn't know what else to do. Do you know where she might be, Adora?"

She squeezed her eyes shut, mind racing on one thought alone – Catra.

"Adora?"

Adora would have to apologize to Scorpia later, she ignored all of the calls behind her as jelly-legs carried her to the places she thought Catra might run away to.

It wasn't supposed to be like this.

She was sure that everyone knew El was in bad shape, the child had relapsed at such a frequent rate that it would have been an absolute miracle if she had survived long term, but no one wanted to take the wrath of letting Catra know that. Catra, who had believed with every fiber of her being that the girl would recover. Catra, who had spent hours down in oncology with her when she didnt need to, just to keep El company. Catra, who *knew* it was a bad idea to get so close to a patient, but it happened to everyone eventually.

Adora felt the muscles of her heart strain as they pushed against her chest. Losing a patient was hard, losing a kid was even harder, but this was different.

The love of her life had lost their favorite patient, a child she knew Catra saw a part of herself in, and the only thing running through her mind was finding her, making sure she was okay. holding her while she broke apart.

But she was gone. Not *gone* gone, just that Catra wasnt in any place she normally hid out when she had a rough day. She wasnt downstairs, or in the skills lab, or at her apartment, or at Adora's apartment, or the gym, or or or *or.* She was gone.

And Adora was trying not to panic, but that was very hard when she was the only person who knew just how deeply Catra felt, just how deeply she could fold into herself. For the first time in years, Adora was afraid.

It took 37 hours. 37 of the longest hours of her life. She had scoured Bright Moon, checked every coffee shop, book store, hotel, post office, music store, clothing store, grocery store. you name it, Adora was hounding anyone and everyone for information on Catra. Her stomach had ceased to exist at one point, her eyes burned from frustrated tears and the need to sleep, but she wouldnt sleep. She couldnt, not until she found her.

Adora screeched to a halt as she drove past a cracked, dingy *'Open 24hrs'* sign hanging from the tattered, boarded windows of an even

more cracked and dingy dive bar. Had it been any other situation, she would have driven past without a glance;Catra didnt drink away her sorrows, the memories of her parents had made sure of that, but Adora was running out of options.

She had to force the door open, the stickiness of the floor holding the shoddy craftsmanship from toppling over, and Adora's stomach churned at the smell that smacked her when she walked in. How had this place passed any sort of health code?She spotted that familiar tuft of hair laying on the far end of the bar, and her body flushed in relief, but that was just as quickly washed away when Adora actually got a look at her.

Catra's hair was caked in something unholy, she was still in her surgical scrubs, and she was mumbling something that didnt sound like a language she had ever heard.

"Catra?"She asked gently , pushing away the empty beer glass, but the woman didnt move. She brushed some hair out of her face, and bloodshot eyes creaked open for a second. "Catra, how much have you had to drink?"The woman didnt answer again, and panic ripped through her chest. Adora checked her pulse and breathing, thankful to note that they were fine and that she was still warm, even if a little sticky and sweaty. She looked up at the man scrubbing glasses with a rag that he probably used to clean the floor. "How much has she had to drink?

"Dunno,"he said with a shrug.

"How long has she been here?"

"Dunno,"he repeated, not even bothering with a shrug.

"W ell, do you have a log of the drinks she's ordered?Anything that can tell me how much she's had?"

He scoffed and she watched particles of spit fly from his lips. "Does it look like we do that here, blondy?Y our girl here wanted to drink, and

I gave her drinks. It was a fair trade."

It really wasn't the time to bug her, having slept maybe five hours in nearly two days, Adora was done. She leaned over the bar and ripped him up from the sweat-spotted collar of his shirt, his beady eyes finally looking scared. Good. "I ask you how many drinks she's had."

"Hey-hey, we don't need any violence—"

Adora tightened her grip. "Drinks, how many? And when was her last one?"

He wriggled but she wasn't budging one bit. "Since I've seen her, maybe eight, but we switch out every twelve hours so I don't know about yesterday afternoon."

"And when was her last one?"

"Uhh-uhhh," he babbled, his breath making her queasy, "3am?"

"Good, thank you," she said and let him drop to the ground. "What has she been drinking?"

"A whole mix of things, but she's been on beer for most of the night."

She nodded and checked her pulse and breathing again. Had it been any other day, Adora would have already had Catra at the hospital and getting checked for alcohol poisoning, but she just wanted to get her home and cleaned up. The last place she needed to be at was the very place she had run from. Nearly satisfied that they were in the clear, she busied herself with thinking of the best way to get her out.

She was bending down to pick Catra up when the man spoke again. "She hasn't paid yet, you know. She's drank a lot and—"

"You're more worried about money than potentially killing someone? Alcohol poisoning is incredibly serious."

"That's their business, not mine. So long as they pay and make it out the door, I don't care wha–"

Her fist connecting with his weak jaw shut the man up quickly. Adora shook her hand out before pulling a few bills from her wallet and threw them on the counter. It wasn't like her to lose her cool, but as she picked Catra up and felt how she flopped in her arms, there wasn't a speck of room to care about anything else.

"Dora?" There was a push against her ribs and Adora's eyes closed. They needed to get out of there.

The chill of the early morning air made Catra shiver, and Adora leaned her against the side of the wall so she could actually see her. She looked awful, her face was streaked with grime and tear lines, her scrubs were definitely going to have to be burned, and there were scrapes along her elbows and knees. Did she walk there? It was miles away from the hospital…

"Hey, look at me," she said and put her fingers under Catra's chin. "What is your name?"

"Fuck you."

She was so, so tired. "What. Is. Your. Name?"

Blue and yellow squinted at her with an attempt at anger, but it just made Adora sad. "Catra."

"How old are you?"

"Who cares–"

"I do, Catra." Her eyes squinted harder. "How old are you?"

"Twenny-nine."

"When is your birthday?"

"Why's it matter?"

Adora's fingers pressed into her biceps in frustration. "I'm trying to see if you have alcohol poisoning, so just fucking answer me."

"October 28th."

"Thank you."

"S'at all?"

She didn't like this part. "No, and I'm really sorry"—Adora gave no warning before sticking her fingers down Catra's throat, pulling them out quickly as they were followed by chunky liquid. She stepped out of the way as it splattered to the floor, and rubbed the woman's back through it.

Catra stayed bent over, breathing heavy. "Why?" was all she asked.

"Now I know you probably don't have alcohol poisoning, now let's go."

"No."

"This isn't a debate, Catra."

"I don't want to go, I don't want I...don't want I—can't."

Adora wiped Catra's mouth with her own shirt and half-carried her to the car, neither of them having much fight to give. "You need fluids and food, I have some saline drips at my apartment." As she buckled her in, Adora wondered how quickly she could get home so Catra wouldn't vomit in the car.

"Why?"

"Why what?" she asked as she pulled away from the bar, noting its name so she could call the health department later. "The saline

drips? Well, I try and keep some stocked since Bow and Glimmer like to make me regret everyth—"

"No," Catra cut in, "not that."

Adora glanced over, "what do you mean?"

"No."

"Catra," she tried, but noticed how pale Catra had gotten and she rolled down the window. "Can you make it out of the window or should I—"

Well, she sort of needed a new car anyway, and Catra really did try and get it out of the window, but her utilities weren't that great at the moment. "Gross."

Adora just rolled down her own window and held back a sigh. "It happens, don't hold it back if you need to puke more. When was the last time you ate?"

Catra's head lolled to the side and looked at her. "I don't know."

"Great," she murmured and pulled into her spot, leaving the windows down, because she would happily let someone steal it at that point. Adora walked around to Catra's side and helped her get unbuckled, but the woman gave no effort to get out. "Can you walk or should I carry you?"

Plastered, broken eyes looked up at her. "I'm so tired, Dora."

She picked her up again, holding her close, and Adora's chest squeezed. It had nearly broken her when she was trying to find Catra, but now that she was in her arms, drunk, and broken herself, the weight of the situation slammed into her.

A kid died. Catra's patient, who had just turned thirteen, died on the table during an operation. Catra had watched, had attempted to resuscitate the little girl whom she had grown a fierce bond with. It

knocked the air out of her chest, knowing that the dirty, vomit-crusted woman in her arms had run, had run to the thing she had sworn never to run to.

Children were always the worst sort of deaths, it affected everyone, but Elora had been different, and Adora wasnt sure what to do.

So all she could do was stick her in the bath and cut the scrubs off her pale, swaying body. Catra tried to fight it for a second, but gave in once Adora climbed in behind her, fully clothed. The angles were weird, but she did her best to wash off the parts that were dirtiest, and let herself hold a hand over where Catra's heart was beating steadily. Exhaustion didnt even come close to what she felt, she was so far beyond it, but Adora was more than capable of staying awake when she needed to, no matter how unhealthy it was.

The water poured over them both as she breathed in tandem with Catra, needing the press of her body to feel rooted. The hours she was missing had terrified Adora beyond anything she had ever felt. When she left Fright all those years ago, she had missed not seeing her, of course, but knowing that Catra was missing and in a hurt, altered state of mind, it had formed a sick put in her stomach she didnt know could exist.

Eventually Adora dried them both off, getting Catra dressed first in some clothes she had left over, and then carried her out to the couch so she could get the IV hooked up. Her hands were shaking a little bit, both from lack of sleep and worry from not having actually put in an IV in years, but she knew Catra's veins.

"Oww," Catra groaned when she pushed the needle in and Adora kissed just below it.

"I know, Im sorry. Here, you need to drink this too before you sleep." Catra recoiled and tried to push it away. "Catra, drink the damn juice, please. You need the glucose."

Thankfully, she seemed to give in and chugged it, which Adora wasn't super thrilled with, but it was a start. She gave her a big bowl for vomit and went to search for her old blood pressure cuff she knew she put somewhere, just wanting to triple check that Catra was okay.

When she came back, there was purple vomit *mostly* in the bowl, but also some on Catra and the floor. *It's going to be a long day.*

Adora got her cleaned up again, grabbed some towels to spread around her just in case, and then sat on the edge of the coffee table.

"You don't have to watch me," Catra said as she closed her eyes, holding on tight to a towel.

"Just go to sleep, please. You'll feel better when you wake up."

An annoyed huff, which could have coupled as a dry laugh, passed through dry lips before her chest started to rise and fall with patterned breathing.

Adora sent off a quick text to Glimmer about finding Catra and the situation, then leaned onto her knees, just watching. While she didn't know exactly how the woman on the couch felt, she knew that when Catra cared, she felt it in her soul. It was something that every professor, mentor, and attending physician warned people about; eventually there would be a case that hit too close and would make you question everything you had done, everything you worked towards. Adora wasn't sure if she had a specific case that had changed her, but it was a major reason that she switched from wanting to do cardiology. It just felt like no matter what she did, the rate of patients surviving wasn't good enough, and each one that died chipped away at her.

But she knew this wouldn't just be a chip away for Catra. She looked her over, how peaceful she looked while she slept, and sorrow creeped into her bones. El was a good kid, the times Adora had seen her, she had been spunky and sassy, and she tried not to see

the decline of her health and attitude towards the situation. She had brought up the possibility of El not making it through treatment *once,* and Adora never spoke about it again. *I'll figure it out if it comes to that,* she had told herself.

Now that scenario was here, and it was worse than she ever could have imagined. Catra's eyes flew open as she sat up, and even though Adora was ready for it, the vomit missed some of the bowl and got over both of them. At least it was just liquid at that point…

It happened a few more times after that, and she ignored the mumbled *'sorry'* each time. Catra wouldn't understand it now, what she could say to her, but Adora would clean up the foulest things on Etheria from her body if it could help, if it could take away some of her pain. Each time those eyes flew open, she heard the retch from the base of Catra's throat, it made her heart ache. Cleaning her up only served as a reprieve from letting her mind spiral.

What if this became a habit? Addictions were hereditary after all, and from the little she heard of Catra's birth parents, she hit the double whammy when it came to that. Sometimes all a person needed was a spark to ignite the decline into bad habits.

Catra whimpered in her sleep, followed by a small snore, and Adora knew that she would be there to help her through every single step if it ever came to that. Catra wasn't a bad person, she was strong, but she had always been troubled. Maybe, once this was over, and their boards were over, maybe they could get into some therapy together.

Adora fought her eyelids, her chest was on fire with how tired she was, and all she wanted to do was to climb onto the couch and wrap Catra up tightly. She could sleep for days at that point, she was sure of it. She removed the IV once the bag was finished, placing a kiss over the bandage, and sat back on her post.

It was close to noon, Adora was taking her vitals again, when Catra seemed to finally wake up.

"Hey , Catra, goo—" her smile was wiped of f her face at the look in Catra's eyes. "What' s wrong? Are you okay? Do you need to—"

"What are you doing?"

"W ell, I was just checking your vitals again, I was—hey where are you going?" Catra ripped of f the blood pressure cuff and stood up, throwing everything to the ground. Adora grabbed her wrist and she wrenched out of the light grasp. "Catra"…

"Leave me the fuck alone." She made her way towards the door but Adora ran to block her.

"Hey hey , you shouldn't be going anywhere right now , you're still—"

"Adora, get out of my way ." Her eyes were so empty , it made the hair on the back of her neck stand up.

"Please come sit back down, you can't feel very good right now . Sit down and I can make something and we can talk about what hap—"

Catra just tried to push past her , but Adora caught her. "Let me go!"

"No, Catra, I don't want you to—"

"I don't give a fuck what you want, Adora. Let me leave."

"Just talk to me," she pleaded, pushing them apart so she could look at her. "Please. Just relax and let me—"

"Stop!" She screamed and lurched back. "I don't need you to do anything for me, I don't need to be your little muse for your savior complex again. I don't need anyone."

"Catra" she tried, but the woman stepped back even further .

"Where' s my stuff?" she asked, patting at her pajama shorts, looking around with those empty eyes. Adora regretted leaving her little wallet and phone on the counter, and wanted to take them, but there

was something about the whole situation that made her know it would be worse if she did fight for them. But she would fight for her.

"At least let me drive you home, Catra."

"ST OP!" she screamed again. "Just stop, for once in your stupid, perfect fucking life. I dont need to be your god damn charity case. Get out of my way."

Bile inched up her throat. "Y ou're not a charity case, why would you say that?"

"It' s what you do, isnt it, Adora? Y ou help people to feel that accomplishment, and then you leave once they cant serve as part of your fucking hero complex anymore." Catra shouldered her out of the way in her moment of stunned horror. "I've had enough of you using me as a long-term justification for your own issues, so please, for me, fuck off."

In a last ditch effort to stop her, Adora jumped towards the door and reached for her, but Catra slapped her hand away, hard.

They both stopped, there was a beat of stunned silence between them, before the front door was ripped open and Catra left without a word. She leaned against the wall and sank to the floor, the back of her hand stinging from the slap, and then laid down, not knowing what else to do. Adora's eyes slid closed on their own, giving into the exhaustion

Later , later she would think about whatever the fuck just happened.

—

'Wait, so Adora really had no idea that you were into her? That whole time?'

She laughed and hung up the bag, the last chemo treatment. 'Nope! I tried dropping major hints, but she just repressed everything for so

long that it didn't click.'

'Wow.'

'I know.'

'So how did you tell her then? Or did she finally realize?'

This had to be a lie, at least somewhat. 'I, I just couldn't take it anymore one day and kissed her. I think she got the point after that.' El nodded a little mindlessly, and Catra pointed at her. 'I also recommend not just kissing people without permission, that's not cool.' The tattoo resting above the dimples on her lower back had been the drive to get Adora to realize…and the kiss had just been the last touch.

She ran her hand through her hair and pushed it around a bit. 'Yeah, I know all about consent, don't worry.'

El's hair had grown back so curly and wild, but she helped her learn to style it in a way that was more feminine, and it was adorable to see her be happy with it. 'You sound like you've been thinking about it, kiddo, is there something on your mind?'

'Well,' she said shyly, 'there is this new boy at school, and he sits next to me in history. I don't know, he's sweet, but I'm just…I've never really had a crush like this. What do I do?'

Catra leaned back and let out a slow breath. She was probably the last person to take advice from, her track record between Adora and all of the emotional-support-blondes between their missing years didn't yield a ton of healthy dating habits, but she could try. 'You just have to be yourself, El—no, don't give me that look, I don't care how cliché it sounds. Maybe try being friends with him, ask him to study with you or something? Get to know him, and then maybe, it will happen naturally. Just don't try and change yourself in a way that you think might make him, or anyone, like you. You're awesome just as you are, and people need to see that part of you.'

She nodded again and rubbed at the fabric of her sweats. 'And what if he doesn't like me?'

'Oh, honey,' she said softly and took her hand, 'that can definitely happen, but it's nothing against you. It might hurt, but sometimes people just aren't meant for each other, you know? As much as you want it, you can't force someone to be something they aren't.'

'Meow.'

Catra blinked. 'What?'

'Meeow'–

This wasn't right…

"Mboow"–A soft paw touched her lips and Catra opened an eye. "Mow."

"Mog"–she said with a small sigh. She closed her eye and felt Mog stand up, stretch, and then lick her forehead before hopping down from the couch. Catra threw an arm over her face, trying to block out the sunlight, and breathed through a tight throat.

Her dreams had always been vivid, whether they were a replay of the past or a crazy, impossible hodge-podge scenario, like when she used to dream she was a cat as a kid.

But over the last few days, they had always been the same thing. In her dreams, Elora was alive, Catra had brought her ice cream once she recovered from surgery and spent the months of her remaining treatment telling the girl about Adora. They varied, of course, their discussions and what other people came and went, but in every dream, every one of them, El was alive.

And then Catra would wake up to the suffocating reality of a world in which the opposite was true.

She got up at the sound of an annoyed meow to feed Mog, and started a pot of coffee she knew she wouldn't finish, but she was trying to stick to some sort of routine if she could. Catra's head was empty as she watched the brown liquid drip into the glass container, and empty as she filled her mug with coffee and creamer, empty as she sat on the couch and stared at the black face of her TV.

It was when she took a sip of her poorly made coffee, eyes catching the coasters Adora had bought for the little table, that she choked on the hot liquid. Her chest heaved painfully as she tried to swallow before she knew what was coming. Catra tried to hold back her sobs, her shoulders hunching forward as she clapped a hand over her mouth, large drips of coffee slipping over the edge of the mug as her body convulsed.

So had been her routine over the last few days, and once the worst of it had passed, and she was able to control her movements, Catra would set the mug down and sit back, just staring at whatever her eyes decided they wanted to fixate on.

Why she even tried, she didn't know. Why she even got out of bed, she didn't know, why she brushed her teeth or showered was so far beyond her ability to rationalize that she just did it. Why did any of it matter? That was the question she had been trying to answer, the question that slammed into her chest each morning once her brain decided to kick into gear, and thus far, Catra didn't have an answer for it.

Because *why* did it matter? She didn't matter, that had been made abundantly clear over and over again in her life. Her parents had left her on the doorstep of someone's house and drove off, the woman that took her in abused her, she was terrible at making friends, she couldn't keep her patients alive…

Hopeless. The cavity that had formed in her chest was a seemingly never ending pit of hopelessness. A bubble tried to push through her throat, stretching out her neck as another sob escaped. Hopeless, useless, and a burden to everyone she ever came into contact with.

And maybe a burden would be the better word for it, because even broken and battered things could be useful.

No, Catra was a burden.

She had begged for the cat ears and tail she saw at the supermarket, begged and cried so hard that some old lady bought them for her. Burden. She wore them every day, was wearing them when her mom and dad left her on Weaver's doorstep and drove off. Her parents had left her because they didnt like her . They didnt like how she was loud, how she used to play pretend, or that she rarely slept, or was specific about her food. She had been an accident, unplanned – a burden to people who wanted to sit around and waste their lives away with bottom shelf liquor and menthol cigarettes.

Catra had been a burden to Weaver, who had made it perfectly known how much she favored her first "child," and how Catra had only served as a distraction to her protégé. She was an extra mouth to feed, a body to clothe, a human to teach, and while she had done bare minimum, it had been a burden to Weaver to give her even the bare necessities.

She was a burden to the people she worked with, that had been clear enough by all of the not-so-quiet whispers she heard around the hospital, both at Bright Moon and at Horde. They all would like it better if everyone had the sunny disposition of Dr. Shimmer and her golden retriever husband, but Catra wasnt that. She wasnt great with people, and they made it perfectly apparent that she wasnt worth the effort to get to know better.

Her one crowning achievement was being an excellent surgeon in training, but even some of the greats of history can fall from grace.

Her fall from grace was providing the Woods family with the everlasting burden of the loss of their only child.

Catra's head spun, but her eyes stayed locked on the shirt she had ripped off after stumbling home the other day. It was her fault, it was

all her fault that she couldnt save her , that she didnt do enough, and Catra had run before having the decency to look Elora's parents in the face and tell them their daughter was dead. Elora would never get to experience life as who she was inside, or get to know a world beyond the walls of a hospital, or learn about how many things there are out in the world that she should have gotten to see. And it was all Catra's fault.

Why? Why did it end up the way it did? Why did Catra get to sit there, clothes wet again from spilled coffee, while a hole was dug to fit the coffin of a child who should have gotten to experience a life. Why did she get to wear what she wanted, and have people call her what she wanted, and get to go do anything she wanted, when that little girl had only wanted to be healthy? El only wanted to experience a life in ways normal kids got to, so why couldnt she? Why should Catra live, when someone who deserved it had their life taken?

Because Catra was a burden, and she was burdened with a life.

Stubbornness had pushed her through the trials of her childhood, and spite had carried her through the rest. Thoughts of taking her own life were not new to her, Catra had begged for a reprieve often enough that the thoughts felt like home most of the time, but there had always been a pair of blue eyes that pulled her from those depths.

And oh, Adora. Her hand still prickled from the slap it delivered to the only person who had ever truly remained constant. Catra's chest heaved at the thought of what she had done, she had sworn when they were teenagers that she would never lay a hand on her like that again, and it only served to sink lower into herself.

A burden, that's what she had always been to Adora and her fucking complexes. It wasnt in the woman' s nature to give up, and Catra was the perfect candidate for her endless need to save someone, because she was unsavable. Adora knew it too, she had finally realized how useless Catra was, and she left her . In return, what did

Catra do? She came back and latched herself on like the leech she was, they were just yin and yang of the broken and the fixer .

Adora didn't want her . How could she?

Catra was just blood and bones with a brain that told her body what to do, she wasn't anything special. Adora had lived without her once, she was sure that she could do it again. She'd find someone better , more worthy of her sweet, idiotic, jacky disposition. Adora would find someone who was better for her, because Catra wasn't good for anyone. Catra was useless.

Her jaw ached from trying to keep it shut, and she slapped her hand to her mouth as her lip quivered. She was so tired of hearing herself cry. It was one thing to feel it well up from the base of her stomach, fire licking the sides of her neck and jaw as she racked out sobs, but hearing her vocal cords damn near tear was getting to be too much. Catra was just so tired, she was so tired of wondering why she had been given such a life, and why she had been so hellbent on proving people wrong.

What did it matter? None of them would remember her anyway , or care about her. People would just be sad out of the general societal construct of a life passing, but no one would mourn for long. She hadn't accomplished enough that would warrant her name being spoken for long. They always say that people have two deaths – the first is when your brain dies, the second is when your name is spoken for the last time. Catra knew her second death would follow quickly after the first.

It would be nothing like the little girl she couldn't save, it wouldn't be anything like that life that was so fucking unlived that Catra wanted to gouge her eyes out from the pain of her tears. The tears that fell thick and hot when she thought of Elora's life cut short, and she always wound up in hiccuping gasps, usually on the floor, scratching for something... anything.

See, Catra had lived a life already, she'd done so many things she had dreamed of doing, and while her list of dreams and things to do wasn't yet complete, she still had time. There was nothing looming over her head that demanded she rush anything. No one is sad about someone who has already grown up.

And El will never grow up. She was buried yesterday, with a bald head and more than likely bruising on her back from Catra's hysteric attempts to bring her back from something she never could have recovered from. She was invited to the service, of course, but she couldn't face it. She couldn't face anyone.

She had known from the moment Adora texted her Elora's symptoms were getting worse that the young girl's days were numbered, but she refused to believe it. El had been a fighter, if anyone could survive, it was her. Catra didn't want to believe it, because she saw some of herself in that little thing, so full of life to give, but restricted by things far out of her grasp.

But Catra had survived it, hadn't she? She had survived, whether that was her choice or by some intervention, she was forced to live her life, and she made it what it was. She was burdened with life.

El had hers taken.

Why was she different? What gave her the right to survive when someone who *wanted* to live was taken from the world.

Catra's phone vibrated somewhere and her head snapped up at the sound, the light in the room had grown a bit darker, and she sighed before cleaning up her cold, messy clothes and the cold coffee. It was probably just Adora calling her again, as she had done over the last however many days. Calls, texts, voicemails... she considered changing her number again, but that wouldn't work. Catra had to go back to Bright Moon Memorial in two days, she had to go back to the place that people walked into, and sometimes left in body bags.

Angella had called her, she almost ignored it thinking it was Adora, but caught it at the last second. The chief gave her time off, but expected her back and ready. She just blinked and said *'okay,'* because what else was she to do for one of the only people who had never expected anything from her other than herself. So she would go back, and she would have to cut people open and give reports to families, she'd have to see Glitter , and worst of all, she'd have to see Adora.

Catra put the cup on the counter and starfished herself on the cold tile floor of the kitchen. She let the static numbness wash over her, since it was far better than crying, and wished she had just stayed the fuck in Fright. Or maybe gone to any other state and worked at a hospital there. That way she never would have to see Adora find some other damaged soul to work on, and she never would have had to deal with the emotional baggage that came from losing a patient that had needled too far into her heart.

Was it worth it? Was any of it worth it? The question Elora asked her thumped at the front of her skull, and Catra closed her eyes, because she didn't know . She didn't know much of anything, it felt like. The only thing she was sure of, was that no one would miss her. She could end the pain, she could, and life would continue on for the people of Bright Moon just as they had before she butted her way into all of their lives. Nothing for them would change, no one would miss her.

Melog bumped his head into hers and her chest caught, but Catra refused to let anymore tears spill. If she hadn't moved to Bright Moon, she would never have found him, and how would her life be without his annoying, gorgeous meows at far too early in the morning? She had saved him, and in return, he had saved her as well quite literally .

She pulled him onto her chest, letting his purr reverberate along with the numb static. Catra had gone up to the roof the day after the Adora fiasco, had found herself up on the edge, the tears in her eyes blurring the end of the ledge and the beginning of a long drop. Her

sobs nearly folded her in half with the pain of lungs that wanted to explode. Mog had followed her up, had wrapped himself around her feet, and meowed at her until she stepped back. It would have been so easy, no one would miss her, but there wouldn't be anyone to feed her boy. She couldn't do that to him.

So started their routine of Mog waking Catra up, Catra finding herself in a position where she didn't understand why she was breathing and her dead patient wasn't, and then he would find her again, letting her know that if anything, one thing in life cared about her.

She took a deep breath through worked lungs. Catra wasn't sure how she was going to be able to handle going back to the hospital, but she would figure it out. She always did.

Chapter End Notes

> Please, if you are ever thinking or having thoughts of self harm, please get help. You matter and are important to this world, no matter how much you think the opposite. As an American, we finally got a quick Crisis Line to call if we're ever in need, but most countries have some as well if you are in dire straights and need to talk to someone. Here are some resources:
> https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_suicide_crisis_lines
> https://blog.opencounseling.com/suicide-hotlines/
>
> I know the pain of feeling like you don't matter, and the utter hopelessness that tags along with it all. I know it and I fight with it so often, so if you are struggling, I see you. I see you and there is help out there, there is goodness still out there, no matter how hard it is to find sometimes. Please remain curious about what could be.

On a (hopefully) happier note, Catra did absolutely use a tattoo on her lower back to make Adora realize she was a flaming homosexual. She has a bow with the cat ears and tail, then bent over and Adora was done for. This is also how Adora knew the person on the bike was Catra with the license plate.

Thank you for reading, this chapter meant a lot to me, even if it's fucked up and dripping with angst. I hope you all are well.

Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The basement was colder than she remembered it being, but maybe it was just the amount of weight she had lost in the last two weeks or so.

The weight was something she hadn't realized until she had been in the OR and shivered the whole time. She thought, for a moment, that it was just a natural reaction to being back in the hospital, back in that sterile room with all of the noises that had been haunting her, but after the second and third time, it clicked. Angella had been nice enough as well to not schedule her any surgeries in OR-2, or any neuro surgeries where the patient was prone, but it wouldn't have mattered. Catra was numb to it all anyway.

The days being back at work had passed by in an easy enough fashion, Catra would get to work on time, lean against the wall for the daily briefing, then toss out her barely eaten bagel before being sent to do something. Her days had been filled with hours down in the emergency department, or getting chosen for random surgeries, and she had done everything without a word.

Quite literally, it was nearly impossible for her to open her mouth, because she didn't even know if anything could come out if she wanted it to. Catra avoided everyone, nodded her head when spoken to, and enough people had gotten the gist to just *leave her alone* that all others stopped trying. She could feel their eyes, she could hear their whispers lower or stop completely when she turned a corner, she could see how each different attending surgeon realized that she wasn't going to talk.

She was too numb, too empty. Catra was a zombie by the end of each shift, worn to the bone from the exhaustion of having to be

alive, that she hardly had the stamina to reach her bed most nights. But then again, she was practically a zombie during the day as well.

Even the cold didn't bother her much anymore, it was just another weight to bury her under, another thing Catra couldn't be bothered to drag herself out of when she was alone. She had tried spending time up in the skills lab with Entrapta, had tried sitting in the break room, but it didn't feel right. All of the people there were just carrying on with their lives as if nothing happened, as if nothing had changed, and she couldn't be a part of it. It didn't feel right.

So she busied herself with as many surgeries or clinic hours as she could in a day to avoid interacting with anyone who wasn't screaming or under anesthesia. Catra was able to zone out then and just focus on what she had been training for years to do without thought, and it was better that way. If she was in surgery, or helping people in the clinic, then she could wear a mask and avoid everyone she didn't want to interact with.

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The vibration still startled her, even if Catra had turned off the sound of her pager. She just stretched out her neck before hopping of f the lone gurney, and tossed out her uneaten soup. She looked at the splash of liquid on the sides of the bag and sighed, soup had actually sounded decent when she grabbed it, but a surgery awaited her, and Catra forced her legs to push through their groaning at the speed she needed to walk.

Catra scrubbed in quickly and was not expecting to have the air in her lungs leave at the sight of blonde hair poking out from the bottom of a red and gold scrub cap.

If there was any person she had been specifically avoiding, it was Adora, and now they were forced together in an emergent surgery? Catra thought for a split second how much trouble she would be in if she walked out, but then her eyes followed Adora's scalpel along the line of their patient's spine, and everything else faded away. She was

a surgeon, she had one job and no one was allowed to distract her from that.

"Dr. C," Mira said flatly, eyes not looking up, "there is a left parietal epidural hematoma six millimeters lateral of the lambdoid suture, I need you to perform the craniotomy—Dr. Gray, pull back right there."…

She watched Adora pull back the layers of muscle that Mira was cutting through and needed clarification. "You want me to perform the craniotomy? By myself?" The effort made her throat ache.

"That is correct, Dr. C."

"Where is the chief?"

"Trying to save this man's husband. Now would you be so kind as to relieve the building pressure in his skull, or should I find another resident who would not do it as well as you?"

Adora tilted her head ever so slightly, stormy blue eyes catching her from the corner, and Catra stood up straighter at the sturdy set in them. Adora nodded once, a reassurance, and went back to the patient.

There was no second thought she had before Bow was sliding gloves on for her, and she stepped up to the side of the man's head that was draped, shaved, and red with betadine. Something clawed at her stomach and chest, but she swallowed it down and held her hand out for a scalpel.

Catra easily ignored the voices of the two ortho doctors next to her, and got busy cutting and drilling into her patient's skull. It was odd to not have Angella there for her first solo surgery, but she had trained for this, she had done enough craniotomies with the chief that Catra felt confident in her abilities…it was all she had.

If she allowed it, also, it felt nice to have Adora there for her first solo, even if they weren't working together. It *almost* felt like everything they had planned for.

But then Catra was scooping off blood clots by herself, pointing to where she needed suction from a nurse and not an assisting resident, and let her already numb brain blank out on any thought beyond how she needed to proceed. She had probably taken longer than what was normal, but speed wasn't really crucial at the time, and Catra needed it to be perfect. By the time she finished with the staples, she looked up to see that Adora was gone, and Adora was busy stitching the last bit of skin up.

She watched as proficient fingers wrapped around the string, her chest catching a laugh at the remembrance of Adora once saying she didn't have a delicate touch, and wanted so badly just to stand next to her. Catra wanted to watch her finish, to see her proud smile at the end of it, and to scrub out together. Maybe they could hold hands on their way back to the surgery station, or go grab some lunch...but it wouldn't happen.

Adora had been ignoring her as much as Catra had been doing the same, or perhaps it wasn't ignoring and just keeping her distance. She had seen her watching, had seen those eyes watching her from across the hall and following for as long as they could. When they caught each other's gaze, Catra had always looked away quickly, but she could feel Adora's stay. She never let herself look long enough to tell if the woman was sad or angry, she wasn't entirely sure if she wanted to know, but if Catra could hazard a guess, it was sad.

Even though she was the one that had hurt Adora, and she should be mad, it was just in the perfect, blonde idiot's nature to not stay mad. She was probably thinking of ways to make Catra feel better, to tell her that everything would be okay.

But nothing was okay, and she wasn't going to feel better.

She backed away and scrubbed out, nearly running straight into Mira as she hurried out of the OR. Catra tried to walk around her, but the dumb jock of an attending blocked her way.

"Catra, I was hoping to bump into you," she said with a smile. "You did wonderfully in there, I'm very proud of you."

"Thank you." She tried walking around her again, but Mira stopped her.

"Would you come with me? I'd like to talk to you."

She opened her mouth to reply, but the door to the scrub room opened and Adora walked out, looked between them quickly, and nodded before she walked away.

"Perfect," she said with a clap, "follow me."

Catra really didn't have a reason not to go, beyond her usual need to bury herself with work, but Mira seemed to be the only person besides Angella who hadn't treated her as if she was delicate, so she followed. They didn't speak as they rode the elevator to the top floor, and her interest was piqued as the woman fished a ring of keys from her pockets to unlock the door to the roof. Catra had always wanted to go up there.

It was bright and warm, warmer than she had expected it to be, and Catra let the sunlight sizzle her skin as she took a deep breath. Most days she had been awake before the sun rose, and got home long after it set. On her days off, she didn't bother going anywhere but her kitchen or couch, and she realized only then how much she needed sunlight.

The sound of feet across gravel made her open her eyes and Catra followed Mira to the edge of the building, taking in the sight of the entire city of Bright Moon, blooming with late spring flowers. It was the first time she had felt something nice in weeks.

"So how are you doing, Catra?"

And then it was gone. "I'm fine."

"You lost a patient you had grown very close to, you are not okay, and that's okay."

The thump of her heart echoed in her empty body. "I'm not talking about this, I can't—I can't talk about this." Catra backed away as she said it, giving one last look to the skyline.

"I was in love with mine."

She stopped, "what?"

"Everyone has a patient they get too close to, Catra, a patient that gets under their skin and then dies. You're not alone in this, honey." Mara smiled and stepped forward, taking her arm and pulled her back to the edge. "It's something that no story can prepare you for, no matter how many times you're given the advice to not get too close, and the pain of it is..." she shook her head and let out a deep breath. "It feels utterly unbearable, at the beginning."

Catra didn't say anything as Mara looked out over the edge, collecting her thoughts. Of all the attending surgeons, she was the one Catra had spent the least amount of time with outside of the operating rooms. It was nothing against her, more just that… sometimes Mara had this weird ability to read her better than she was expecting, and it always made her think more than she wanted to. This felt like it would be one of those times, yet when the woman took a deep breath, it kept her rooted in her spot.

"I was a second year resident," Mara said, "I hadn't really decided which route I would go yet, so I was taking every case I could get my hands on. This woman came into the clinic one day and I was immediately smitten. I was nearly shaking as I did her work up, it was the most ridiculous thing, but she had this smile that could melt rock, you know?" She leaned against the side wall and crossed her

arms. "She just came in for chest pain and dizziness, she was so young that I didn't really think much of it, but she was diagnosed with viral cardiomyopathy from a stint with the flu. I was so sure she would be okay"…

"But she wasn't," Catra surprised herself by saying, and Mira shook her head.

"She wasn't. We tried so many things, but her condition kept getting worse, and eventually she was put on the donor list, so there was nothing to do but wait. For a year, she was in and out of the hospital with complications, and I spent every second with her that I could, ignoring how her body was weakening. She just had this energy about her that always made me forget that she was sick. I fell for her so hard, so quickly, that I was blinded by everything. She finally made it to the top of the list and got her transplant, and I counted down the days to when she would be released after her recovery." Catra wondered how Mira could smile at a story like this, even when she was clearly in pain. "We were going to go on a date, I picked this restaurant that would cost me an entire month's pay, but they were the only place that had these little fritter things she loved, so it would have been worth it. I came to pick her up from the hospital, only for them to tell me that she was gone. At first I didn't believe them, I thought they were joking and that she was going to walk around the corner, but she never came."

"What happened?" Catra asked.

"She had a massive stroke in her sleep and they couldn't save her," she answered easily. "I refused to believe it until I saw her, and even then, it still didn't hit me until a few days later when her family came to drop off the funeral announcements. I can't even describe that pain, but I was just so lost and distraught after that, I didn't know what to do. It almost made me quit medicine entirely because I just felt like it was my fault somehow, and I wasn't sure I could watch that happen to another person or their family."

They shared a look and Catra knew Mara understood. "So what changed?"

She shrugged. "Time, mostly, and I had an amazing support system to help me through a lot of it. Catra," she said and pulled her in by her hands, which felt rough just like Adora's, "it's okay to be sad, the feelings you have of losing Elora are real and painful and valid, but I need you to understand that sometimes there isn't anything we can do for our patients, even if we try our hardest. You are one of the best residents I have ever worked with, and it would be a damn shame to see you give up this path. I had you do that surgery today because I needed you to see yourself how I see you, and how most of us see you. You are capable of so many wonderful things, and I hope you understand that though you haven't been here for long, you still have so many people to help and support you."

The words bounced around her head, and Catra wanted to pull away. She itched at the feeling, it didn't feel right. "Who? Who supports me? Everyone just whispers when I'm around or avoids me completely. I'm—I'm nothing"…

Mara bent down a fraction to look her in the eyes. "I can't make you believe it, but that is not true. Not only do the attendings want to help you, but your resident colleagues want nothing but your success. Glimmer, Scorpia, Adora"—

"Adora wants to save everyone," she spat, her heart hammering.

"That *is* sort of her job, you know?"

Catra pulled her hands away. "No, she's—she has this hero complex where she feels the need to hurt herself to save others, she's always been like that. She doesn't actually care about me"—

"Adora does things because she *wants* to, Catra. Did she ever tell you why she switched from cardio?" Catra shook her head after a few seconds, and Mara nodded. "She already struggled a bit when she got here, coming from such an oppressive place such as Horde

was already hard enough, which you know, but she was just so determined to do anything and everything she could for her patients that it nearly killed her. Cardio is tough, especially at a level one trauma hospital, and it was like a piece of her died with every patient she lost. eventually we had to have an intervention. She' s learned a lot since coming here, and if she does anything, it is because she *wants* to."

She wrapped her arms around herself, there wasn't any way that was true. Adora had always been Adora, she didn't need Catra. Adora didn't want her. "Whatever."

Mira placed a hand on her shoulder. "You don't have to believe me now, but please don't let yourself sink too deep into despair. As doctors, we are subject to seeing some of the worst of humanity that comes through the door and expected to take every case in stride, but we are only human, we can only do so much. You are in pain because you cared about a patient, a human being who had their life cut too short, and there is nothing wrong with that. In fact, I think it makes you a better physician all around, since you care not just about the medicine, but the person you are helping. It is hard though, and you need to be more open about accepting help. If not from your friends, then professional help through the hospital."

Catra felt her pat her shoulder and she listened to the crunching gravel again before she turned around. "Mira?" she asked. "Does it get better?"

She was thoughtful for a moment, but then smiled. "The pain will last, but you will grow to tolerate it and appreciate what once was. Time is a funny thing, which I think you know better than most, but life will always be full of a certain balance between pain and joy, especially as a physician. I think that if you allow yourself to see it, the good you find will always outweigh the bad." Mira opened the door to go back in but stopped. "And Catra?" Catra nodded. "Take people exactly as who they show themselves to be. You deserve to feel the love given to you."

—

‘Take people exactly as who they show themselves to be’ — were words Catra frequently repeated to herself the week that followed her rooftop discussion with the ortho attending. The words that were spoken just after poked at her every now and then, especially when she caught blonde hair peeking around corners, but that was easy enough to ignore.

The more she looked as she walked the halls of Bright Moon, her coworkers' avoidance of her was out of respect more than anything. Catra’s conditioning — from Weaver and Horde — had driven her snap judgments towards believing people were whispering about her, mocking her for feeling something, for showing any sort of weakness in the face of a loss. Not at Bright Moon, where everyone (save for Glimmer) had been wholly welcoming from the very first day, no. If she caught anyone’s eye, they would either tilt their head in a greeting, wave, or offer a hello.’

It was nice enough, really, and Mara’s words usually floated through her head enough to get her through the days, which was her ultimate goal. People could be as nice and genuine as they wanted, but none of that changed the fact that Catra still fell face first into her couch at the end of the day, still threw away half eaten food, and woke up each morning from dreams that would never be a reality again.

Adora seemed to be keeping her distance, not in a way that meant she didn't want to talk to Catra, but more that she was just watching, waiting for some other shoe to drop. She'd catch her staring from behind a clipboard, or from the little window break through doors, and it almost made her laugh by the sheer attempt at being subtle. Adora was about as incognito as a brick wall on a busy highway.

Sometimes Catra would allow herself to stare when Adora wasn't looking, she'd let herself feel the clawing at her empty skin at the thought of how life was for them only a few weeks ago. It seemed so far away now, it was almost a different world entirely. She'd just stare, remembering how their legs and arms tangled, how easily they

found themselves falling back into a routine of life together. Such as now, Catra watched her try and reach an itch on the upper part of her back, a spot Adora and all her stupid muscles had never been able to reach, and she wanted so badly just to walk over and do it for her.

But Adora didn't want her.

Mara's words begged to be recognized, but even if they were true, and Catra was sure they were, she just couldn't do it. Maybe Adora did love her, only a fool would deny that, but it wasn't the same as how Catra loved her. Adora's love was borne out of her need to protect, it was formed through forced time together. She could do better, she could have anyone.

As she watched her use the edge of a door frame to scratch the itchy spot, Catra knew Adora was the only one for her. Even when she wasn't able to feel anything besides hopelessness, Adora was still able to make her smile, however small and painful it was.

"Dr. C?"

Any good feeling she had vanished in an instant as Catra turned around to see Elora's parents standing behind her with the chief. "I'll give you some privacy," Angella said with a slight nod and walked off, leaving her with a mix of something bubbling in her stomach.

"We hoped to speak with you for just a moment, if we could."

Violet stepped forward slightly as Catra's hardly regained ability to speak left her body. "We won't take much of your time," she said and pulled at her fingers. "Mark and I—we want to thank you for being there for our daughter when we couldn't be, and I know that we weren't here with her as much as we should have been. You gave Elora a—" she choked and Catra felt it shake her chest. "You were able to help her be who she truly was, and we are so grateful for you. We tried to do the right thing for her, but it wasn't always easy, and there are decisions we made as parents that we—we will always

regret. All we ever wanted was a happy child. Life didn't really work out that way – she dealt with the cancer from such an early age – but you were able to make her happy at the – at the end. You made her happy."

Catra looked at them both as Mark rubbed small circles on his wife's back. She had never really cared much for El's parents, she had never taken the time to truly look at them. Violet was dark, nearly as dark as Bow, and had eyes nearly the same color as El's were. Mark looked nothing like either of them, with his dark red hair and pale, freckled complexion, but his frown was exactly like his daughter's. They both had dark, puffy, baggy eyes and hunched shoulders, and that feeling in her stomach erupted.

Violet and Mark Woods had left Bright Moon Memorial Hospital three weeks and four days ago without their child, their only child. Yet here they were, two people who raised their child in a way they thought was right for their family, thanking the person who had never even given them so much as a second glance before being the reason they lowered their daughter into freshly turned soil.

"We had her name legally changed," Mark broke through, "so everything is correct now on her birth certificate." And her death certificate, he didn't have to say.

Violet pulled a bracelet and a small envelope from her purse and handed them to Catra. "We found these in Elora's hospital bag when we were going through her things. We think she would have wanted you to have them. I made copies of the pictures, I hope you don't mind. I just – we just didn't have a lot of pictures of her. Of – of our girl."

Her thumb ran over the blue, purple, and pink fabric that intertwined together to form the word *'Elora,'* her vision started to swirl.

"She loved you, Dr. C, you were one of the best things that ever happened to our daughter. My wife and I will always be grateful that you were able to help our family the way that you did. You are very

special, and we had to personally thank you for everything you've done for us."

Catra hardly heard them thank her again and say goodbye, she was too lost in the picture she pulled from the envelope, one of her and Elora from the beginning of her treatment. She knew the floor was coming, the rush in her ears deafening everything along with her body giving out, but Catra didn't care anymore.

Something hurt, she knew that, but everything felt heavy and muted. Catra heard some dishes clanking and blinked open her eyes, shutting them back tightly at the sight of Adora in the kitchen. Of course, of course the savior herself had come to Catra's rescue.

"When did you eat last?"

Melog trotted happily next to her and jumped into Catra's lap. "Go away, Adora."

"No," she said and put a plate of food down. "You're getting weak, you need to eat, Catra."

Her heart pushed tightly in her chest at the look Adora gave her. She wanted so much, but she curled away. "I don't need you to do anything for me, I don't need anyone. Just leave me alone."

"I know you don't, you have never needed anyone. But I'm not going anywhere."

"Why can't you take a hint? I don't want you here." Her voice cracked from the lie. "Just leave me alone."

Adora sat on the corner of the couch and Catra itched to pull her closer. "Look," she said, "you can hit me, yell at me, you can fucking cut my head off if you need to, but I am not going anywhere, Catra." Why did she have to look so pretty when Catra wanted to be mad?

“We leave for Mystacor in two days, and I am not letting you out of my sight until then. I’m not letting you give up on everything you’ve worked for.”

She felt her fight wash away as blue eyes bore into her, what was the use? Adora was her own woman, if she felt so inclined to try and help a lost cause, then that was her prerogative. Catra had watched her leave once, she could do it again. She was sure her heart couldn’t split anymore than it already had.

“Whatever ,” she gave in as Melog hopped over her knees and rubbed himself along Adora’s thigh. “If you’re going to trespass, at least feed my cat.”

“I’ll feed him after I feed you, now eat.”

She loved her so much it made her sick, and Catra just stared at her for a while before she ate that whole plate. Neither of them said a thing when Adora refilled it, and she finished that too.

Chapter End Notes

Aura, honey , we love you.

Elora's parents really tried, sometimes it just takes a while):

Adora, bless you for being a stubborn jerk.

Medical stuff!
left parietal - left side of the middle top of the skull
epidural hematoma - (via UCLA Health) occurs when blood accumulates between the skull and the dura mater, the thick membrane covering the brain
lateral of the lambdoid suture - away from the lower middle of the skull

Thank you again for being here!

Chapter 14

Chapter Notes

> I decided to break up the final chapter so now it's 15 instead of 14 chapters.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A foot kicked her hand away as Adora reached for her duffle again. "Hey"–

"Stop checking your bag, you either have what you need or you don't." Catra didn't even look up from her book as she pushed the bag further under her chair. "Also it hasn't changed since the last eight times you checked."

"I'm just trying to be prepared." Adora tried, sitting back with a huff. "Did you remember your"–

"I remembered everything," she said easily, flipping a page, "I always do. Now relax or you're going to pop a vein."

"Sorry," she muttered, "I don't really like flying."

Catra finally looked up. "Adora, you wanted to be an astronaut when we were younger."

"That was before I felt turbulence."

"You were fine when we flew to Snows for our match ceremony?"

"I was also incredibly drunk." *And you talked to me the whole time.*

Catra made a fair point' face and crossed her legs, she was about to say something when the intercom popped to life.

“Now boarding first-class for flight 872 to Mystacor. Business and business-select passengers may begin lining up now.”

“Ready?”

“As I’ll ever be.”

Adora gave her the window seat, stating that it helped her if she couldn’t look down at the 30,000 feet between them and the ground, but it was mainly so Catra would get to see the views as they landed. She hadn’t flown much since moving to Bright Moon, but Adora had been dragged along with Glimmer and Bow to a lot of their vacations, and Mystacor had the most interesting runway she had ever seen. The city was up in the mountains, so you would have to fly up above the clouds surrounding it before landing on the edge of a cliff. It had been horrifying the two times she had seen it, but she knew Catra would love the rush of it, she had always been the more daring of the two of them.

As she gripped the armrests during the steep incline out of the small mountain ranges surrounding Bright Moon, Adora was grateful that the chief had sprung for business class, as it meant that they had room and didn’t have to squeeze next to someone they didn’t know. Catra curled her legs up in the seat and watched out the window as they climbed higher, and Adora watched her.

In the two days since she collapsed at the nurses station, Catra had regained some color in her cheeks, and it looked as though she took the time to part her hair properly after a shower. Adora had even seen her smile once, however small, when Melog did something cute. She knew it wasn’t much, but it was something, and she cursed herself for not having tried sooner to get her to take better care of herself. Adora knew better than anyone that sometimes Catra needed to be forced out of her bad spots, and the last few weeks had been the worst she’s ever seen.

Patience had never really been her strong suit, it had never been either of theirs, and that quality in them led to many heated and

unnecessary arguments, but Adora would do anything to help Catra. Having her hero complex' thrown in her face again had hurt, she thought they had worked through that once before, but Catra was not exactly nice when her entire world was falling to pieces. Losing her favorite patient only exacerbated that fact, and Adora was more concerned about what dark recesses of her head Catra was losing herself in. She watched her, had kept an eye out whenever they worked together and made sure that everyone else watched her too, just in case the lack of self-care caught up to her. None of it was easy, but Adora knew how Catra's mind worked, and she wished she could make the woman understand just how much she meant to her.

She wished she knew that Adora would realign the planets for her.

But instead, she was patient with her.

She knew there were things she couldn't push, and Adora couldn't push the healing of a broken heart; a heart that wasn't just broken by losing a patient, but by a life that just seemed to want to smack her down over and over. Things were getting better, especially with Catra's success at Bright Moon over the last year, but the balance of wins and losses was a curvy, bumpy road. Losing Elora had been a pothole that popped their tire, and neither of them knew how to fix it.

But there was no guidebook to life, or dealing with a traumatic loss, so she was taking things day by day, hour by hour. There certainly was no guidebook to Catra, but as she looked away from the window and caught Adora staring, the edge of her lip raising slightly, she figured books were distracting anyway.

The intercom dinged, breaking them from whatever nice little moment they were having. *'Good afternoon, I apologize for the interruption, but if there are any medical personnel on board, can you please push your call light button. Thank you.'*

They shared another look and Catra sighed before reaching up and pushing the button. A flight attendant rushed over, making them both on alert.

"Hello, one of you has medical experience?" His nametag read *'Leech,'* and his body language read *'not paid enough for this.'*

"We're surgeons," Adora said. "What's wrong?"

"Wonderful. There is a woman who might be in labor."

"What do you mean *'might be?'"* Catra asked incredulously, already unbuckling her lap belt.

"Well, she seems to in a lot of pain, and there is a lot of fluid"–

"From *where?"* Catra asked with an even more irritated tone.

"From her uhh"–

"Oh for fucks sake." Catra said and they both stood up.

Leech beckoned them to follow him back towards the economy section, and Adora tried to ignore everyone craning their necks to see what was going on. He gestured to a small woman with a clearly pregnant stomach sitting by herself in her row, her lap soaked and eyes full of terror. "This is Swen."

Catra squatted down close to her. "Swen, my name is Catra, this is Adora," she threw a thumb over her shoulder, "we're doctors. What are you feeling?"

"I'm scared!"

"It's okay to be scared, but we are here to help you. Do you know how many weeks along you are?"

"Around 35 I think." Swen said and bent over with a hiss as a contraction hit.

Catra timed the contraction on her watch and nodded to herself through it.

"Do you think she's in labor?" Leech whispered to Adora.

She turned her back to Catra and Swen. "We'll need to track her contractions and check her cervix, but that's a lot of fluid. What sort of equipment is in the plane's emergency kit? We need gloves and some towels or blankets." He nodded and walked off quickly, placating people as he hurried down the aisle.

Catra stood back up and looked around. "We're going to have to check her, but there isn't a ton of privacy here."

"Leech went to get gloves and towels," Adora said. "I can hold a blanket over you while you check? Or did you want me to check?"

"No, I know you were never great with OB."

She opened her mouth but snapped it shut, at a momentary loss for words. "Right—"

"I didn't know what to bring, so I got the whole first-aid kit and as many blankets as I could carry." The plane jostled slightly, and Adora was reminded that they were 30,000 feet in the air, in a metal tube, trying to see if a patient was in labor. Why could her life never be normal?

But then Catra was trying to soothe Swen through another contraction, and she knew that a normal life would be boring as fuck.

"Adora, I need you to get me hand sanitizer and gloves, then I need you to hold a blanket over us while I help Swen out of her pants."

She did as she was told and tried to hold the blanket as best as she could, glaring at other passengers that kept trying to see what was going on. She understood curiosity, but come on…

Catra pulled off her gloves and Adora knew immediately that this was not going to be a regular flight. Blue and yellow looked right past her to Leech. "We need to land this plane right now."

"But—but we aren't near anything."

"Where are we?"

"Over the Crimson Desert," he answered solemnly. "We're probably just under two hours from Crimson City." They were three hours from Mystacor, and two and a half from Bright Moon. Crimson would have to do.

"Then land there," Catra said flatly and pulled Adora towards the stewards cabin. "She's 8cm dilated and her contractions are three minutes apart right now, this baby is coming soon."

"Alright, what do we do?"

Catra clasped her fingers behind her head and paced for a moment. "It's not the safest, but I think we can set up a spot here on the floor," she said and measured out the size with her hands. "That gives her privacy and us room to work, but there's no way that the aid kit has anything we need if—if something goes wrong." At 35 weeks, the odds weren't exactly in their favor. "Who the fuck gets on a plane at this stage of pregnancy?" She muttered to herself more than anything.

Adora placed her hand on Catra's bicep. "Hey, nothing is going to go wrong. People have been giving birth without medical aid for millenia." Catra squinted at her for a second, but they both snapped their necks toward the yelp in the cabin. "Shit, okay. Do you want to set up in here and I'll help her over?"

"Who is setting up where?" Another flight attendant with a glittery ascot asked shrilly. Was that how people saw Glimmer?

"That woman is close to having a baby, we need to get her to an open space and away from people."

Storm, so their name tag said, looked aghast. "A—a baby? Now?"

"Oh, I'm sorry," Catra said, "did I say baby? I meant a Christmas Tree is about to pop out of a passenger's vagina. Do you happen to have any ornaments handy?"

"Well—"

"Don't you have emergency protocols for situations like this?" Adora could tell Catra was starting to lose her patience.

"Our protocol is not to allow people who are ready to give birth on our flight, it is a safety hazard for all."

"Fun fact," Catra said and started to lay down blankets, "babies can come earlier than people anticipate. Now could you be a doll and get me some pillows from first class?"

"I'll go get Swen," Adora offered, not wanting to be in the line of fire from Catra's spiky attitude. It would be funny if they weren't in an incredibly precarious situation. Of everyone she knew, Catra had always taken emergent situations the most seriously, and a birth was incredibly serious. New and young lives had always been an interesting spot for her, and Adora felt a rush of nerves at what could potentially happen so soon after Elora…

No, that wouldn't happen. They had this taken care of.

She half-carried Swen down the aisle, purposely throwing her hip into someone's head as they stared too much, and winced when the woman let out a tense grunt.

"I don't think I can do this," Swen said as she and Catra helped her down slowly. "I can't do this."

Catra pushed back some of her hair before dousing her hands with hand sanitizer. "Yes, you can. Adora and I are the best resident doctors in Bright Moon, we are going to get you through this." She gestured to the box of gloves and Adora helped her slip them on, just waiting for instructions at that point. Catra was in charge. "Look at

me, Swen," she waited for the woman to look, "labor is different for everyone, okay? Nature will take over and I will help you through this, but you have to trust your body and what you need. Maybe the baby won't come out until we land, or they can be here in twenty minutes. I just need you to trust me, alright? And squeeze Adora's hand really, really hard if you need to."

They didn't look at each other, but Adora knew that small smile was for her. They were going to be okay. She rifled through the medical kit. "Okay so the aid kit has a BP cuff, some clamps and a blade we can use for the cord, a saline drip, bunch of useless meds" she tutted, "oh look, LifeSavers!"

"Are you suddenly diabetic?"

"No? They're just good"…

"Adora, take her damn blood pressure." She was sure she heard Catra mumble *'idiot'* and it made her smile.

She tried to take her blood pressure, but Swen groaned and hunched over, pulling Adora closer as she rode through the contraction. "I don't want to do this"–

Adora stretched out her hand once the woman released it and she grimaced. "That baby isn't really giving any of us a choice at this point, I'm afraid." Which made Swen let out a sob and Catra glared at her. *'What?!'* she mouthed, and Catra just rolled her eyes.

"Swen I'm going to check how dilated you are again, alright?" She lifted the blanket up and put it back down quickly. "Through these next contractions, I want you to focus on your breathing, alright? The baby has started to crown."

"Oh god"–

"Adora, help her through some breathing techniques, don't let her push yet."

She leaned in close to Catra. "What sort of techniques?" she whispered.

"Just have her take deep breaths." Catra hissed back. "Come on, you're not new at this."

"OB was never my strong suit!"

"You two make a cute couple," Storm said from the edge of the cabin, making both their heads snap up towards them.

"We're not—" she tried, but Swen cried out and Adora tried to get her to mimic deep, steady breathing.

"Hey, Cloud," Catra said without looking up, "we're going to need more blankets."

"It's Storm, actually."

"Swen, do you know the sex?" Catra completely ignored Storm, who stood awkwardly for a second before leaving. "Were you waiting until they were born maybe, or letting them decide later on in life?"

The woman huffed and squeezed her eyes shut. "I don't wa—ahh!"

"Alright, just breathe for me," Catra soothed, her arms moving below the blanket where Adora couldn't see. "Adora, I need you to pull her leg back for me, can you do that?" She did as she was told while Catra put Swen's other leg on her knee. "Now, I want you to try and push through this next contraction, don't push with your stomach muscles, push lower than that."

"I can't do this, please don't make me do this—"

The plane shook again, but Adora had forgotten for a moment their little predicament. She was terrified, the look in Swen's eyes made her even more terrified, and it just nailed the fact in that OB was her toughest, longest rotation in med school, and how she never wanted to do something like that again.

Except for when she and Catra wanted kids, but this wasn't the right time…

The blanket fell down as Catra pushed her leg back further, and it took her breath away how much baby there was already. A baby, 30,000 feet above the ground. She might pass out.

"It's almost over, you're so close, just bear down for me right now"– the head came out completely, she could see the cord wrapped around the baby's neck, and Catra slid her finger under it. "Alright, give me another big push with this."Swen grunted and pushed as Catra tilted the baby down and then pulled them out, quickly unwrapping the cord. The seconds dragged and felt like eons as Catra rubbed the newborn's back, wiping them down with a fresh blanket, and then an angry wail rang through the plane.

"There we go,"Catra said with a true, earth shattering smile, the whole plane erupting with applause, and went to place the babe on their mom. "Here, mom, that was amaz–"

"Get it away from me!"Swen flinched away , swaying slightly with her motions and Adora had to catch her before she slid down the makeshift bed.

The already tense little stewards cabin went stale. "What did you just say?"

"Catra"–

"I can't–I don't want it–them"–Swen choked out, her eyes slammed shut. "Get it away from me–please, I can't–I don't want to be a mom. I can't–please"–

"What do you mean *'it?'"* Instinctively, Catra held the baby closer. "This is a child, you can't just"–

"Catra,"Adora said softly , putting a hand on her arm to stop her, "stop. We need to clamp the cord."She watched her breathing

qicken, her eyes were darting everywhere, swimming in fury , and Adora pushed her back a little. "W e need to get the cord cut, Catra, sit back and Ill take care of it."

"Shes-she"…

Adora lowered her voice to hardly a whisper. "She just gave birth, on a plane, without medication or an ounce of comfort. Stop."

Catra didnt look any less angry , but she sat back on her heels and watched Adora clamp and cut the cord, then she draped another blanket over them both. "Go sit down, Ill take care of the rest."It looked as if there would be an argument, so Adora just shook her head. "Go take care of the baby , Catra. Ive got this."

She worked silently as she started the IV, which she should have done earlier but everything happened so fast. Leech brought over a tub for the placenta, since apparently Storm had been scared off, and Adora was thankful that Swen hadnt teared externally . The woman of course would have to be seen by proper medical personnel, but from her examination, all was well. Once the IV had finished, Adora cleaned her up as much as possible and not-so-nicely made them find a spot for her in first class, since it wasnt going to be a comfortable remainder of her flight.

"Im sorry ,"Swen said as Adora set her down slowly . "Y our friend is right to be angry at me, but I never wanted that baby. If I looked at them for one second, there was no way I could give them up, but I wouldnt be a good mother . I couldnt do it. Theyre better of f without me."

"I understand,"she replied, and she did. Some people werent meant to be parents. "Do you want me to sit with you?"

She shook her head and leaned back. "No, Ill be alright. Thank you for being there. I wasntI .didnt think it would happen on the flight. I thought I would have time to go somewhere nice, let them be adopted by a nice, wealthy family, to have a better life than I did."

Adora didn't really have anything to say to that, so she patted her shoulder. "For what it's worth, I think you did the right thing. Your heart was in the right place."

She walked across and back down the aisle towards Catra, feeling uncomfortable at the praise she was getting from people. Adora hadn't really done anything, it shouldn't be her getting the recognition, she almost passed out.

Catra was busy trying to fit the adult-sized cannula on the small baby, and she chuckled to herself before sliding into the seat. "They don't have a smaller size?"

"No," she grumbled. "Can you go get the kit? I need to check her heart and breathing."

"Her?"

She nodded, "yeah. All her limbs and facilities seem alright, even if she is little, but I need that stethoscope in the kit, Adora."

"Right," she said quickly and got back up. From what she could see of the small babe, she looked nice and pink, with a strong set of lungs, which were all pretty good markers of being healthy, but they were so out of their element without a hospital around them. "So they have a peds oxygen mask, which might work a little better." She handed over the kit. "Also a man gave me a baby blanket so we wouldn't have to keep her in the scratchy airline blanket."

"Is it clean?"

Adora shrugged and handed it to Catra. "I don't know , it was folded up in his diaper bag."

"Whatever , this metal tube is already a cesspool for germs anyway." Catra went to take the blanket but Adora pulled it away.

"I think you should probably go get changed first."

"I'm fine."

"You are covered in blood and all sorts of bodily fluids, and you were just talking about germs. Let me hold her and you can go get changed."

"I can hold her!" A lady in front of them chimed in.

"No," they said at the same time. Catra turned her body away from the lady and frowned before looking at Adora. "Help me check her , then Ill get changed."

The stethoscope from the kit was quite a few years older than the one they use now, so Adora struggled getting a good read, especially since it wasn't a neonatal stethoscope, but she managed. Catra also double-checked to make sure she was correct, which was annoying, but there was already something shifting in her demeanor. Once they were both satisfied, and Catra was able to calm the baby down again, she passed her over to Adora who pretended to know what she was doing.

It had been years since she held a baby, and not that she didn't know what to do, but it was overwhelming how small she was, and how much responsibility Adora had by holding her. The baby fit perfectly in her two hands, and she just took in her fresh, soft features. There was only a dollop of wispy, dark hair on top of her head, but her eyebrows were nearly white, so Adora was sure she would turn out blonde. Her skin was so pink, and she still had a lot of vernix on her, but it didn't take away from how squishy , soft, and cute she looked.

She and Catra had talked about having kids, it was something they agreed upon rather early in their relationship. They both wanted one, maybe two or three, and they wanted to give their kids a life they never had. Looking down at the fresh, pure baby in her hands, Adora wondered how anyone could treat a child the way she and Catra had been treated. She wondered how anyone could do anything to their

kid besides love them wholly. Her neck started to tense up, but then a hand was on her shoulder.

"Everything okay?"

"Yeah," Adora said quickly, making room for Catra to crawl past her. "She hasn't made a peep."

In an instant Catra took the baby back. "Raindrop said we'll be landing in about forty minutes."

"Storm—"

"I don't care." She didn't have anything to say back to that, so the both of them just watched the small baby in Catra's lap, sucking in small breaths when she would stretch or twitch. "What's going to happen to her?"

The strained, sad whisper was like a punch to the gut. "She'll have to go get checked out at the hospital, and then from there, more than likely into the system. I talked to Swen for a bit, she doesn't have any family." She paused and rubbed the back of her finger over a fat cheek. "She was going to Mystacor to give her baby a shot at a good life."

"But she's going to be in Crimson," Catra whispered again. "It's not Fright, but it's certainly not Mystacor or Bright Moon either."

"We don't really have a choice in the matter, Catra." For the first time since the baby popped out, they really looked at each other, and Adora's heart sank. "You cannot adopt her, Catra. You aren't ready." This wasn't just a cat someone found in an alley.

"I know I can't," she snapped and looked back down, worried she woke her. "That's not what I meant."

"I know you're upset—"

"Stop, Adora. Please. Im fine. Ill just hand her over to random people and shell be fine."

The baby started to cry again and she just watched as Catra tried to console her. She didnt know the first thing about taking care of a newborn, she knew instinct and determination would kick in when the time came for her, but the woman next to her seemed to be a natural at it. Catra leaned back and gently positioned the tiny thing on her chest, patting her little butt gently until she calmed down. Big, purple eyes blinked open a few times, and then closed again as she fell back asleep. Must be nice.

"What if she goes to a family that treats her like Weaver or worse." A protective hand splayed over the entirety of the baby's tiny back. "What if"–

Adora stopped her, "we cant deal in 'what if's,' Catra. We can only hope."

She watched her curl away slightly, the intercom announcing their descent into Crimson City startling her. The closer they came towards the ground, the tighter she could see Catra hold onto the baby. Adora was almost thankful for the turbulence as they flew over red dunes, it gave her something to focus on other than the deepening furrow of Catra's brows.

Nothing was said between them as they landed, and Adora went ahead of Catra to explain the situation to the medical personnel that were waiting on the runway. As per Swen's wishes, she left first in her own ambulance, and the baby would be taken to a different hospital with a neonatal unit.

"Do you want me to hand her over?" she asked Catra, but she just brushed past Adora, and handed the baby over to a paramedic without a word.

Catra was silent as she went back to the plane to grab their things, silent as they switched to a new plane with everyone, silent on the

short flight up to Mystacor , and silent as they were driven to the hotel.

But Catra didn't need to speak for Adora to know that she was stewing about something, her back was tense and hands kept flexing in the way they did when she was mad. It was almost nice to see her angry, it was better than the unfeeling shell of a human she had been for a while. Adora was nervous, Catra had always been a mixed bag when it came to how she expressed her anger, and she didn't have excellent control over her emotions as of late, but whatever was about to happen, Adora wasn't going to let her go through it alone.

Their rooms were right next to each other, but Catra wasn't trying to push her away, or shut her out, so Adora followed right behind her. She dropped her duffle and watched as Catra rolled her suitcase to the side of the bed and started to unpack, but she wasn't doing it at all in the planned and perfect way that she usually did.

Adora walked over and stopped her hands. "Hey ," she said, "talk to me."

"Why do people have kids if they don't want them, Adora?"

"I don't know ," she said after a moment, "I've never really—"

"Why go through all of that work of being pregnant and giving birth just to throw the kid away?"

"Catra, we don't know Swen's story, she might not have had a choice…"

Catra walked away and began to pace in front of the window, not entirely listening to Adora. "I don't get it," she mumbled, "I don't get why someone can just create a life and not care what happens. That they just give up when things get hard, and give their kid to someone they don't know. Why…"

Oh. Adora might have been very, very ignorant. Sure she had been curious about her birth parents when she was younger, but that was always just images in her head. Adora, like Swen's baby, had been given up at birth, she didn't know any other parent besides Weaver, but Catra? Catra was almost five when her parents abandoned her. Catra remembered her family, she remembered them leaving. She had slept by the front window for weeks after they drove off, waiting for them to come back.

"Catra," she said, taking a step forward, but Catra threw her hands in the air.

"Why have a kid if you aren't going to love them unconditionally? Why? Why are humans like this? I just don't understand any of it, I don't understand anything."

"Because there are a lot of stupid people in the world, but there is more good than bad, you know that."

She finally looked up at Adora. "Do I? Because I have had a shitty life, Adora. My parents left me, Weaver hated me, I've had to fight for everything I've wanted," she grabbed tufts of her hair, voice rising. "Even when I fight it's not enough, I still get people killed, people that would have lived a better life than me. They deserve it more than me."

Adora's stomach churned. "Don't say that, you're worth—"

"Nothing matters!" She yelled, hands flying from her hair. "Nothing matters, Adora. No one cares, and nothing matters, and everyone who matters to me leaves me." Catra deflated, looking utterly depleated.

A knife through the heart would have been less painful, she was sure of it. "I left you," Adora whispered. "I left you."

Tears fell from Catra's eyes. "What's wrong with me?

"Nothing," she choked, stepping closer, "there's nothing wrong with you, Catra. None of it was because of you." Adora was done holding back, so she grabbed her wrist to pull her in, and Catra melted into her with a sob. "People are fucked up and do bad things, but that's not your fault. None of it was your fault." She held Catra tighter as she cried, taking a steadying breath. "I left because I couldn't take Horde anymore, I was suffocating. I knew we were better than that, I wanted more—it wasn't because I didn't want you."

"I know," Catra sniffed. "I understand that, but you did it without me. We did everything together."

"That's why I had to do it," she said with a sigh. "I spent so much of my life trying to help you, to make sure you were happy, that I had forgotten about myself. I couldn't stay, but it killed me to go." Adora pulled away and cupped Catra's cheeks. "I missed you every single day, it was torture. I wanted you to come with me so badly, to get away from that place and start a life we deserve." Her bottom lip quivered and Adora's chest nearly cracked.

"I want to understand," her face fell into Adora's shoulder. "I know why you did it, Adora. I don't blame you—I'm just so mad. At everything." Hands gripped at her jacket. "I hurt so much. I should have gone with you, but I was so mad and hurt that you did it on your own." She sank even further into their embrace and Adora held her close. "I—I tried to do it on my own too, to prove I could do it without you. I can, but—but I should have gone with you."

"I'm so sorry, Catra," she said and pulled them apart, needing to see her. "I'm so sorry that I made you feel like I did something behind your back, I thought I was doing the right thing. I wanted to make our lives better, all I've ever wanted was for you to be happy." Adora took a steadying breath. "I still want you, Catra. I still want you to take my hand and start a life we deserve, and I always have."

She wiped away a tear that fell and Catra closed her eyes. "That's just your hero complex talking, we both know I don't matter."

"You matter to me," Adora said softly. She brushed a thumb over her cheek, leaned forward, and placed a kiss on Catra's forehead. "I love you, Catra." Eyes snapped open and blinked a few times. "I am so in love with you, that has never changed. I love you on *purpose,* not because I feel obligated to. It's only ever been you, and I'll do whatever I need to prove it to you."

Hands pulled where they were fisted in her shirt. "You...you love me?"

"Of course I do."

Catra shook her head slightly, the corner of her mouth lifting. "You're such an idiot."

"Yeah, I am," she said with a smile. Adora wouldn't have stopped the words that followed even if she could. "Marry me."

"...What?"

She stepped back and grabbed both of Catra's hands. "Fucking marry me. Marry me and we'll have a million kids and give them the life we never had, Catra. We'll never leave them and we won't leave each other because we're better than that and you are all I want, so marry me."

Adora was worried she had pushed too far, because Catra practically crumpled in her arms with a sob, but she was squeezing for dear life, so it had to be okay at least. She held her tight, which earned more sobs, and she figured this was finally Catra's chance to really, truly cry for all the shit in her life that had gone wrong.

She soothed her as best as she could, but there was nothing else Adora could do besides slowly lead them to the bed and get them cuddled under the blankets. She wiped away tears when she could, and whispered all the things she loved about Catra in her ear as the late afternoon turned dark.

Once the majority of her sobs subsided, they spent the night talking—finally talking. About exactly how Adora had met the chief and Glimmer, why she felt the need to keep the process a secret, how lost she was for the first bit after she moved. Catra kept her eyes closed and spilled her truths too, her regrets of staying in Fright, how she tried to work on herself once the initial anger washed away into sadness. It was fucked up, and raw, and almost funny with how stupid it was, but that was them. They had never done anything the way people expected, so what would have made this situation any different?

By the time they finally cleaned up and relaxed for bed, Adora's hands brushing through Catra's short hair, she wished she hadn't waited as long as they had, but there was nothing either of them could do but accept the past and move forward with their future.

—

The brightness of the sunrise woke her up the next morning and Adora cursed herself for not remembering to close the blackout curtains. She was surprised at how well rested she felt though, especially sleeping in a foreign bed, but then felt the body next to her shift slightly.

She cracked an eye open and smiled. "You're up early."

"We forgot to close the curtains."

Adora just hummed and stretched before lifting up onto her elbow. Catra looked more at ease than she had in a long time, and while she knew they still had so much work to do in their relationship, her body flushed with contentment. She loved her.

She loved her crinkly, groggy morning eyes and wild hair. Even now that she kept it short, her bed head was so cute. Her little sleepy morning scowl was ever present, and all Adora wanted to do was kiss it away.

“Marry me.”

Catra laughed and rolled out of bed to close the curtains. “Don’t you think that’s a little hasty?”

“No,” Adora said plainly. “It doesn’t have to be now, or next week, but I’ve wanted this for years and I’m tired of waiting. It’s going to happen anyway, we might as well do it.”

“I don’t know,” Catra said with a smile, “I think you’re going to have to convince me better than that.”

She got out of bed and pushed away the half eaten room service cart. “Marry me.”

“You said that one already.”

Adora slipped an arm around her waist and brought her in close. “Marry me.”

“Ehhh—”

“Marry me,” she said again, smiling as she tilted Catra’s chin up with her finger.

“You’re sounding a little desperate, Adora.”

She whispered it one more time on Catra’s lips, her whole body flushing with goosebumps when those mismatched eyes closed, and whatever answer she had was blocked by a slow, gentle kiss. It was achingly soft, and arms wrapped around her stomach to bring them closer together. She could live in that moment forever, she was sure of it.

Eventually they broke apart, and Adora kissed her warm cheek.

“Will you marry me, Catra?”

“Yeah, I guess.”

She kissed her. "Brat."

Catra kissed her back. "Yeah but you love me."

"I really, really do."

Chapter End Notes

In the immortal words of Idz, it's about damn time! These bitches really went 74,058 words before finally talking. Yes, Google counted that for me.

Anyway, please don't give birth on a plane, it really doesn't sound like a good time.

I also had so much fun writing those flight attendants.

I don't think there was much medical stuff besides OB, which means Obstetrics, which deals with childbirth. the birth itself was not entirely like that, and I can assure you is farrrrrr messier than you can imagine. I tried to keep that modest, but I've seen it live twice, and it's amazing but also terrifying.

Only one chapter left and I hope you all had fun reading this! Thank you so much for being here with me <3

Chapter 15

Chapter Notes

My least favorite part, the end.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was the first warm morning they had in months, and Catra let the sun warm her face as she walked over soggy grass.

She laid down the blanket Adora had made her bring, silently thankful that her wife was always careful about weather conditions, and sat down in front of the headstone. Adora had offered to come with her, but she needed to do this on her own. Catra busied herself with placing the flowers down and getting out the baggie filled with two bowls of ice cream, which she wasn't sure she'd be able to eat, but it was the thought that counted. One deep breath, and then she looked up.

Fora Vio Woods

3 Years and 2 Days

A Most Beloved Daughter and Friend

Even though she had been prepared for it, and knew she was ready, reading those words still made her chest ache. Catra knew the grief she felt was the love and memories everlasting, no matter how painful it was, so she wiped at her eye with a small smile.

"Hi, El," Catra said with a cough to clear her throat. "I want to start off by apologizing for not coming sooner, but I don't really have a reason other than my general issues as a person. You only got to see a certain side of me that I allowed, and I know I slipped up a lot and treated our relationship as more than just patient and doctor, but there was still so much about me that you didn't know. I've struggled

to come visit—mainly—because I'm mad that I never got to tell you things in person, and frankly I...was mad at you.

"You didn't do anything wrong, my anger was misplaced due to my own baggage, and it's taken a lot of therapy to help me cope and redirect. I was mad because I felt I—felt like you didn't try hard enough to fight, and that you left the world so suddenly when I knew you had so much potential. I was mad because there were so many points in my life where I wanted the option to give up, but I had to fight through them, and I wanted you to be like me. I was only thinking of me when I should have been thinking about how much you had on your shoulders, and I am so, so sorry for treating you that way, Elora. It's been three years now since you've been gone, and I miss you so much, but sometimes souls aren't ready for the world yet.

"I don't really know my feelings on the afterlife, but wherever you are, I hope that you are at peace now, and I hope you can forgive me."

Catra took a deep breath and tried a bite of her melting ice cream, which earned a churning kick in her stomach. "Sheesh, I get it, you don't like mint." She adjusted her seat and grunted at another kick. "You're just like your mom, such a travesty..." She rubbed the increasingly uncomfortable stomach that sported her unborn child, and smiled at the fact that even if she was uncomfortable, she currently had a built-in table.

"I guess I should probably give you a life update, since I don't know what else to do at a grave site." Catra adjusted again and sighed when the little gremlin finally relaxed. "Adora and I got married two and a half years ago. We both wanted just a nice, normal wedding, but Angella's daughter, Glimmer, refused to do anything but the most elaborate, fancy, exhausting wedding imaginable. I'll never tell her, but it really was incredible, even if it was exhausting. I'm just glad I only have to do it once.

"We bought a house down the street from Glimmer and her husband for some reason, and I'm trying to talk Adora into getting another

kitten so our cat can have a sibling. She says that our baby will be his sibling, which brings in the conversation of more kids, and I dont know if I really want to go through this whole process again. Im already nervous because I know Adora is going to pass out, and Id really like it if my wife didnt get a brain injury when we have a newborn.

"Adora and I toyed with the idea of naming them Elora" if theyre a girl, but we decided against that. You had your own story, and as much as I care about you, my kid should have their own destiny, you know? We've decided to name this one Finn, their middle name is still up for discussion. Were waiting until theyre born to find out the sex, because we couldnt give two shits about their gender , skin color, limb countany of it. W e will love them no matter what.

"And oh fuck, do I love this kid. It is terrifying how much I love them, and I havent even met them. It might be the pregnancy hormones or something, but when Adora talks to them about her day and they start kicking, I just bawl because it physically hurts how much I love them both. I cant wait to give my kid the childhood I never got, that Adora and I never got. It's scary, but it's going to be such a cool adventure."

Catra ate a few more bites of ice cream, much to her baby's irritation, and closed her eyes through a few Braxton Hicks contractions. "Y ou asked me once about how Adora and I fell in love, and I wish I would have told you that I fell in love with her when Adora literally fell out of a tree." She laughed. "W e were nine, and I really wanted this lizard that had run up further than I could reach. I could have climbed, Im better at it than Adora anyway , but she just told me to wait and heaved herself up. She was so excited when she caught it that she let go of the branch and fell. It wasnt that far , so she was okay, but the smile on her face just made me realize that I never wanted to be away from her. I knew the second she handed me that damn lizard and wiped the blood of f her elbow that Id marry her someday.

"It took her a lot longer to realize," Catra said and rubbed her stomach absent mindedly. "We had moved out together for undergrad, and I thought maybe once we were free from the place we grew up that she would finally do something, but Adora is kind of thick-headed sometimes. I always caught her looking, and I wasn't at all subtle with my flirting, but she was just ridiculous. So I went and got a tattoo on my lower back, wore these pants I knew made her brain melt, and that was about it. I won't tell you her side of the whole story, but we really were just ridiculous."

Catra sat there and finally told El about her childhood, about Weaver and all her best times with Adora, even what happened during their time apart. She told her about the therapy they've been going through, how they finally decided on 'Gray' as their last name instead of 'Grayskull,' but they still call each other Grayskull at home. She told her about their friends, their adventures, their successes at work and the general fears she faces with life as a whole.

She was doing better than she had been for years, Catra would always have her demons, but then she would roll over in bed and strong arms would hold her tight, and things would be okay.

"I should probably start heading home," Catra said after quite some time. "It's our night to host Game Night, and Adora wants to get the crib set up first for some reason. It's been so cute to watch her get excited about all the baby stuff, and she stays up so late reading safety reviews, but I love that idiot so much. Anyway, kiddo, I want to just thank you, for allowing me to be a part of your life for that short bit and to help you. I hope you know that you helped me a lot too, and you're always on my mind. I promise I'll try and get over here more often, but if not here, just know you're with me always."

Climbing into the car was difficult at this stage, and she whispered *'only a few more weeks,'* to herself before tapping the bracelet that had hung from her rear-view mirror for three years. She could feel the weight lift off her chest as she drove home, pretending that the warm feeling was El saying hi from wherever she was.

There were large boxes blocking her spot in the garage when Catra got home, and the house smelled like fresh paint.

"Adora?"

"I'm in Finn's room!"

She found her wife on the floor of their baby's seemingly entirely furnished new room. Catra snorted, knowing full well it had been full of boxes of furniture waiting to be built when she left hours ago.

"Looks like you've been busy," Catra said and Adora smiled up at her.

"Hi," she said and hopped off the floor. "I realized once I started I might as well just keep going, so I put together the dresser and rocking chair too. But then I realized that I didn't have the right drill bit to use for one of the parts so I ran to the hardware store to grab it, but they had a really good sale on paint so I picked up some of that and painted the accent wall before you got back." She threw a thumb over her shoulder to the green wall behind her. "Do you like it?"

"It's nice," Catra said and leaned in for a quick kiss. "What are the boxes blocking my way in the garage?"

"Oh! It's a playset for the backyard, it was on sale too so I figured I would grab it now and we can keep it up on the loft until Finn is old enough." Adora took her hand and led her from the room. "Let's go to the kitchen, it's not great for you to be around fresh paint."

She had to appreciate that, the smell was starting to give her a headache. "You know that Finn won't be able to play on that thing for two or three years, right? And none of our friends have kids yet."

"Well, no," Adora poured her a glass of orange juice, her current favorite, and leaned against the counter. "But Glimmer is only a few weeks behind you, and Perfuma and Scorpia just got married, so

maybe theyll have a kid eventually too. I was just thinking of the future, you know? I got excited."

Catra downed the last of her drink and pulled Adora in closer, as close as they could get. "I know you were, and I love it." She kissed her cheek. "I love you."

"I love you too," Adora said with a small sigh. "I'm not being too ridiculous, am I?"

"Not at all."

It was so hard to find words adequate enough to explain how much she loved Adora, and watching her get excited to become a parent had made everything so much better. To listen to her wife talk about their future, to plan for their family, nearly made Catra's heart burst at times she loved her so much. Nothing was perfect, of course, especially with pregnancy hormones, but they had worked so hard to be where they were now, and she wouldn't have it any other way.

Adora's joy was her joy. Adora *was* her joy.

And yeah life beyond their marriage was fun too, they were living the life they'd always dreamed at work, their friends were amazing, and life was just good. Sometimes Catra would lay awake at night, watching the patterned breathing of Adora's chest while she slept, and wonder how they had ever gotten to where they were after going through the things they had. So much struggle and strife, but somehow they wound up stronger than ever.

But that was it, wasn't it? They were a team, just the two of them, and a team has to work together through all of the bad to get a taste of the good. She and Adora had experience with the bad in abundance, and it made its way through every now and then, but they worked together to beat it. They were a team, and they were in love, and she wouldn't change a damn thing. Sure, the pain of what they went through sucked, but would they be the same people if life hadn't happened the way it did?

Catra didn't know, and she didn't want to find out, because nothing else in the world mattered besides her wife, who was currently wrapping her arms around her from behind and lifting up her stomach to release some of the weight from her belly.

"Oh god, yes," Catra said and sank into Adora's embrace. Since she was about 32 weeks along, when her stomach really decided to pop out, their daily routine had always found itself back to Adora holding up the weight off of her so she could get a break. It was also the only way they could get close anyway, since hugs from the front were all awkward angles and such.

Adora hummed and they swayed silently for a bit. "How did it go today?"

"It went okay." She had been waiting for the question. "I had the whole speech planned out, as you know, so that was fine. But I have never really talked at someone's grave so it was... interesting."

She felt a kiss against the top of her head. "How do you feel?"

"Good," she said and closed her eyes, letting the pressure and comfort of Adora soothe her. "I feel really good. I hurt, because I miss her still, but it felt good to go and get it all off of my chest. I think seeing her headstone sort of finalized it in my head in a way? I think it was the closure I needed, and it kind of sucks it took me so long to go."

"You did it on your own time, and that's okay, Catra. You've always been someone who can't be pushed to do something you're not ready for. El would understand."

She hummed and wrapped her hands over Adora's. "You're right, I just..." she didn't really have words to explain it, but Adora kissed her head again, and Catra figured she understood. She always did.

"Can I come with you next time?"

Catra groaned at the added weight to her lower back when she unlocked Adora's arms and turned around. "You want to go? Why?"

"Why wouldn't I?" Adora asked. "Elora was a good kid, I liked her, and she was important to you. It's the right thing to do." She smiled that dumb, jocky smile. "And I want to tell her that her 'G' theory was right all along."

"Hey, I told her about it!"

"Okay, okay," she said with a laugh and put her hand on Catra's stomach. "I just want to be there for you in any way I can."

"I'd appreciate that, really. I'd love it if you came with me next time." Before Catra could lean in for a kiss, she felt an odd gush between her legs. It took her a second to realize what it was, and then her heart started to race. "You can also support me by getting me to a hospital"…

Adora looked utterly confused, which made her almost laugh. "Hospital? Why?" Catra just pointed down, and was ready for Adora to faint. Thankfully she didn't, but the panic in her eyes was palpable. "Oh—oh god..oh my god! What do we do? Now? What do we—are you okay? Right now? Oh god"—

"Adora, look at me," she grabbed her cheeks and forced Adora to look at her. "Relax, it's going to be fine. Get the hospital bag in Finn's room and I'll get to the car."

"But you're not due for two weeks wha—how"—

She kissed her, and again to try and wipe the panic off her face, and smiled. "Babies can come at any time, Adora. Now can you go get the bag, please?"

"I think I'm going to pass out."

"Oh for fuck sake, Adora, look at me." Blue eyes blinked at her a few times. "We are going to get to the hospital, and everything is going to be alright, do you hear me? You are a surgeon, you've dealt with worse things."

"Okay, okay, it's going to be okay. Let's go."

She waited for Adora by the front door, who had walked down the hall in a daze to get the hospital bag, and stopped her before they went to the car. "Hey, Adora? I love you so much. It's going to be okay, we're going to be okay."

"I love you too, but you might need to drive."

"You're such an idiot."

Chapter End Notes

And that is how Adora passed out the second Finn was plopped on Catra's chest, and Glimmer was the one who cut their umbilical cord.

But this is the end, y'all, and I hate having to come to an end because I just love these stories I get myself into. I am so thankful for anyone who stayed through to the end, and I truly hope you enjoyed this story. I had such a time writing it, both fun and heart wrenching, but it's my baby and I just...thank you. Thank you for being here.

Also I need to give a big shout out again to my wonderful friend @BlueEyesAndHair. They helped me tons with ideas and checking my horrendous initial grammar. They're lovely (most of the time). Love you, Mon!

Medical stuff!
Braxton Hicks are little practice contractions that happen during

pregnancy, sometimes mistaken for real contractions, sometimes ignored. Catra would 100% be the person to ignore real contractions and think they're Braxton Hicks.

Anyway, thank you again!I hope you're all well and I wish you all the best. Cheers!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!